

HOANG-THAM, PIRATE

BY PAUL CHACK

Translated from the French

1933 / 2026

Hoang-Tham, pirate was first published in Paris by Les Éditions de France in 1933.

This English translation was produced in 2026.

CONTENTS

PART ONE

BA-PHUC, OR THE ADOPTIVE FATHER

- I — Yen Thế
- II — Piracy, Limited Company
- III — Đề Đốc Tham, and a Few Others
- IV — Columns
- V — Cleanings
- VI — The Band
- VII — A Chinaman
- VIII — Ba-Phuc
- IX — On the Bed of Gou Wood... and Underneath
- X — The Bomb
- XI — The Attack on the Fort of Hữu Thuế

PART TWO

CAPTURE AND SUBMISSION

- I — THAM IS ALIVE
- II — THE RAILWAY IN 1894
- III — TWO FRENCHMEN CAPTURED
- IV — THE ATTACK ON THE TRAIN
- V — AT LẠNG-THƯƠNG
- VI — NEGOTIATIONS

PART THREE

ĐỀ THÁM SUBMITTED

- I — Đề Thám Submitted

- II — Repression
- III — Pursuits
- IV — The Child of the Miracle
- V — Submission... Yet Again
- VI — The Great Lays
- VII — In Pacified Yen Thế...
- VIII — At Phong Xuong

PART FOUR

PAR LE FER ET PAR LE POISON

- I — THE BAD SEED GERMINATES
- II — AUDIENCES
- III — THE ORDERS
- IV — THE SORCERER OF THE RUE DES VOILES
- V — THE DEATH OF THE THONG-THUONG
- VI — DIVISION OF LABOUR
- VII — HANOI, 27 JULY 1908
- VIII — FRENCH JUSTICE

PART FIVE

LE ĐỀ THÁM TRAQUÉ (1909-1910)

- I — UNEASE
- II — THE FACE LOST... AND REGAINED
- III — WITH THE PIRATE BAND
- IV — THE HUNT RESUMES
- V — THE BOAR IN FLIGHT
- VI — AT XUAN-LAI
- VII — LAST COMBATS

PART SIX

THE DEATH OF ĐỀ THÁM

I — TREMORS AND PARLEYS

II — AT THE HOUSE OF LUONG-TAM-KY

III — THREE CHINESE REFORMISTS

IV — THE DEATH

V — THE HEAD AND THE BODY

HOANG-THAM, PIRATE

by Paul Chack (1933)

Translated from the French

=====

HOANG-THAM, PIRATE

PART ONE
BA-PHUC, OR THE
ADOPTIVE FATHER

I — YEN THẾ

This carries us back to the first years after the conquest of Tonkin. Only the flat delta — that desolate, muddy horizontal, its vistas open, its roads commodious, its villages numerous — has bent, since the summer of 1889 and save for passing convulsions, to the French rule. Throughout the rest of Tonkin, piracy prolongs the war. Chinese piracy along the entire frontier zone of Quảng Đông and Quảng Tây, country of a hundred thousand mountains. Chinese piracy still in the massifs of the north and east, a labyrinth as yet ill-known, bristling with fearful forests, a chaos of entangled races: Mán, Thái, Thổ, Mèo, Lô Lô, and I know not what else. Sino-Annamite piracy in the middle region,

the transition zone between the heaped granites and limestones of upper Tonkin and the ocean of rice that is the delta.

The canton of Yen Thế is a parcel of this middle region. In the memory of the marines and legionaries who served between 1886 and 1912, in the recollection of the sailors who navigated the river gunboats in the era of the great piracy, Yen Thế evokes names — comrades buried near the farm of the Pine-Parasols, or in the cemeteries of Bồ Hạ, of Nhả Nam, of Phủ Lạng Thương, of Bắc Ninh.

Yen Thế begins some fifty kilometres northeast of Hanoi. It is wedged between the Cai Kinh massif on one side and, on the other, the upper courses of the Sông Cầu and the Sông Thương. The northern part, Upper Yen Thế, is a labyrinth of hills a hundred to a hundred and fifty metres high; farther south, Lower Yen Thế — with its many rice-fields and cheerful villages — is a plain from which rise, dressed in tall grasses and clumps of trees, hillocks of twenty to fifty metres, by which the landscape escapes the despairing monotony of the lower Tonkin, that flat country which the silt of the great rivers has engendered, patiently pushing back the sea.

A vegetation gone wild covers the hills of Upper Yen Thế. Gigantic trees, shrubs, lianas, and giant grasses, tangled like the hair of the sick, have swarmed in the humus accumulated over millennia. Patient and cruel, stronger than water and fire, defying the breath of typhoons with enormous roots and interwoven branches, the forest has devoured the ancient roads and the villages

of old. One travels by compass, cutlass ever at work. The green haze of dense leaves blocks every view. Only the fact that one ceases to climb and begins to descend betrays the presence of ridges. The valleys, drowned in mist and heavy with silence, are nothing but marshlands treacherously masked. The arroyos run soundlessly in tortuous tunnels vaulted with interlaced branches. Eight months of the year, the soil, the trees, the grasses are saturated with dampness.

In this vegetal hell, the fog, the stagnant pools, the sweating earth distil the mortal fevers that myriads of mosquitoes carry. One walks upon a warm rot in which writhe serpents, leeches, worms, centipedes, ants, and numberless fireflies. One cuts a path through thickets where harbour tigers, leopards, lynxes, tiger-cats, foxes of so deep a red, civets, and martens; where the enormous black ox with the grey head — the terrible solitary gaur, his hide stitched with claw-scars, for he charges the great carnivores who dread his attack — sleeps in the shelter of the impenetrable bamboo brakes.

There lives, in perpetual terror, the con nai, the great Tonkinese deer whose flesh is succulent and whose new antlers restore to decrepit Chinamen their virility.

Upper Yen Thố is a land of misfortune. For generations, the villagers have lived in horror, in blood, ever ready to betray the weak for the strong, ever ready to pillage whoever guards his goods poorly, ever ready to receive the pirate bands with the requisite humility that masks so well the eternal mistrust of the Annamites. One

must be gentle and polite towards the rough lads who would cut your throat at the first suspicious move. One must be obsequious and smiling before the French — newcomers who, they say, have brought liberty, but whose taxes add to those one must pay the bandits, in coin or in kind, as insurance against pillage. In truth, one finds oneself caught between the pirate's anvil and the hammer of repression. If the shock grows too great, one digs up the rifle — the only friend who never betrays. Then one buys from the Chinese of Lạng Sơn or Phủ Lạng Thương cartridges come from Hong Kong by way of Canton, and that is a third tax added to the other two.

For the pirates of the profession, as for the occasional malefactor, Upper Yên Thế is the ideal lair. The jungle there is rigged. It has covered or inextricably overgrown ruined villages in a region that was once peopled, and that has found its prosperity again only since our patient, tenacious effort has killed the piracy. And so, just as the cleared Cambodian forest revealed the marvels of Angkor, the clearing of Yên Thế and the cutting of roads have brought back to the light the remains of pagodas and the traces of hamlets — wounded by the tiger or the pirate and finished off by the forest. Were the mat of vegetative debris that covers them less thick, the trails would sound hollow when they pass above the dead villages. In their hidden and rotting ruins, the hunted bands find refuge. Through the roots that embrace the collapsed cai-nhas, the pirates dig tunnels of retreat, invisible passages by which

they can, before a stronger assailant, vanish as though swallowed by the forest.

What follows is the story of Yen Thế in the era of the great piracy.

II — PIRACY, LIMITED COMPANY

The nearest town to Yen Thế is Phủ Lạng Thương, a great river-port, reachable in ten hours from Hải Phòng by steam-launch, coming up the Sông Thương, the great river of the delta. Phủ Lạng Thương is a transit centre for the interior, at all times crowded with sampans and pot-bellied junks. They land merchandise there, and also supply-parcels destined for our military posts, strung out along the hundred and ten kilometres of the Mandarin Road, besieged by the devouring bush and running northeastward to the Chinese frontier.

The jungle hides the pirates, and the pirates attack the convoys. Our posts wait in vain for their victuals and their ammunition...

To replace that dangerous road, they began to build, in 1888, a railway — a poor little single-track Decauville line of sixty-centimetre gauge. Three years later, the first section of twenty-five kilometres was opened to traffic. It would take seven years for the trains to reach Lạng Sơn.

The building of the railway was a windfall for the pirates. The army of coolie labourers was, for the bands, a fine reservoir of men. More precious aid still: a cloud of

Chinese middlemen had descended upon Phủ Lạng Thương.

Pot-bellied and chattering, wearing clamped to their ears enormous horn-rimmed spectacles that their crushed and tiny noses could never support, ceaselessly laughing in great bursts only to exchange, over a matter of sapeks, the most horrific and fleeting insults — these Chinese, sellers of all things and honest by definition (for none ignores that a Chinaman's word is worth ten French signatures) — add to their avowed trade certain secret and lucrative lines. Half-caste compradors, shopkeepers who employ six clerks for ten piastres of daily turnover, they are there to point out to malefactors of every origin the fine opportunities for attack. They are the intermediaries between the pirates and the Chinese across the frontier for the traffic in yellow skins. They receive, lastly, the pillaged booty — which often comes from their own warehouses. It is, in sum, organised to perfection: the eternal return of the same goods, an ingenious means of avoiding a deplorable immobilisation of capital. Cases on their way inland are promptly raided and brought back to their point of departure only to be sold again, dispatched, stolen anew, and so on... Only the shipments from Chinaman to Chinaman pass untouched. The pirates recognise them by blue bands sewn on the tarpaulins, or, very simply, by the beam of light that a mirror, held by the coolie at the head of the convoy, flashes in the sun.

The liaison is thus magnificently established between the markets of Quảng Đông and Quảng Tây and the pir-

ates of Tonkin, who dispatch across the border stolen cattle and young Annamites of both sexes captured in the villages, and receive in exchange arms, ammunition, silver, and opium. The brigandage enterprises have their head offices and their corporate names in China.

Thus they escape all repression, for the mandarins of the Two Quảng are shareholders or accomplices. If, by some rare chance — but a profitable one — a band succeeds in kidnapping a European, the viceroy of Canton takes a solid commission on the ransom.

As the railway advances, new Celestial merchants install themselves. At the same stroke, the pirates widen their field of operations, although their success suffers, from time to time, eclipses when they attack certain well-fortified villages defended by resolute native notables. Some agglomerations escape pillage when the inhabitants are accomplices of the bands and assure them refuge and supplies. Note that every pirate chief proclaims himself a patriot struggling against the French invader. Narrow and credulous, the peasant of those parts, the poor nha-quê, never reflects that piracy is as old as Annam and China, and that before our arrival it had to deal with the mandarins' police. Only the gendarme has changed.

The old gendarme was pitiless. The new one is less harsh. So it is that, in the middle region of Tonkin, the telegraph wires are regularly cut, the native trams and couriers despoiled, the roads untenable, the villages terrorised. In 1888, the Annamite bands of the chief Đê Nam, descended from Yen Thố, and the Chinese bands

harboured in the Bao Day massif, operated at the very gates of Phủ Lạng Thương and pillaged four villages in the single month of December. Against them, in the following February, there took the field an energetic and loyal mandarin, who had accompanied Courbet at the taking of Phủ Lý and Négrier at Lạng Sơn. His name is Hoàng Cao Khải; he is tong-doc of the province of Hải Dương and will later become Kinh-lược — that is, Viceroy of Tonkin. He commands, with the title of Kham-sai, a column of militia-men joined by partisans recruited and armed on the spot. His right arm is the famous Doi Văn, a freshly submitted ex-pirate chief, whose band, solid and seasoned, knows the tactics of the jungle to the full. But the loyalty of Doi Văn is ephemeral: he defects in autumn and, followed by all his men, takes again to the maquis. Yên Thế is more blood-soaked than ever — Yên Thế and so many other regions.

In truth, piracy profits from the blunders which, in that period, we accumulate as though by design. From 1889, we replace three-quarters of our military effectives in Tonkin with the native militia, subordinated to the civil residents, who administer the tranquil provinces — which is logical — and those where brigandage rages — which seems less indicated. So long as the Governor-General does not order the dispatch of a column of repression, only the *linhs* — such is the name of the native guardsmen — have the right to chase the pirates. The pirates? What am I saying? Pirates do not exist. There are, at most, proclaims

the Governor-General of the period, a few buffalo thieves, a few vagabonds...

Former Tonkinese tirailleurs, the *linhs* possess all their qualities. Indefatigable marchers when no burden weighs them down, they are ready to hold to the death behind an entrenchment. Mediocre shock-troops, they can nonetheless attack when a solid troop frames them. Their French chiefs, inspectors and principal guards, are too few and sometimes incapable of handling large forces. But they always know how to get themselves killed properly at the head of their men.

By degrees, we end up having in Tonkin 12,000 native guards, and certain residents play at being military commanders. Our all-too-rare soldiers are dispersed in posts too weak. The freebooters of every race have so fine a game that they abuse it, and we must at last call the military to the rescue.

Crossing villages that have all furnished *corvées* to the pirates for the building of lairs, the columns see only miserable *nha-quês*, respectful and trembling, their mouths sewn shut by fear of reprisals. The most obsequious are bandits. They have hidden their arms in some pond or among the bamboos of the roofs, and they mingle with the fearful crowd that they hold under their gaze. After exhausting beatings, in which the least robust reap the pernicious fever, our soldiers are suddenly greeted, in the heart of the bush, by a fusillade from no one knows where. The marksmen are invisible. One fires back at random. Our bullets search the thickets in vain. No one. In

the forest, the band has dissolved like salt in boiling water, only to re-form a little farther on. Our men bury the dead and carry off the wounded.

Our rare successes have no morrow. In September 1889, Captain Gorce drives Đễ Nam from his lair at Lang Sặt. Đễ Nam will easily find other refuges. Then the column of Chef de Bataillon Dumont pursues Doi Vãn's band and pushes it back into Lower Yen Thế. Hunted, abandoned by his men, shivering with fever, Doi Vãn slips between his pursuers. But he can go no further, and ends by surrendering. Transported to Hanoi in a cage, he is beheaded there on the 7th of November.

But soon, called to some other canton where a Chinese chief practices wholesale throat-cutting and pillage, the columns quit Yen Thế, leaving in the military posts a few Annamite tirailleurs who must be relieved constantly, for in the middle region the men of the delta die like flies. A fortnight later, quietly returned to the very place that saw their defeat, or entrenched a little farther off, the bands put to death — not without some preliminary tortures — the natives suspected of having informed the French. After the tearing out of the livers of the village notables, the pirates burn the cai-nhas, massacre the children, carry off the women to China, and for us it is all to begin again...

Fifteen months before the execution of Doi Vãn, the terrible Cai Kinh — his true name Hoàng Đình Kinh, a former canton chief turned pirate — has been assassinated by his own followers. For three years he had spread terror between Hanoi and the frontier. His headquarters lay in

the Núi Đồng Nai, an appalling labyrinth of peaks, cirques, and gorges, which touches Yen Thế to the east and has ended by taking the name of the Cai Kinh massif.

Does the death of Kinh and that of Doi Văn sound at last the knell of piracy in northeast Tonkin? Shall we be able to reduce, or must we buy off, the redoubtable Chinese — Lương Tam Kỳ, former Taiping, and Ba Kỳ — who, with a thousand rifles, have carved out fiefs where they are absolute and terrible masters?

III — ĐỀ ĐỐC THAM, AND A FEW OTHERS

The evil is deep. Đề Nam still lives, and the former lieutenants of Cai Kinh seek to surpass their vanished chief. For a long time now, men have spoken of old Ba-Phuc, a veteran bandit, former chief of the canton of Ngọc Cúc, whose first depredations go back to the thirty-sixth year of the glorious reign of Tự Đức — that is, 1882. Phuc was one of the most solid companions of Cai Kinh, and it is said that at a great congress which, in 1888, assembled a thousand pirates at the village of Định Tép, deep in Yen Thế, he was proclaimed Tổng Thống Quân Vụ — that is, Generalissimo.

They speak also — but in a low voice, for the man is dangerous — of the adopted son of Ba-Phuc, though they are not always agreed upon his name. He was born at Ngọc Cúc, and his true father, Phó Quát, bequeathed him an example of dubious virtues and the patronymic name of Trương Văn Thám. An ephemeral appellation, which Cai

Kinh replaced in 1886 with that of Hoàng Hoa Thám, adding thereto the very respectable military brevet of Chánh Đề Đốc. Despite which, some call him Đề Đốc Dương.

And it will be hard to find one's bearings until the moment when his bloody exploits have made famous the name of Đề Đốc Thám, or more briefly, Đề Thám. That name will make Yen Thế tremble and blanch the hair of more than one resident of Bắc Ninh, of Bắc Giang, of Vĩnh Yên, and of other provinces besides.

In fact, it is entirely possible that I am in error as to the origins of Đề Thám, for certain annalists have him born in the province of Thanh Hóa, the most northerly of Annam, and say that his father was a half-breed of Chinese and Annamite.

Be that as it may, history is sparing of details on Thám's beginnings. It is known that, towards the ninth month of the first year of Hàm Nghi — that is, in 1884, before the arrival of our troops in Tonkin — he began to distinguish himself by piercing the wall of the military cantonment of Đức Lâm, where he stole three rifles. He easily found two companions of the bush, and that was his first band; with which, respectful of hierarchies, he joined that of Đề Hưng.

At the moment when the French seize Hanoi, Thám, aged twenty, ranges himself under the banner of the *lanh-binh* of Bắc Ninh and fights against us. He is found later in the band of the pirate Thung Phúc, lieutenant of Cai

Kinh. Then he works on his own account in the cantons of Yên Lãng, of Việt Yên, and on the Hanoi–Phủ Lạng Thương road. In 1889, at the congress of Định Tép of which I have spoken, the pirate chiefs share among themselves the regions to be scoured, and they award Thám the district of Lạng Giang. In 1890, he ravages, in collusion with Đề Kiêu, the zone between the Red River and the Sông Chảy.

In the spring, seized no doubt by nostalgia for his native pagoda, or preferring to pass the hot season in his own country, Thám returns to Yên Thế, where Đề Nam holds sway.

Then begins the organised pillage of the whole region, right to the edge of the delta, within sight of Đáp Cầu, a garrison of French troops. The pirates levy taxes in the villages, exact corvées that build forts in the heart of the forest. In the rigged sylvia, Thám feels happy. And, posted near the railway where the French are numerous, he awaits the chance to imitate the Chinese Lưu Kỳ, who has just pocketed 50,000 piastres as ransom for the Roque brothers, seized in Đông Triều — a kidnapping easily carried out with barely a hundred rifles, whereas the combined bands of Thám and Nam count some four hundred.

The future would be all rosy if Đề Thám counted only allies in his own country. Alas! the tong-doc of Bắc Ninh, Lê Hoan, bears him an implacable and secret hatred. Moreover, in Yên Thế itself, the French have installed solid military posts: at Bắc Lệ, of sinister memory, at Kep,

at Bồ Hạ. Commanded by Lieutenant Camilatos, who gets himself killed in the engagement, the tirailleurs of Bồ Hạ, aided by the partisans of the quan-huyện of Đào Quan — another sworn enemy of the pirates, whom the soldiers call "the Commander" — cut to pieces the band of Cai Biều, faithful second of Đề Thám. Thereupon the latter retreats into his lair at Cao Thượng, whence the native militia of the province tries to dislodge him and reaps a bloody failure.

The pirates' braggadocio becomes formidable then. But the blow to the nape is near...

IV — COLUMNS

In the month of November 1890, General Godin enters into action, aided by the river gunboats Moulun and Jacquin which ply the Sông Thương. Four hundred and eighty Europeans, three hundred and twenty tirailleurs, and five 80-millimetre guns join the dance at Yên Thế: they scatter the bands, destroy the lairs at Cao Thượng — alas, evacuated in time — push as far as the fortified villages of Định Tép, Yên Thế, and Hữu Thượng, all deserted, and continue to comb the forest.

Let us follow a column into the jungle. In single file, the soldiers advance. They have muffled their canteens and the scabbards of their bayonets. Not a word. The soft noise of marching and the smell of men from Europe terrify the beasts of the forest. Trembling, they draw aside, belly to the ground, ears laid flat.

Here are the marines: white men and famous. You smile, thinking of the enormous drinking-bouts, the beaten coolies and rickshaw-men, the battered Chinamen, the sprees in the opium-dens of Hanoi. Come now! Take off your hat to these men. They are masters, sahibs, lads of our stock who have conquered everywhere, and the humblest of whom has the bearing of a chief, even when he carries his pack and his haversacks — rogues who do not steep themselves in the vices of the yellow country, but who sometimes deign to taste them and forget them. Oh! there is nothing delicate about their appearance, but watch them follow the twisted and re-twisted trail — a straight road nonetheless because they tread it — a road that leads to the death which these conquerors despise. Here are the Annamite tirailleurs. And here is the Foreign Legion, the rampart of ramparts. They have placed it in the rearguard, so that none shall dare to flee.

They march, while far, far behind them, in some office in Hanoi, or much farther still, people fret over the column's fate. For heavy losses carve out graves and trigger official interpellations.

With the vanguard go the guides, nha-quês terrified by the thought of the inevitable ambush and of the pirate rifles lying in wait. One hears, muffled by the ocean of vegetation, the uneasy barking of the sharp-muzzled dogs, guardians of some forest hamlet near or very far, unfindable.

The rare clearings with their thin rice-fields are abandoned. In small groups, our soldiers cross them,

waiting for the fusillade. Then the trail resumes. The yellow faces of the guides turn earthy. They are approaching. The cutlasses now hack the path through the green curtain.

Suddenly the guides stop, livid, as though scenting danger close by. At once a volley cracks, fells men. Where does it come from? From a palisade, surely. The pirates only fire well sheltered, invisible. Our men advance, as though groping. A new fusillade sweeps the thicket... At the command, the tirailleurs lie down. Two or three, at once disembowelled by poisoned bamboo stakes, howl at the death that comes swiftly. A man, fallen into a wolf-hole lined with a stake, writhes in his agony.

But this time we are there. The rifle-butts probing the brush have just struck an obstacle, a barrier. Forward the cutlasses, to make a breach. And careful as you break through! Dead calm. At the sound of the machetes, the firing has stopped; the pirates have fallen back towards their fort.

It is invisible, like everything else. No open ground marks its approach. Only the European soldiers clear the forward positions and arrange a glacis where their bullets can see clearly. But the forest remains the pirates' accomplice. With its compact foliage, it masks a second palisade of bamboos, which our men discover only when their chests touch the line of stakes, pierced with loopholes where the defender's rifle waits to fire at point-blank range. Beyond, our soldiers find still the hostile undergrowth barred by chevaux-de-frise and by a tangle of

traps that oblige us to divide our forces and lead us into open spaces swept, at less than thirty metres, by pirates posted behind a third barricade drowned in the leaves. Behind it runs a ditch bordering the enceinte of the lair: a fort with parapets of earth and pisé, a buried redoubt, invisible, furnished likewise with every defence imaginable.

From the loopholes of this enceinte burst the triple-tiered fires that issue from the bastions, the armoured casemates, the armoured caponniers, the armoured shelters — all hidden by tall grasses.

Before these positions, which no one can see before he has conquered them, the cannon falls silent, powerless.

It was in such a setting that, on the 9th of December, in the heart of the bush, with barely five metres of visibility, our troops struck against the entrenched camp of Hữu Thuế. Two hundred and fifty rifles and one cannon failed. Six hundred men and Colonel Winckel-Mayer tried again on the 22nd and attacked, marines in the lead. There fell, at the third assault which he led, Lieutenant Blaise of the 3rd Tonkinese. Đễ Thám remained inviolate in his den. But voices are raised; the bandit parleys, plays the good apostle, harangues the Tonkinese tirailleurs. He presents himself in turn as a rebel defending the land of his fathers, and as a peaceful landowner whom they come, without reason, to disturb in his home.

And we are very near to losing face.

But on the 9th of January 1891, Colonel Frey intervenes, this time with 1,300 men who plunge through the usual invisible and mortal network. At the first attack falls Captain de Guigné of the 1st Tonkinese. The pirates still hold.

They hold, but they are afraid. By an incredible feat of strength, our men have brought cannon right up to the enceinte. Once the breach is made by the shells, the French will attack to the end and, who knows? cut off the retreat.

Then, this time again, as in the previous fights, as yesterday, as tomorrow, as always, the forest swallows the pirates. The assault of the 11th of January carries the entrenchments of Hữu Thuế. The lair is empty. Almost without loss, the pirates have slipped away northward.

And it is all to begin again.

Yet the administration boasts of a success which, moreover, the French of Tonkin have greeted with indignant clamour. In July 1890, the great Chinese pirate Luong Tam Kỳ — the powerful Luong — made his submission. I mean that we undertook to pay him 42,000 piastres a year — 170,000 francs at the rate of the period — if he would consent to keep still in the principality he had carved out for himself. Of this fief he thus becomes the legal master, recognised by us. We no longer have the right to garrison it. We do not even have the right to enter it. With the piastres that should serve to pay his Praetorian Guard, the Chinaman augments his reserve of munitions and arms,

while the said Guard pays itself from the country by joining the pirate bands that devastate it.

Seeing which, Ba Kỳ, emulator and crony of the submitter, asks for and obtains a like arrangement. There, truly, we lose face. At Lýn Đàm, where Luong rules, as at Kê Thượng, where Ba Kỳ resides, the escaped from gaols, the deserters from the Tonkinese regiments, and the hunted pirates find an inviolable asylum.

Decidedly, there is something rotten in Tonkin.

To such a degree that one year later the pirate chief Đốc Ngừ — of whom I shall say little, for he acts far from Yên Thế — amuses himself, one evening of carousing, by posting his men on the left bank of the Red River, facing Hanoi. From there, his volleys pepper the windows of the *Dat-dé-Danh*, the charming French concession shaded by mango-trees and flamboyants. The bullets break a few panes of the Governor-General's palace, which was not yet, in that era, exiled far from everything, as though charming Hanoi had wished to push away the present palace, that heavy architectural realisation of the perfect cube.

The fusillade of Đốc Ngừ costs the proconsul of the day his post at once. His name matters little, as does that of his predecessor, who two years earlier was dismissed upon the formal demand of the French of Tonkin. They had found rather bad taste the triumphal entry into Hanoi of the submitted pirate Doi Văn at the head of three hundred armed faithful, who, ever preceded by their chief,

had, very few days after, taken up the campaign against us again.

V — CLEANINGS

In June 1891, Monsieur de Lanessan is named Governor-General of Indochina. At once he imposes himself and rectifies the situation. According to the formula "each to his trade," he leaves to the civil residents the care of administering the regions where calm reigns, and divides into military territories the mountainous Red Zone that borders the delta in the north. The extent of the territories varies according to the progress of pacification. Their commanders hold civil powers under the authority of the Governor-General and military powers under the orders of the general-in-chief.

The general-in-chief is called Duchemin. Read what the great Lyautey has written of him! To praises coming from such a mind and such a pen, I shall not add a word.

The commanders of certain territories are called, at that time, Gallieni, Servièrre, Pennequin.

In the shadow of their swords, the *nha-quê* returns to his rice-field. The forests are pierced with roads that solid posts protect, linked by blockhouses. Slowly, surely, in an oil-stain spread — the Gallieni method — the pirates are pushed back. Step by step one advances, leaving no contaminated region behind. Peace installs itself. Seconding the effort of our troops, the local defence — the inhabitants and armed partisans — organises itself. Villages that

defend themselves against the "giac" — such is the Annamite name for pirates — are no longer the exception. To the commanding officers of circles, or chiefs of posts, and even to the civil residents, the notables bring bandits' heads.

Yen Thế is a parcel of the 1st Military Territory, which encompasses the most agitated region of Tonkin. Our effectives do not permit attacking everywhere at once. First, the rigged forest must be explored. Slowly, drop by drop, it yields its secret. It hides, this time, a crenellated entrenchment three kilometres long, which rests, in the east, on the forts of the pirate chiefs Đê Nam, Đê Thuật, Đê Lâm, Đê Chung, and Thông Thái, and, in the west, on a sixth fort, that of Đê Thám. To the north of this fortified line, the king of Yen Thế, old Ba-Phuc, is entrenched in a powerful redoubt.

From the 11th of March 1892, the column of General Voyron — fifteen companies of marines, legionaries, and Tonkinese tirailleurs, ten cannon, two mortar sections, and two engineer sections — rakes Yen Thế and pushes the pirates back. On the 25th, the column arrives before the forts.

A thick fog gags the cannon. The assault is given nonetheless. Lieutenants Holstein of the 1st Tonkinese, Vignerot of the 9th Marine Infantry, and Becquet of the Marine Artillery fall before the western fort, whose furious resistance will render more brilliant than ever the renown of Đê Thám.

Then the fog lifts. On the 27th, the artillery is in position and cannonades the lairs.

And on the 28th, when once again the bayonets charge the main line, the lads from Europe and the tirailleurs find it evacuated. Not a soul... The forts are empty. Abandoning mountains of rice and paddy, the pirates have slipped between our fingers during the night. Yet we held the paths. The tomb of Đễ Nam, recently dead of dysentery, is discovered in his lair by the partisans of the Quan-đạo, who dig up the corpse of the great chief of the Yen Thế bands and cut off the head to carry it in triumph.

Carried on the 30th, the fort of Ba-Phuc is likewise deserted.

The chase is at once given to the scattered bands. We retake from them women, buffaloes, horses, provisions, rifles, flags, and sometimes even the chiefs' seals — those stamps whose imprint at the bottom of proclamations posted in the villages makes the nha-quês tremble.

Never do we succeed in taking a prisoner.

But our pursuit has interrupted pillage and feasting. By day, the pirates hide in the deepest of dens. They spend the nights alert or in flight. The widow of Đễ Nam has followed the main band, and two months later she will give birth to a son. But one day the band is almost entirely surrounded by a reconnaissance party. Famished by days and days of flight without provisions, frozen, chilled by the forest dew that the enormous leaves of the wild bananas have plastered onto their clothing — those leaves

that betray the passage of whoever brushes them, transforming the water-droplets into muddy pools — the pirates have ended by taking refuge in a grotto whose entrance a thicket of sharp brambles conceals. Motionless, they listen. Violated by the charge of a frightened beast, the brush crackles suddenly, then all falls still. The pursuers are still far off. But now the pirate sentries rejoin, one by one, with wolfish steps. The danger approaches.

Then, suddenly, in the heavy silence, there resounds a wail, at first weak, then shrill. In vain the widow of Đè Nam tries to quiet her child. One of the pirates then tears it from her. A handful of grass in the infant's mouth, and it is thrown at once into a hole. Upon the little body, four shovelfuls of earth, tamped down with the foot. It is done. The son of Đè Nam is buried alive before his mother's eyes. An hour passes. The French have passed wide without hearing anything. This time again, the band is saved.

Meanwhile, some pirate chiefs, hunted, famished, repulsed by the villages that once were their accomplices, renounce the struggle. Đè Sát, Đè Toán, Đè Kiều submit. Their lives are granted them, nothing more. There is no more question of fiefs.

April having come, Ba-Phuc, harassed, still holds out with about a hundred rifles. Hoàng Thám hides God knows where.

In Yen Thế they breathe. Not for long, for the Chinese pirates are not far. On the 1st of July, in civil territory, the

chief Lưu Kỳ kidnaps the contractor Vézin in the midst of the railway yards. Cost: 25,000 piastres ransom, of which the bandit does not long enjoy, for he loses his hide eight days later in the attack on an escorted convoy — an affair costing the lives of Commandant Bonnaud and Captain Charpentier.

How, you will say, is such an attack possible on this line, when a brigade of five hundred militiamen watches it? Because, in places, the bush presses the Mandarin Road so close that the convoys cannot guard their flanks. There, as on many tracks of the Yên Thế forest, the road is, at certain points, doubled by a parallel path a few metres away, concealed by the vegetal tangle. And then, on the 9th of July as on the 1st, the Chinese railway workers aided the attackers; then, the deed done and the arms hidden, they became again peaceful labourers furnished with papers in order. Finally, nothing resembles a militiaman more than a pirate dressed in khaki, belted with a blue sash and capped with the regulation salacco.

Meanwhile, the pirates of Yên Thế grow less and less cocky. The garrisons of the posts give the bands no respite, and the population aids us more faithfully each day. In three summer months of 1892, two hundred and eighty-seven pirates bring us their two hundred and eighty-seven rifles. Harassed, starving, miserable, obliged each night to decamp from his lair and seek another lodging for the ensuing night, Đê Thám, in November, speaks of submitting and of bringing Ba-Phuc and two other chiefs with him. These parleys will, he hopes, halt

the pursuit and give him time to breathe. But we sniff the trap, and the chase continues. At month's end, Thám's band is surrounded and, as usual, slips through our fingers.

A relative calm reigns in Yen Thế until 1893. In February of that year, Đê Thám scores a serious point by seizing the submitted chief Đê Sát, then descends to pillage the plain between Bắc Ninh and Hanoi. In that part of Yen Thế which is not military territory, the natives at once turn their coats and begin again to fortify their villages — against the tiger and against the pirates, they declare. In reality, Thám has ordered the rebuilding of the palisaded enceintes.

Soon there rises, around each agglomeration, two or three hedges of bamboo, reinforced by as many earth walls. Deep ponds stretch between the enceintes, which are pierced by only two or three well-barricaded gates, through which one reaches zigzag corridors menaced by loopholes. The village, by its labyrinth of narrow alleys, is divided into an infinity of islets, ready for resistance, each one made of cai-nhas in pisé, solid as blockhouses and girdled with walls against which lean the outbuildings where the cattle lodge. Thus Đê Thám possesses ready-made asylums to receive him — lairs added to the mysterious lairs he builds in the forest of Upper Yen Thế, "his forest."

Thereupon, the troop of his faithful is swollen by the debris of bands which, in the military territories, are beaten, hunted, disaggregated. Thus flow back towards

Yen Thế Chinese pirates fleeing the frontier circles of Lạng Sơn and Cao Bằng, quitting the gorges of the Cai Kinh or the parts about Bao Day. These regions, blood-drenched for centuries, are at last to know peace.

For Gallieni, commanding the 2nd Military Territory, has passed that way, and everything is cleaned. Everywhere he has brought his effort, the greatest of our great colonials has known how to "strike at the heads and reassure the mass led astray by perfidious counsels." In zones untenable six months before, he has first fought, then organised. He has multiplied the roads that the posts protect, he has opened markets. The inextricable Cai Kinh massif has been swept, and its inhabitants aid the military authority. The railway, which now goes farther than Bắc Lệ, is divided into well-watched sectors; the chiefs of Chinese bands ask to submit. Lạng Sơn develops. In the circles where command the officers whom Gallieni has impregnated with his fertile genius, the interest of all is "defended in the name of common sense" and no longer "fought in the name of regulations." Where the great chief has shown himself clement, no native has thought him weak, for his strength had first imposed itself.

VI — THE BAND

17th of May 1894 — 22nd day of the 4th month of the 6th year of Thành Thái. His Majesty Heaven, where, clad in imperial yellow, sits Ngọc Hoàng, the Jade Emperor, holding in his joined hands the ivory sceptre, lets fall upon

the forest of Yen Thế the first downpours of the rainy season, which succeeds the pitiless Tonkinese drizzle — lugubrious and penetrating as that of Brittany, veiling the months of March and April in mist. A grey web envelops the earth in a soft and enervating caress that follows upon the vivifying whip-strokes of the fine dry December and January days. Of the twenty-four Tonkinese seasons, we are now in that of the beginning of summer. In the plains, all contours blur. In the forest, the shadow is almost night. The vapour concentrates in the gorges. A dust of water clings in tatters to the flanks of the hillocks, as though to thicken the mystery of the hidden lairs.

Let us make our way towards Hũu Thuế, where Đê Thám has rebuilt his fort. The French, for their part, have a post at Nhã Nam, and as the crow flies there are barely six kilometres between Đê Thám and the French. But six kilometres of dense jungle is a day's march.

Let us enter the lair. One must cross, through zigzag breaches, two palisades erected in the thicket, then the third enceinte with its armoured defences and its rampart of beaten earth hardened like rock. A guard-house closed on three sides only watches the entrance. Its walls are of clay mixed with straw; its roof is palm-thatch.

On the terreplein of the fort, an immense shed can hold three hundred men. Others, smaller, contain the reserves of paddy, supplied by Lê Văn Chí, an honest merchant of Phú Lạng Thương. The band possesses more than a thousand loads of it, three-quarters of which are hidden in silos in the heart of the forest and minutely

counted by the pirate Ba Trực, the third secretary of Đê Thám and his treasurer.

At the door of a hut with pisé walls — a door masked by a low wall barring the passage to evil spirits — the pirate Đê Tiều, of the village of Vau Cau, mounts guard, ceremonial sabre in hand and a Winchester carbine within reach. The door opens onto a room where twelve men — always the same ones — keep watch in groups of four. These are the faithful, the rare ones to whom Đê Thám, mistrustful as a beast of the bush, dares confide his safety. They chew the eternal betel and stain the beaten earth with purple spittle. On the walls hang command parasols, dress sabres, rattan canes. Yet another door, and here is the chief's lodging.

Everywhere dominates, heavy and powerful, the smell of opium — a tenacious perfume that the wind cannot carry off, for only the highest crests of the tallest trees tremble, brushed by a light, maddening breeze; the winter monsoon is dead, and the summer monsoon is too weak in the Gulf of Tonkin to penetrate inland.

Distributed in squads of ten men, the band is at rest and in joy, for today, to the ration of rice is added meat. A detachment has just raided a whole herd of those black pigs that share the lodging of the Tonkinese nha-quê and swarm in the sordid alleys of the villages. Uncertain of the morrow, all guzzle and stuff themselves to the limit of the great full. Then they sleep or smoke, or gravely, two by two, delouse each other, or play at ba-quan or Chinese chess, while there resounds the sad melody heightened

with tremolos which a virtuoso, filthy as they come, performs on a sixteen-stringed harp. A group surrounds a storyteller who replaces the beautiful legends of the land of Annam with his memories of the capital, for he was a cook in Hanoi and remains inexhaustible on the usages and customs of the French. Huddled in a corner, a few pirates, seized by a bout of fever, shiver. These are men from the delta, whom the forest is killing.

Every three hours, one sees enter men soiled with sticky clay: sentries just relieved. Without deigning to scrape off their mire, they throw themselves upon the bowl of rice mixed with meat and, chopsticks in hand, nose in the bowl, devour their pittance. A cup of tea from Sơn Tây, and they fall asleep.

Distractions are rare. Sometimes visitors come to find the chief, and the people of their suite, if there is one, give news from outside. Sometimes a sentry brings in a trembling *nha-quê*, who has lost himself in the forest and passed beyond the limits fixed by *Đề Thám*. Three minutes of interrogation, and if the man cannot prove he comes from a village in league with the band, he is delivered into the hands of Hai — a woodcutter of Yen Thế, stocky and robust, executioner of high works. With a backhand stroke of the cutlass, the head flies. Hai never misses his blow save when he has received orders to make the condemned man suffer. If, by chance, the captive is a young woman, she is penned in an isolated hut where other unfortunates await the next convoy that will take them to China. If the woman has no market value, Hai

dispatches her as I have said. Thus all tattle is cut off in advance.

Despite a few disagreeable moments, the pirates find the life they have chosen very fine. Rare are those who regret the hard labour of the rice-field, the days when, plunged waist-deep in liquid mud, breathing air heavy with the stench of the ooze, they pushed the primitive plough drawn, through a haze of mosquitoes, by a great pink buffalo led by a cord passed through its nostrils. Then the feast — the only felicity on earth — was rare, and money rarer still, for the harvest was sold, at the moment of sowing, to the Chinese usurer. The bliss of opium seemed one of those that the hand can never reach. Certainly, here the chief's grip is heavy, but heavy too was that of the notables of the commune or the mandarins of the canton, so prompt to order the bastinado or to pocket the still more dreaded fine. And what, in fact, are these mandarins? Too often former boys, or sons of former boys. Their barely comprehensible pidgin has marked them for the favour of the French. They have replaced the functionaries of before the conquest — the scholars who became suspect to the invader or who took refuge in Hué upon the irruption of the conquerors. Better to hold the bush, Mauser or Winchester in hand, than to lead the existence of the poor *nha-quê*, forever crushed, submissive, passive, struck by the great cataclysms that are the summer typhoons, the tigers, and the wrath of the Dragon-King of the Waters who unchains the flood. Better to be thief than robbed, tax-collector than taxpayer, and

the pirates understand marvellously how to exact the taxes by which the villages buy their tranquillity. So long live piracy, despite its risks!

Đề Thám's band is made up of *nha-quês* disgusted with work, escaped prisoners, men condemned in absentia, and also freed or deserting *tirailleurs* and militiamen. The brutal disbanding of the 4th Tonkinese and of the battalions of Annamite *chasseurs* has thrown into the pirates' camps fully formed fighters — brave and hardened, who look one straight in the eye, carry their heads high, and have acquired, among us, the bearing of free men; for, compared to the yoke of the mandarins, military servitude under the flag of France has been, for them, liberty. Having appointed as squad-leaders former *cai* and former *doi* of *tirailleurs* who excel at commanding volley-fire against our columns, Thám pays them better than we can. Their men salute them with respect and obey them. Coolies carry their baggage when they set out on expedition. In the pirate band, they are considered chiefs. In their village, they would be only *nha-quês* among *nha-quês*, for the meticulous Annamite hierarchy has provided for them no distinction. They have right neither to a place of honour in the common house, nor to a reserved high bench in the pagoda. And we French have done nothing to see that they remain honoured for having borne our arms. Only the retired militiamen receive a brevet of military mandarin; the former *tirailleurs* return home having lost all face. So long live again piracy, which preserves honours!

At this moment, the whole band — escaped from gaols, cangue-birds, deserters, and freed tirailleurs — gathers without care the clement hour. The granaries are full; recent pillaging permits a lasting binge, and the French do not stir.

Đề Thám, for his part, is troubled.

But who could suspect it? No one obtains his confidences, not even the old bandits, not even those who served under the banners of Đốc Tích, of Doi Khét, or of Đốc Kuyến, who was cruel among the cruelest. None dares to interrogate Ông Thám. And none risks questioning Diên An, who wears silk stockings and patent-leather shoes, and whose topknot, like a pagoda roof, is at all times decked with a tortoise-shell comb. Yet he knows many secrets, for this man, whose waxen complexion stands out among the smoked faces, is Đề Thám's first secretary. Son of a mandarin of the village of Ngô Xá, suddenly disgusted at obeying former coolies promoted to notables sitting beside his father, he became a pirate. Later, he will abandon his companions of the maquis and, taking the side of order, will serve us faithfully. In this moment, he is the depositary of the thought of the illiterate Thám, charged with his correspondence, while Đỗ Nuu, the chief's second secretary, drafts the summons and calls to the villages from which they wish to extract money, provisions, coolies, and also, when the band has suffered losses, recruits capable of fighting. No rifle must remain without a marksman. Diên An is secretary and not counsellor to the chief, and his head would fly under Hai's

sabre if he dared reveal to anyone a scrap of the master's projects.

Now the master is perplexed. For hours he has been shut in with his accredited sorcerer, Viên, a native of Mực Sơn, who passes for living in constant communication with Tử Vi, chief of the genies, father of horoscopes — Viên, who excels at announcing propitious days.

At the edge of the camp-bed made of a single thick plank, black and polished, of gou wood — incorruptible and unattackable by white ants — and dominated by panels of red lacquer fixed to the wall, bearing in gold the characters of the Five Felicities — which are Wealth, Nobility, Longevity, Prosperity, and Tranquillity — Thám is seated, legs folded. He is clad in the flowing trousers and the long tunic of black silk, from which emerges the bull neck that supports the head with heavily hooded eyes, the flattened nose as the race demands, the lips less fleshy than it requires, the chin from which hang four or five hairs of a nascent goatee. His hair is shaven — an exceptional thing in the land of Annam. Gravely, he occupies himself with scratching the soles of his bare feet, which he contemplates with sympathy, not deigning to look at the man he questions. Standing in the farthest corner from the camp-bed, head bowed, arms crossed and hands flat upon his collarbones in sign of great respect, Viên listens and answers without raising his eyes. His task is arduous. He dares not step outside the vagueness of imprecise prophecies, nor affirm anything as certain. Now certainty is rare,

and Thám has more cunning in his shaven head than all his companions under their intact topknots.

Viên declares that he has evoked the three patrons of sorcery and the five tigers of the five cardinal points, invoked the Buddhas, the saints, and the genies. The nefast days are not yet finished, but no peril threatens the chief. From the most skilful sorcerer in Hanoi, Viên has just received an amulet that brings happiness and riches. At the appointed hour, he has performed on this talisman the rite of the opening of the eyes, then buried it before the threshold. Let Ông Thám chase away his cares. Besides, news will come soon.

"When?" asks Thám. "And will it be good?"

"Let the powerful mandarin give me time to interrogate the genies, and I will answer him. Let him also allow me to go into the forest to gather the plants necessary for my incantations. I need to be alone upon the paths of the Black Turtle."

"Go," replies Đễ Thám. "And tell the sentries on that side to keep away from you, without ceasing their watch. Return quickly."

Three times the sorcerer prostrates himself; then he withdraws and leaves the camp by the path of the Black Turtle — which is the North — near which stands the highest of all the high camphor-trees of the forest, on which a sentinel perches when danger threatens. The tree,

today, bears no watcher. The sorcerer hoists himself to its summit and looks northward.

Beneath his eyes billows the great green swell of the forest. Of the waves of foliage, he distinguishes only the rounded crests and guesses at the hollows without being able to measure their depth. The clearings escape his sight. Far off, towards the west, rises the summit of Mount Tản Viên, on whose slopes no European can live. Viên gives not a glance towards the sacred mountain. His eyes do not leave the northern direction. Look. There, between two green breasts, three thick white smokes rise, then two black smokes. It is thus that the village of Đình Thượng signals what must be signalled. Viên has seen and understood. He descends and re-enters the lair.

"Lord," he says to Đề Thám, "two men are coming towards you. They will arrive this day."

Then, backing away, he withdraws. The chief has not so much as blinked.

VII — A CHINAMAN

At Mo Tràng, in Upper Yên Thế, a Chinaman arrived at dawn on this 17th of May. He presented to the notables a safe-conduct bearing a respectable seal and not the least French visa. The traveller asks for a guide who will lead him where he wants to go without passing by the watched ways. The lý-trưởng has given an order, and the xã-đoàn,

chief of reconnaissances of the village, has set out with the stranger.

The trail — barely visible and here and there effaced by the bush — first skirts a hillside and follows the meanders of an arroyo that one hears flowing to the right without seeing it. To the left, it is the abrupt slope, the greenish wall of the jungle. The glaucous gleam that filters through the vault of camphor-trees, of flamboyants, and of giant mango-trees lets one perceive, by moments, the mouths of tunnels pierced through the thicket as though with a punch — woodcutters' passages or game-trails. Where the plants have devoured the trail, the guide's cutlass clears the way, and the march is slow. Then, on a freer path, the two men resume their trotting gait, light and muffled. The care of husbanding their breath and the dull anguish the forest diffuses command silence. The rain falls without respite.

They advance, and the jungle of Upper Yen Thê — where lodges the all-powerful Striped One — grows thicker. But the Chinaman and the Annamite here know that the Lord Tiger does not attack man before the evening twilight. Besides, they are approaching a village. A dog barks, pigs shriek. The guide enters a path whose entrance a tuft of brambles conceals. Soon another bush bars the way. It masks an obstacle: a hedge of bamboos, so close-set they touch. Their foliage hides their feet, and their heads rejoin the low branches of the great trees. It is the outer enceinte of the village of Đình Thượng — an enceinte impassable to the Striped One as to the pirate. To

the Striped One especially, for here the pirate often finds open door and good welcome.

One has only to skirt the palisade to the point where it gives place to the entrance of a zigzag corridor, between two bamboo barriers pierced with loopholes and reinforced by banks drowned in the tall grasses.

The barking of invisible and near dogs redoubles. And here is a ditch full of greenish water, where float white lotus picked out with touches of pink — a strange recall of beauty in this sinister place. Suddenly, at about ten metres from the arrivals, a drawbridge falls that the grasses growing under its apron had hidden. A second enceinte reveals itself, made of bamboos sharpened to points and pierced by a door that, pivoting about a horizontal axis, half-opens, swallows the two men, and closes again with a dull thud. All this as though by magic, for only two gaunt dogs are visible, growling dully. Without hesitating, the *xã-đoàn* enters a labyrinth of tortuous, muddy, tangled lanes, so narrow that a buffalo would brush both flanks against the *cai-nhas* with their thick, windowless walls, lugubrious as blind men's faces. And here, in more open ground, between a pond of stagnant water and a great banyan, is the pagoda of the village. It is dedicated to *Hưng Đạo*, who was, in the thirteenth century, a great general, aide-de-camp to the emperor, pillar of the throne, generalissimo of the land and sea forces, and who, under the reign of *Trần Nhân Tông*, freed Annam from the yoke of the Mongols, masters of China. *Hưng Đạo* is venerated

likewise in Hanoi, in Cao Bằng, in Văn Yên, and in many other places.

Hard by the pagoda is the common house, the đình, where rises the altar of the protecting genius of the village. In the hall of ritual banquets, a major notable, escorted by the public crier, welcomes the strangers. A few words of parley, a few bowls of tea, and the mayor himself — the lý-trưởng of Đình Thượng — offers himself as new guide. His daughter has married one of the pirates of Đền Thám's band... This is why, as soon as the travellers are on their way, three thick white smokes, then two black smokes, will rise.

Now, in the forest, the Chinaman and his companion are grappling with a clinging mire. They advance with great difficulty, attack with the cutlass clumps of ferns from which serpents flee. The never-stirred air of the undergrowth is charged with the reek of vegetable rot, whose nauseating insipidity is heightened near certain thickets by the unbearable stench of the tiger-cat. One hears sometimes the soft, muffled sound of a desperate flight through the coppice. In broad daylight, the great carnivores — all of them — fear man. But when there resounds the terrible buzzing of swarms of wild bees, it is the men who blanch and hurry their step. Overhead, the stems of bamboos, by the million, interlace their striae. An invisible stream gurgles near them. Descents follow ascents without the view ever extending beyond ten metres, so that one would swear the travellers lost in the

compact jungle. But the guide orients himself and advances without hesitation.

After three hours of painful march, a clearing of bare rocks suddenly appears, encircled by the high forest, whose trees one can at last discern, freed from the tumultuous jumble of the undergrowth. In all their glory soar the flamboyants with their lace-like foliage and their clusters of fire-flowers, the colossal false kapoks, the giant chestnuts, the majestic and grave banyans — sacred pillars of the forest-cathedral — the banana trees with their enormous tattered leaves, the tamarinds and the hibiscus. Lianas run from one tree to another like shrouds and lifelines, assuring the defence against the formidable summer typhoons.

But no one here has a care for all this splendour. A gesture from the lý-trưởng halts the march, and the Annamite searches the edges of the clearing with his eyes. Must they cross it, or prudently go around it, remaining ready to throw themselves back into the thickets? The lair of Hữu Thuế, the goal the Chinaman wishes to reach, is now quite near, and the pirate sentinels are often brutal. Nonetheless, after having profited from the halt to detach the bush-licees clinging by dozens to their bodies, the two men advance into the open. A few steps from the opposite fringe, they are halted by a cry:

"Halt! Throw down your arms — all your arms."

They must obey. The cutlasses are laid on the ground, as well as the revolvers hidden in their belts.

"Advance now. One by one."

The lý-trưởng advances and, five paces from the thicket opposite, stops again under the menace of a Winchester carbine.

"Where are you going?" asks the bearer of the weapon.
"And who is with you?"

"I accompany the Uncle Các-tiểu, who brings news from the North to Ông Thám. I am the lý-trưởng of Đình Thượng, and my daughter is the first wife of your comrade Lanh Thu."

"Take back your arms, elder brother, and the Uncle with you. Tell Lanh Hy, who is on guard, that Giêm has recognised you."

The sun is all but at the meridian when the two men penetrate the fort. The doi of the entrance post has interrogated and disarmed them. Crouched on the thatch of the guard-house, they wait until the great chief deigns to receive them.

They have been thrown, as to hungry dogs, a few balls of cold glutinous rice. Before them, nailed to the wall by bamboo pegs, hang three freshly severed hands. They belonged to three militiamen of the Nhã Nam post, captured a few days before. The Lord Thám — who dares to say he is cruel? — has deigned to leave them their heads on their shoulders and has sent them back. But he has kept their right hands — those that held the rifle... As an example.

Having finished his midday siesta, Đê Thám orders the lý-trưởng brought in. The man prostrates himself and waits, forehead in the dust.

"Speak, little brother. Whom do you bring?"

"A Các-tiêu, O Elder born before me. His name is Háp Sùng. He arrives from the North with news."

"What does he say?"

"The intelligence is for you, Lord. I would not dare ask him."

"Rise and listen. The moment approaches when my banners shall fly. I have need of you and of the people of your village."

"You are powerful, Ông Thám. In what could the miserable insect that I am aid you?" replies the lý-trưởng, back to the wall, head bowed and fists joined before his breast, respectfully.

"Silence. The vigorous young men are numerous at Đình Thượng. As have done the lý-trưởng of Phú Khê, of Yên Lê, of Ngô Xá, of Lâm Quát, and many others still, you will tell my secretary Diên An the names of those who, on the day that comes, must rejoin me. I leave you the choice: keep for me the best, and reserve the imbeciles to send to the French tirailleurs. You will sleep here and depart tomorrow at daybreak. Go."

Three prostrations, face to the ground; then the man withdraws and gives place to the Chinaman.

The latter has removed the hat with a brim that hid his face. His aspect is sinister. Both his ears are gone. His neck is hollowed with old and deep marks of the cangue.

"Your name is Háp Sùng. You claim to have served under Hoàng Thái Ngan in the Núi Đồng Nai massif. Do you speak the truth?"

With a brusque gesture, Sùng bares his left shoulder and shows a Chinese character branded with a hot iron. It is the mark of the band. Still mistrustful, Thám questions:

"Who looked after the arms of Thái Ngan?"

"A white devil, Lord, but he was not French. He was a foreign mercenary, thin as a stalk of maize. He smoked two taels of opium each day."

That is correct. A Dutchman, deserter from the Legion, was gunsmith to the band of the pirate Hoàng Thái Ngan, in the lair of Lung Lát. Now Thám begins to believe.

"What have you come to do here?" he says. "And why do you not bring a written message?"

The Chinaman is not reassured. If Thám takes him for a spy, his head will fall. Worse still, just now, on the terreplein of the fort, he passed beside a gibbet whose use he knows, for he has seen at Lung Lát its exact replica. It is the swing. One hangs by the feet the man one wishes to torture and swings him violently, so that his head goes at each swing to rub against a stout bamboo stake fixed in the ground, which furrows the skull to a depth of half a

centimetre. When the torture has been well applied, one dies slowly after two or three months of suffering. One finds sometimes, in the villages, wretches who have survived. Those are mad.

"I have no message, O great mandarin, because all our chiefs are dead or in flight. We were, as you know, more than a thousand rifles in the Núi Đồng Nai. All is scattered. Many among us have submitted to the French and surrendered their arms. Others have been able to rally to your invincible banner. Others have hidden their rifles to use them again. It is in their name that I have come to offer you their services. If you deign to accept them, they will come here, or to any place you fix."

Thám does not answer. He thinks. Better than this Chinaman perhaps, he knows the details of the defeat suffered three months earlier by the bands that scoured the Núi Đồng Nai, which the French call the Cai Kinh in memory of the terrible pirate.

From Suối Gành to Lạng Nác, the eastern face of the Cai Kinh dominates with its limestone wall the Mandarin Road that little by little becomes the railway. From the Cai Kinh, the Chinese bands would pounce upon the line, scatter the coolies, burn the villages, pillage the convoys, carry off isolated Europeans. Roty, Bouyer, and Fritz Humbert-Droz have been captured and led to the lair of Lung Lát. Other Frenchmen, travellers or public-works employees, have been killed. Terror reigned in the

region... The bandits, their deed done, would vanish by paths known only to themselves into the limestone labyrinth — an extraordinary jumble of abrupt peaks, pierced with deep caves, plumed with thick bush, separated by hatchet-stroke gorges, with here and there well-watered cirques that would have been fertile had the inhabitants, terrorised and dying of misery, dared to cultivate them.

In the whole massif of a thousand caverns, of a hundred thousand thickets, the chief Thái Ngan ruled as master, seconded by Đễ-đốc Ca Quy, by Liễu Tinh — who called himself Đễ Kỳ — and by the widow of Lưu Kỳ, who knew no fear. Their lair, built in the cirque of Lung Lát, passed for impregnable. Two years earlier, the French had suffered a bloody reverse there.

Now Lung Lát is taken. Thái Ngan is dead, and his lieutenants are in flight. This victory cost our troops only one tirailleur killed and two dead of sickness. It is the work of Gallieni, of the terrible Colonel "Gal," commanding the 2nd Military Territory. This also Đễ Thám knows, and as it is important to be thoroughly informed about all the white chiefs, he questions further.

"How did the French manage to drive you from Lung Lát?"

"Lord great mandarin," intones Háp Sùng, "Colonel Gal is powerful. It is he who attacked us. Those who have seen him say his face is like that of an old Đốc Học, very experienced. He is not pot-bellied and

gorged with meats. He is slender, like those who eat rice. His gaze is terrible. The secretary of Thái Ngan, a very old and very wise man who knows the seven treatises on the art of war, said that Ông Gal — a chief whose brush is more redoubtable than his sabre — knows the great and the small, the strong and the weak, the few and the many, the heavy and the light, the far and the near, and knows how to order and arrange to the best advantage, according to circumstances, the three, the five, and the two of all kinds. In truth, this chief has changed everything. To surprise his passwords was impossible, and we could not hear his soldiers approach, for their shoes were wrapped in straw, their bugles were silent, and not a voice troubled the silence. The enemy arrived at once by all the roads that lead to the cirque of Lung Lát.

"We had to flee through the woods, hounded by soldiers and armed partisans. We had ourselves to finish off our wounded and bury their bodies, which would have revealed the direction of our flight. In a single night, forty-two of our men died. Everywhere we fell into ambushes set by the villages on the order of the redoubtable Gal. The inhabitants of Bắc Sơn and of Tri Lễ killed eight of our men one day, and the next day they brought the French seven more of our heads. Everywhere we were betrayed. The people of Vũ Diệc, of Vũ Sơn, and of Vũ Lễ were the most relentless against us. Those of Vũ Diệc wounded our great general Thái Ngan, and two days later he died at Duy

Cái. Thereupon, all the canton chiefs and all the village chiefs asked Colonel Gal for rifles to fire upon us, and those of our men who had been able to stay hidden in the country had to flee. You alone, Ông Thám, can avenge us, and we are ready to follow you."

"Where are the French that Thái Ngan captured?" asks Đễ Thám.

"They are said to be at Kê Thượng, with Ông Ba."

The fact is exact: Roty, Fritz Humbert-Droz, and Bouyer are at the lair of Ba Kỳ — a supposedly submitted pirate who has not hesitated to welcome into his fief on the upper Sông Cầu fugitives from the Cai Kinh and the three French prisoners. The powerful Lương Tam Kỳ, on the other hand, terrified by the roughness of the blows Gallieni has dealt, has refused the fugitive pirates access to his territory. Đễ Thám, for his part, scarcely fears at this moment the attack of the invincible Gal. The rainy season halts large-scale operations. Yet other surprises are possible.

"I beseech you, Ông Thám," resumes Háp Sùng, "to consider my situation and that of my brothers."

"Who, then," replies the great chief, "prevents them from regaining the mountains of the Cai Kinh?"

"The way is barred to them, O very aged Lord, and besides, before leaving the region, the mistrustful Gal organised military posts everywhere. Do not forget that today all the villages over there are against us.

Must I tell my brothers to remain at work on the road of the fire-carriage? It is there that they now earn the rice they eat."

In fact, after Gallieni's victory in the Cai Kinh, the foremen of the railway suddenly saw the workforce of coolies augmented by vigorous and skilful men — unemployed pirates, most of whom would slip away from the worksites as soon as a band chief demanded their services.

"Return to your companions," replies Đề Thám to the Chinaman. "I shall soon make known to them my will. Depart without waiting and without speaking to anyone."

Two hours before night, Háp Sùng has left the lair.

Thám wants no more Chinese reinforcements. By receiving them without counting, his band would end up being submerged by the Các-tiêu. The day they were in force, they would not hesitate to cut down the Tonkinese chief and replace him with one of their own. Who knows if Háp Sùng himself has not come here, to Hữu Thuế, as a spy? This Chinaman knows well that one of his compatriots, an honest merchant of Phủ Lạng Thương, runs an employment bureau for pirates. The Chinese are men of all treacheries, and, all things considered, it is from this moment prudent to infuse the band with new Annamite blood.

Đề Thám then orders the allied villages to be alerted. In eight days, they are to furnish men and arms. Then the chief bids Diên An write two letters. One is for the chief

of the post of Bồ Hạ, indicating that Thám is, as always, ready to submit to the French — his sole desire is to live in peace on the land that is his. The other letter is for Tchang Chai Jin, a Chinese of Longzhou, agent of Thuyết — former regent of the Empire of Annam — who lives near Canton and supplies, as needed, the pirates of Tonkin with silver and munitions.

VIII — BA-PHUC

The sun, in the west, is already very low when the doi of the guard enters Đê Thám's quarters and reports. The sentinels of the forest announce the arrival of the very old and very respectable Ba-Phuc.

"Let him be received as a greatly venerated chief," orders Thám.

Now this greatly venerated chief made his submission to the French authorities of Bắc Ninh exactly three months ago. He handed over seventy-six rifles, of which fifty-four were quick-firing. Part of his band surrendered with him. The others have come here, to Hữu Thuế, to swell the troop of Đê Thám. The adoptive father and the adopted son are now, it seems, adversaries.

Before the tong-doc of Bắc Ninh, old Ba-Phuc performed very humbly the great lai — seven prostrations, forehead in the dust. Young and full of pride, adopted son of the Kinh-lực, Chevalier of the Legion of Honour, rich and powerful, possessing in his stables eighty horses for

the couriers, the tong-doc is Lê Hoan, mortal enemy of Đề Thám, who has for his support in the struggle in which his head is the stake only his faithful men, his forest of Yen Thế... and his cunning.

"Today, it is to my house he comes," thinks Đề Thám, donning a ceremonial tunic and adjusting his flat turban on his shaven head.

And he evokes their previous meeting, which dates from six weeks earlier. That day, Thám, invited by his adoptive father, went to Lược Hạ, in order to have a further conversation — one more — concerning the conditions of his possible submission. A ceremonial reception. The tong-doc had delegated one of his mandarins to do honour to the bush-runner — an honour whose full value the latter declared, upon his arrival, that he appreciated. As is fitting, before entering into conversation, they offered tea from Lục Nam, made of dried flowers with a delicious fragrance. Old Ba-Phuc himself handed his guest one of the cups that a servant presented on a lacquered tray. A cup like all cups — a cái bát of fine porcelain. Thám took it, bowing very low, and passed it to Phuc's own secretary, who, having drunk, fell dead. And Thám manifested great pity before the inexplicable accident... And while some admired — in secret — the intelligence of the invulnerable Đề Thám, others reflected that no doubt a sign from Phuc — an imperceptible start, a flutter of the eyelids — which the tong-doc's delegate could not have seen, had put the pirate on guard against the peril. So that Lê Hoan's order had been executed...

without being executed. Yellow diplomacy. Perhaps Ba-Phuc thought that Thám might have chosen a victim other than that unfortunate secretary. But why did that man drink the mortal tea? He was ignorant, you will say, of the existence of the poisoned cup, and only Ba-Phuc and the little mandarin sent by the tong-doc were in the secret. That is possible, but the excess of honour that the great Đề Đốc Thám did to that worm of a secretary should have seemed strange to him. Before such a favour, an intelligent man would, from emotion, have let the cup fall. And it is to waste one's time to deplore the death of an imbecile. Salutory reflections, especially when one buries them deep within oneself. Which all the company did, prudently. But that day, the parleys concerning the submission of Đề Thám came to nothing.

Three rifle-shots — a salute of honour — greet Ba-Phuc as he crosses the inner enceinte of the lair. The pirates on guard, drawn up, present arms in the French fashion. The doi who commands them is Thông Luân, son of Phuc's elder brother. Before his nephew — who, for more than fifteen years, fought and pillaged at his side — the old chief, thin and shrivelled — sixty-seven years, of which forty years of active piracy — halts for a moment.

"I shall depart again tonight," he says. "You will see yourself to it that my road is free. This is for you alone."

The old man has spoken in a low voice, for here come, bowing very low, Đề Thư, Linh Túc, Thông Trữ, and

other lieutenants of Đê Thám. Ba-Phuc seems to ignore their presence. On his passage, the crowd of pirates bows. Many of these strong men trembled, three months ago, under the gaze of this old man who seems ready to fall at the least breath. All know that, submitted today to the French, he can tomorrow take up the maquis again. Perhaps it is with that intention that he is here tonight — this Ba-Phuc who was lieutenant to the great Cai Kinh and later named, by the pirate chiefs, Generalissimo of all the bands of Yen Thế, at the assembly of mutual aid at Định Tép.

On horseback he has come from Bắc Ninh, to the point where the road must be left for the forest paths. Four servants accompany him. Three are armed with cutlasses and carry the baggage: bags of woven rattan and a Chinese trunk, copper-studded and padlocked. Upon the shoulder of the fourth Phuc leans as though exhausted.

But Đê Thám, who, according to politeness, was waiting a little beyond the threshold of the reception room, rushes forward. Is it not fitting that Ba-Phuc, the very aged, have here as his support his most humble and most obedient son?

IX — ON THE BED OF GOU WOOD... AND UNDERNEATH

Night has come. A clinging night. The rain pauses. A warm breeze plays in the bamboos of the three enceintes and brings the perfume of the forest ferns. By the

thousand, fireflies trace their trajectories of fire. By the million, mosquitoes whirl. The earth sweats. All is calm in the lair.

On the great bed made of a single block of black polished gou, ĐỀ THÁM and Ba-Phuc lie stretched out, face to face. Their heads rest on the supple, cool cái gối, stuffed with woven bamboo fibres. A long tray of purplish trac wood separates the two men and bears the pipes, the lamp, and the accessories of the opium-divan. The grey smoke dims the chamber, full of the heavy perfume of Chinese opium — contraband drug supplied by Tống Soi, a Chinaman of Phủ Lạng Thương, who receives it in sealed beer-bottles.

For more than three hours the adoptive father and the adopted son have been smoking, interrupting themselves only to scrape the dross from the furnace of brown earthenware of the bamboo pipe, or from the furnace of jade of the very old and very browned ivory pipe — a gift of Lương Tam Kỳ. For more than three hours, in polite and rare phrases, the two smokers have exchanged news of no importance. Now their voices are more hollow and harsher. Ten times already Thám has thanked his father for the signal honour he has received tonight, and the old man has affirmed his joy at having found his son in strength and health. He says now that his happiness would be great if this son would consent at last to live in peace with all, without having constantly to fear an attack from the French.

"Do you not think," he adds, "that many of your faithful would rejoice at a recovered calm?"

"Several have served under your banner, O very aged father," replies Đễ Thám. "And when you submitted, they came of their own accord to swell my troop."

This indirect reproach does not seem to move Phuc, who is nonetheless stung when he thinks that the best of his comrades-in-arms are no longer his, when he thinks that he was, in Yên Thế, a true all-powerful king. Today, Thám is the sole master of the forest — master also to keep him here, as a hostage, if the idea crossed his mind.

Slowly, the old man inhales a new pipe — the thirtieth perhaps — then, courteously, prepares one for Đễ Thám and resumes:

"The young prefer battle to the labours of the rice-field. Since such is their will, they could not have chosen a general more experienced than you."

"All my experience I have acquired through your teachings, O very wise one," replies Thám. "And your presence here tonight gives me the hope of seeing you guide us once more on the roads where you have conquered a renown that equals that of the great Kinh."

Four more pipes — two for each — then a long silence, and Phuc answers:

"I am very old and very weary. I aspire now only to rest, awaiting death. I am weary of fighting. Long

before the arrival of the white invaders, I was already fighting against the pillagers from China. I was rich then; I had many rice-fields and servants."

Four pipes, then:

"O my very aged father," resumes *Đề Thám*, "all of us here are your servants, more numerous each day and stronger. The rat-tails who served under *Thái Ngan* and whom the French drove from *Lung Lát* have come to me, you know. Others will come still. A messenger arrived from the region of *Kẻ Thượng* told me so. He has returned to carry them my word."

For hours *Ba-Phuc* had awaited these words. Now he begins to set his plan of battle. It is a matter of lulling *Thám's* mistrust to sleep, so that true sleep may follow.

More pipes, many of them. The Chinese lamp on the ceiling disappears in a halo of mist, then goes out for lack of oil. *Đề Thám's* eyes begin to flutter, but *Phuc* knows well that it is the moment when the hearing, sharpened by the drug, attains its utmost fineness. When the frogs interrupt, for a moment, their amorous tumult, he himself perceives and recognises the hundred thousand rustlings of the near forest, and distinguishes also the cadenced beating made by the evil spirits, the devils — the *ma-coui* — who dance on the terreplein of the fort. *Thám*, younger and ever on the watch, will mistrust any unusual movement.

But the old man has prepared everything. And, in an almost imperceptible voice, he murmurs:

"A messenger. His name is Háp Sùng, I think."

"Yes, Háp Sùng. You are ignorant of nothing, O very aged one!"

Suddenly, Đề Thám reflects. This Chinaman, whom the lý-trưởng of Đình Thượng led here — why did he not ask for a guide to depart? It is too late to send someone in pursuit. The pirate chief has suddenly the sensation of a trap. Bah! He will soon be informed. Unless... But Ba-Phuc speaks again:

"Háp Sùng lied. He did not go back towards Kê Thượng. I met him on the road to Bắc Ninh..."

Thám is about to answer. Holding out a prepared pipe, the old man resumes:

"Háp Sùng was a spy. He will spy no more. His body is in a bush at the roadside. The Lord Tiger will attend to it. And I have brought his head."

"Shall I see it?" says Thám, quite tranquilly.

Having voluptuously inhaled a new pipe, Phuc rises painfully — a little too painfully, perhaps, for an old smoker like him. He is now near one of the sacks the servants carried — a sack all stained with brown spots. Crouching, he fumbles with the complicated knots of the rattan cords.

Thám has closed his eyes. He listens. What now — the old man is also opening the Chinese trunk; the key has grated, oh, very softly, in the lock. The pirate barely parts

his eyelids and sees only the rounded thin back and the skinny shoulders of the old man. Gently, very gently, Đê Thám, passing his hand into the lateral slit of his black silk cái áo, seizes the revolver hooked to his belt. He is ready to fire at the least suspicious move from the other. But how would the other dare such a move here? The snares are more complex in the land of Annam...

"I cannot see clearly," murmurs Phuc. "I am very old."

And, saying this, he pushes towards the camp-bed the trunk, from which he simply draws a box of cigarettes. Then, from the sack, he extracts a blackish and greenish head — a severed head, badly severed at that: the neck is all jagged. He apologises:

"My servant Nam is not very skilful, and the cutlass was not sharpened."

This time, Đê Thám has opened his eyes. He seizes the ignoble trophy by its long queue and brings it close to the little opium lamp. The feeble glow suffices for him to recognise the head — head without ears, head of Háp Sùng. He rises then and, still by the long queue, hangs the sinister ball from a bamboo peg, facing the camp-bed, well in sight.

A few seconds have sufficed, during which he has turned his back to Ba-Phuc. The old man, softly, very softly, and without lowering the lid, has pushed the Chinese trunk under the bed. All is ready now.

The adoptive father and the adopted son are again stretched out, side by side. Only the great tray separates them — and, without doubt, certain very old and solid rancours as well...

"Let us smoke," says ĐỀ THÁM. "Thank you, my very aged father. You are full of strength and experience. Meeting HÁP SÙNG on the road to BẮC NINH, I would, with my feeble brain, have supposed that he had lost his way. He had left without a guide."

"But," replies BA-PHUC, "I found this in his belt."

And, from the folds of his turban, he draws a greasy paper — a plan of the lair. Perhaps drawn by Phuc himself in advance and for all useful purposes; perhaps handed by one of the Chinese here to HÁP SÙNG while ĐỀ THÁM was questioning the lý-trưởng. Tomorrow, the rattan blows will rain upon the shoulders of the guardsmen who poorly watched the movements of the Chinaman without ears. THÁM has half a mind to interrogate on the spot the doi who commanded them. Better to think further.

"When my soldiers and the Các-tiêu here have well seen this head of a damned one, I will send it to BẮC NINH as an example."

Ba-Phuc, then, smiles.

Ba-Phuc smiles. He reflects that another head — that of ĐỀ THÁM — could well, before long, be paraded through the region, likewise as an example. Muselier, Resident of France at BẮC NINH, is resolved to finish at

once with Đễ Thám. And the tong-doc Lê Hoan is weary of negotiating with this pirate who has just had the effrontery to offer his submission on condition that he be left all his arms and that the French troops, the tirailleurs, and the militia evacuate all the posts of Yen Thố.

Ba-Phuc smiles. He knows that at this very moment — that is, the 18th of May, at two o'clock in the morning — Lê Hoan is at the village of Lữc Hạ, ten kilometres from the lair, with a whole troop of militiamen, ready for the attack. Elsewhere, close by, armed partisans are massed. Elsewhere still, Tonkinese tirailleurs are poised to spring, commanded by a French captain. In total, four hundred and fifty rifles and one cannon.

Ba-Phuc is not ignorant that these four hundred and fifty rifles, even augmented by a cannon, have no chance of overcoming the three hundred pirates of Thám sheltered behind the terrible enceintes with triple-tiered fire, concealed by the complicit forest. He smiles nonetheless, for Đễ Thám has against him a force far more redoubtable than all these assailants. That force is Ba-Phuc himself — all old, all broken, all feeble — Ba-Phuc, who is about to act.

X — THE BOMB

The rain has ceased. Again the breeze blows.

The night advances. It is time to sleep. Suddenly, the little opium lamp begins to sputter; it is about to die. Ba-Phuc seizes the burette to refill it. But he is very old; his

hand trembles, and the tiny flame is extinguished. Thám again caresses his revolver. Useless — see, the old man has already struck a match; the damage is repaired. By the resurrected flame, Đề Thám lights a cigarette. The smoke of opium decuples the aroma of the tobacco. A cup of tea. Decidedly, Thám will never sleep...

Strange thing: one would swear that, in the little horn pot, the level of the opium has risen... Perhaps Ba-Phuc just now, before relighting the lamp, replaced the nearly empty receptacle with this one. We shall soon see.

Thám inhales a pipe the old man hands him. The little ball, well cooked and well glistening, fixed at the centre of the furnace, is the size of a chickpea. No suspicious taste. But at once — legs of marble, shoulders of lead, eyelids of iron. Oh, oh! Has the drug been drugged? Careful. But no — look — Phuc, likewise, draws in a single pull a pipe larger still. Has the Chinaman who prepared the mixture given him an antidote that neutralises the narcotic with which the black paste is impregnated? But has a narcotic really been mixed with the opium?

More pipes. But Thám can do no more. The opium that he can no longer draw in a single pull calcines on the furnace and blocks the orifice. With patient strokes of the long, thin needle, Phuc pierces and repierces the little ball. But the pirate is at the end of his breath. Conquered by sleep, he stretches towards a cái bát of tea that the old man holds out to him a hand that falls back, inert.

Đề Thám sleeps.

Ba-Phuc stirs no more. A quarter of an hour... Silence. Outside, frogs and crickets have ceased their racket, frightened by the freshening breeze. A hard gust shakes the cái-nha. The head hanging on the wall nods right and left, as in a silent denial. Thám still sleeps.

Ba-Phuc now risks a gesture. By the flame of the little lamp, he lights a cigarette. The flame is sinking. What matter, since now Thám no longer smokes... will never smoke again, no doubt. He sleeps, motionless as a dead man. More than a dead man — for see, the severed head, it, still moves...

Ba-Phuc is on his feet. A cat would be noisier than this man. He readjusts his turban without taking his eyes off the sleeping pirate. Then he crouches down, perhaps to look for his sandals. His right hand, holding his cigarette, disappears a second under the camp-bed. Thám has not stirred.

Ba-Phuc opens the door and slips out. Đề Thám is alone.

Under the camp-bed, a continuous hissing, discreet, like that of a very small fuse burning slowly — a tiny sound covered by the howling of the wind.

The little lamp has gone out. What matter, since Đề Thám still sleeps?... !

Ba-Phuc is now outside the chief's house. He is on the terreplein of the fort. The moon, which clouds mask and unmask, lights by fits his gaunt silhouette. He circles the

building, on the lee side of which his two servants are huddled.

"Where are the others?" he asks.

"They played ba-quan and stayed at the guard-house. They are smoking or sleeping."

"Let us leave without them. Ông Thám has entrusted me with a mission that must be accomplished very quickly. Tomorrow, we shall return here. They will keep our baggage."

And Ba-Phuc breaks into a run. He reckons that three minutes are already gone. In exactly seven minutes, he must be outside the fort, out of reach. Here is the inner gate of the enceinte. It leads to a double zigzag corridor, bordered by palisades, guarded by sentinels, and debouching into a half-moon that covers the approach to the lair. But, faithful to the rendezvous, the doi Thông Luân is there and prevents the men on watch from stopping the old man. He is outside. And still running:

"Hai," he says to one of his servants, "the moon is clear enough for you to recognise the road to Lược Hạ without difficulty."

"The thing is easy, O great mandarin. I could follow that road on the blackest night."

"It is well," replies Phuc. "You will go to Lược Hạ with Nam. I shall follow you from afar; I can no

longer go quickly. Do not stray from the path, on account of the poisoned stakes."

"Shall we leave at once?"

"Wait..."

The track the three men follow plunges into the forest. Ba-Phuc slows his pace. He listens.

Ten minutes have passed since he left Đề Thám's dwelling. More minutes pass, very long. Ah!... Here it is.

A dull detonation. One would say a muffled cannon-shot. A faint glow beyond the trees. Then silence.

Under the bed of gou wood, the Chinese trunk, packed with explosive, has just gone off.

"Run now," says the old man to his servants. "Run with all your strength. At Lược Hạ, say simply to the Lord Lê Hoan: 'Ông Phuc informs you that the thing is done.'"

And, having thus dispatched his adopted son, the adoptive father follows at a tranquil little step the path down which his two servants flee.

XI — THE ATTACK ON THE FORT OF HỮU THUẾ

Half past three in the morning. Towards the sky, above Lược Hạ, rise three rockets — two red and one white.

It is thus that the tong-doc Lê Hoan says to the columns: "Đề Thám is dead. The pirates have no leader. The lair of Hữu Thuế is yours."

Nothing remains but to seize it.

"Forward!" say the three rockets as well. Then, from the southwest, through the forest, come two hundred militiamen of Bắc Ninh with Inspector Lambert, and two hundred partisans with Principal Guard Trouvé. And from the northwest rushes Captain Toquenne of the Marine Infantry, at the head of the Nhã Nam detachment: fifty marines and tirailleurs, and the cannon.

Mounted by Resident Muselier, the operation must succeed, since Đề Thám is dead... They will attack at day-break.

Hard by the lair are Lang Leo and Lang Mac, fortified hamlets. In the dead of night, the militiamen enter them and find them evacuated. Ba-Phuc's bomb has alerted the pirates. Sensing the imminent attack, they have abandoned their outposts and rallied to the fort.

Four years earlier, Lang Leo and Lang Mac had served as the starting point for three assaults by our troops. All had failed. But four years earlier, he who was the soul of the defence was alive. Today, Đề Thám is dead.

The three rockets have said so.

Night is ending. From the banks of the arroyo Ngòi Sát, which covers the fort to the northeast — a natural moat impassable in this period of high water — rises the

cry of the curlews, announcing the dawn. The shadow turns from black to sombre grey, and suddenly the day-break, misty with warm humidity, silences the nightjars and the pagoda roosters, which with their clamour strove to beat back the darkness and its phantoms.

Between the trunks of the giant trees, through the dense network of lianas and shrubs where the cutlass carves the road, the assailants thread their way.

The lair is near, for here already are poisoned stakes and wolf-holes that the bush conceals. The blue belts of the linhs, the red belts of the tirailleurs make spots in the sombre verdure. Soon the outer palisade of the fort stops the vanguards, who stumble against the invisible barrier, drowned in the foliage. The machetes at once attack the obstacle.

This fort of Hũu Thuế is built in a hollow. Around it, the ground rises in a swell and hides it. The first breaches cut in the palisade reveal the glacis — a zone of some fifty metres, cleared and sown with pointed stakes and wolf-holes. Beyond rises the enceinte, an almost vertical embankment bristling with great sharpened poles and pierced with loopholes.

Suddenly, from the fort, a voice rises:

"Do not fire on these dogs until they are quite close."

Amplified by a great megaphone, the order is repeated four times for the four sides of the enceinte. Usually, Đê

Thám alone commands, and it is not he who has spoken. Those who know his formidable voice are not deceived.

"Ông Thám is dead! Ông Thám is dead!" they repeat.

And the cutlasses bite the hard bamboos of the palisade with renewed vigour. And here is a cannon-shot. The piece brought from Nhã Nam is at work.

Then, the barricade having been widely breached, comes the assault — at once mown down by the volleys of invisible marksmen. Well aimed, they first bring down the whites who charge in the lead. Principal Guard Trouvé falls, the femoral artery severed, and bleeds to death. Inspector Lambert is struck. Resident Muselier, in the thickest of the fire, receives a bullet in the thigh. Marines, artillerymen collapse, bleeding. Eighteen Annamites, six of them killed, lie on the glacis.

With the French put out of action, the attack is cut short. Partisans and militiamen about-face, regain the protective thicket that the pirates' bullets search.

Not a single defender of the fort has been seen, but one of them cries:

"You have killed our great chief; we shall fight to the last."

A new attack three days later. A reinforcement of a hundred and fifty soldiers has come from Phủ Lạng Thương. The lair is carried. Without difficulty — for it is empty.

The band has vanished into the rigged forest.

On the terreplein of the fort, well in view, two decapitated bodies. Black pigs devour their entrails. Ba-Phuc, who has followed the attack, thinks he recognises the two servants he left behind in the lair. He is right. That very evening, at Bắc Ninh, he will find their heads neatly deposited on his bed.

What matter? Ba-Phuc has been able to see also that his bomb has worked wonders. Đền Thám's cái-nha is nothing but a heap of blackened rubble. Militiamen and partisans have, with their own eyes, seen a coffin carried out of the fort, escorted by women wailing ritually and dressed in white mourning. As is proper, no one fired on the funeral cortège.

Ba-Phuc, the adoptive father, discreetly rejoices at the death of the adopted son.

PART TWO

CAPTURE AND SUBMISSION

I — THAM IS ALIVE

The Dé Tham is not dead.

He was born under the sign of the star Thuy-Tinh. He carries on his person the jade stone that wards off wounds. He is invincible, invulnerable. His house may blow up a hundred times; a hundred times he shall escape death. The spirits have decreed it so.

And Tham knows how to aid the spirits.

Perchance he had drowsed while Ba-Phuc fled after lighting the bomb-match. Perchance he saw.

The match was of such length that it should, at the end of ten minutes, have burst the device. In the forest, Ba-Phuc waited for the explosion more than a quarter of an hour. And then everything blew. And Tham is alive.

Let us return to him at the instant Ba-Phuc slipped away. Like a troubled beast, Tham in his sleep has doubtless scented danger. He opens his eyes... The opium lamp is out. Night. Silence. Ba-Phuc is surely asleep. Tham stretches his arm across the tray of trac-wood. He gropes, searches for the old man's body. Nothing. And, leaning thus, suddenly he sees.

He sees the edge of the gou-wood bed stand out sharply — a dark line that contrasts with the floor of the cai-nha, which something is lighting. Ah! Barely. A very faint reddish, flickering glow. And, through the lingering fumes of opium, rises the smell of saltpetre afire.

Tham springs up, looks. Under the bed, a red point: the match. He crushes it between his fingers, then relights the little lamp and, for three minutes, reflects. At last he hails a sentinel and sends him to wake the Dé Huyn, the

most faithful of lieutenants, who shall command in the chief's absence. For Tham is about to vanish, and all must believe him dead. Only Huyn shall know the truth. Having heard the orders, the latter withdraws and, in the same instant, has all the cai-nhas neighbouring that of the great chief evacuated.

Left alone, the Dé Tham, having hidden under his tunic the ancestral tablet and a box of opium pellets, slips under the gou-wood bed.

Ten seconds later, the match, relit, fuses anew. But under the bed one would search in vain for the pirate. By a secret passage dug beneath the cai-nha he has vanished, and, when some minutes later the Chinese trunk explodes, the Dé Tham is already deep in the forest.

After the attack of the 22nd of May, once the lair was evacuated, the band dispersed. The tong-doc Lé-Hoan pursues as best he can the groups that ever escape him. On both sides blood flows. Then calm settles on Yen-Thé. The pirates have slipped north-west towards the province of Thai-Nguyen, where the tong-doc Lé-Hoan does not hold sway, where the submitted chiefs Luong-Tam-Ky and Ba-Ky are established in their fiefs. The Dé Tham hides in these parts. Five villages see him pass, and very quickly Sestier, the résident of Thai-Nguyen, energetic and shrewd, picks up the fugitive's trail and warns everyone. The Dé Tham is alive.

In August, Tham regains the province of Bac-Ninh. Hidden in a village, he regroups his men and awaits a

good opportunity. At the beginning of September, his friend Bang-Kinh brings him fifty stout and seasoned men.

Well-established on his lands lying between the railway line and the Sông Thương, at the height of Voi, the said Bang-Kinh, for years, had ensured the security of his estates by aiding the bands of the Dé Tham, certain of finding in him asylum, provisions, and intelligence — until the day when the French authority, all indulgence exhausted, confiscated the goods of the accomplice, neglecting however to clap the man in irons. From farmer turning pirate, Bang-Kinh gained the bush with about fifty well-armed faithful.

Precious reinforcement for the Dé Tham, whose band, further swollen by Thos and Chinese, ends by numbering more than two hundred pirates holding garrison in Yen-Thé in two lairs. One is half an hour's march south-west of the old fort of Dé-Nam; the other, on the banks of the Sông Sỏi, north-east of the old fort of Hữu-Thuế, which the tong-doc Lé-Hoan took care to raze after the attack of the 22nd of May.

Tham, still supreme chief, is seconded by Dé Huyn, Dieu-Ké, Doc-Thu, Tong-Luan, Linh-Tuc, and Bang-Kinh, who has changed his name to Doc-Ké, whose warrior qualities he inaugurates on the 9th of September by attacking a military detachment in the vicinity of Lạng-Thương. A French sergeant and a tirailleur are killed, and three men are wounded, while the Dé Tham pillages the large village of Nguyên-Thương.

The profit is meagre. The country is exhausted. The armed partisans recruited by the tong-doc Lé-Hoan have scoured the region like a cloud of locusts — and the pirates could have done no worse. There is nothing left to raid. Something else must be found.

The Dé Tham seeks, finds, and gives an order to Bang-Kinh.

II — THE RAILWAY IN 1894

From Phủ-Lạng-Thượng, it is first the plain, prolonged to the north by the mysterious Yen-Thé. To the south-east stretches the flat country bounded, as far as the eye can see, by the bald knolls of Lục-Nam and Đông-Triều.

The ground then swells into wooded hillocks. Certain summits carry blockhouses. That of the station of Pins protects the concession of the planters Chesnay and de Boisadam. That of Voi defends the domain of the Kinh-lược — so they name the Viceroy of Tonkin.

At kilometre 18, here is Kep. To the left hand, and as far as the Sông Thương, spreads a chessboard of rice-fields, whose rectangles of emerald shimmer under the breeze. Here, 1,500 Frenchmen, commanded by Négrier, on the 8th of October 1884, beat 4,000 entrenched Chinese. Six hundred enemies perished and we lost thirty-two men. Ten years later, the thirty-two graves lie in neglect... And the casernments of the entrenched camp are empty, and nearly empty the defenceless village on the

threshold of the sinister Kep-Lạng-Sơn route — a land of death where the *nha-qués*, trembling under the menace of the four calamities — water, fire, theft, and brigandage — have seen the great pirates pass: Luu-Ky, Doc-Tich, Doi-Van, Doc-Nghi, Cai-Biou, Dé Tham, and many others.

Here begins the mountainous maze. The hillocks close in. From Cầu-Sơn, where a blockhouse stands, the cutting of the rocky railway trench and the earthworks, in the bush with its rotten subsoil, have killed seventeen European works-engineers and coolies by the hundred. At Cầu-Sơn, the upper Sông Thương draws close to the railway line, then throws itself back towards the north, piercing a breach through the wooded massifs. It is through this gap that the pirates slip, passing from the province of Thai-Nguyen to the region of Lục-Nam, and go to join hands with the Chinese bands of An-Châu and Móng-Cái.

We are deep in the forest labyrinth made for ambushes. In January 1891, near Suối-Ganh, an Englishman and his wife were murdered. Five months later, the contractor Vezin was carried off from his own worksites by Luu-Ky and his band, and ransomed for 25,000 piastres. And we shall see the series continue.

As piracy, so war has left bloody memories here, for here is Bắc-Lệ with its fortress-blockhouse. Bắc-Lệ, where, on the 23rd and 24th of June 1884, Colonel Dugenne, pinned between the limestone wall of the Cai-Kinh and the Sông Thương, fought for two days with 400 men against 8,000 Chinese who enveloped him, and was forced

to fall back in an epic retreat. Here, the sheer mountain almost touches the line. The Sông Thương at times narrows and seems bottomless, at times spreads and flows like a torrent among the rock-heads. Bắc-Lệ, a poor and nearly abandoned village, will repopulate when, years later, piracy has died.

The railway continues to follow the river. It insinuates itself, from Bắc-Lệ to Than-Mới, between the abrupt walls of the Cai-Kinh and the last foothills of the Bao-Day. And here is Lạng-Nác. Still following the valley of the upper Sông Thương, now become a mere stream, the line diverges from the Mandarin Road, which climbs the Col de Cut.

The railway sector from Song-Hoa to Lạng-Nác was opened to traffic on the 5th of August 1894.

And here we are in September. Along the last sector, Lạng-Nác to Lạng-Sơn, they press the works. All must be finished before the end of December. Masons, carpenters, or navvies — robust Chinese, dressed in blue and capped with great lampshade hats of straw — labour hard. Waggonnets circulate, pushed by Annamite coolies — a feeble and lazy race, a rabble of nomads, gamblers, thieves, destroyers, who deign to make an effort only to break the tools entrusted to them. The European overseers exhaust themselves shaking off the apathy of these people. In truth, without Chinese labour, they would never have been done.

The pirates threaten the line under construction as they do the line built. The native guard is overwhelmed. The posts of Bắc-Lệ and Than-Mới are permanently on the qui vive. All the militia of a province would not suffice to protect the engineers, the foremen, the works-chiefs who travel the line. And, since everything is booty to the pirates, one would have to surround even the work-gangs with linhs, bayonet at the ready. There would not remain a man for the indispensable escort of the convoys.

Before Gallieni had cleansed the Cai-Kinh, the attacks were incessant. The Chinese merchants of Lạng-Sơn paved the way for the plunderers, just as those of Phủ-Lạng-Thượng did. The ardour of the latter has, to tell truth, cooled somewhat since about sixty of them were arrested and jailed in Hanoi, along with a few others who lodged at Bắc-Lệ, Nhã-Nam, and Kep. And then, really, certain operations no longer pay. Sometimes they even cost. Fancy — Destenay, chancellor of the Résidence at Chợ-Chu and a famous man, has just obtained, through the mediation of Luong-Tam-Ky, the release for ransom of the three Frenchmen captured on the railway by bands descended from the Cai-Kinh. But, oh misery! — the French authorities have decided that the Chinese shall be held responsible for the misdeeds of their compatriots, and the Chinese congregations of Tonkin had to pay the said ransom. Numerous submissions have followed and, just as if piracy were dead, isolated Europeans venture, without fear and without escort, on the railway line.

Let us see what happens there on the 17th of September 1894.

III — TWO FRENCHMEN CAPTURED

It was, in the time of the conquest, a wooded hillock. At its summit a gigantic banyan had grown — one of those sacred trees, with enormous trunk, and whose aerial roots, thrust from the great branches like vertical tentacles, went seeking a surplus of sap in the powerful soil. These roots had thickened until they formed as many trunks parallel to the body of the giant tree. They were like the colonnade that supports a temple, and their shade had sheltered many a meeting of soldiers and Tonkinese women with gracile bodies, thick oily plaits, and teeth lacquered black — girls and women whom our marines and our legionaries conquered between two battles. For the lads from Paris who fought out there, these idylls in the open reminded them of the gallant rendezvous given under the centenary lindens of Robinson. For in 1884, the Robinson of the Parisian suburbs — still leafy and without factories — had long been a famous and charming trysting-place for students and grisettes in a hunger for love and fresh air.

In 1894, the Robinson of Tonkin has become sinister. The hillock, cleared of brush, is bald, and the banyan is no more. A blockhouse has replaced it, whose quarters await a garrison. Its construction cost the lives of seventy-five coolies struck down by fever, while at its foot stretches, at kilometre 33 of the railway line, a cutting where the

poisoned gases of the humus killed more slowly — but more surely — than pirate gunfire. There, man ceaselessly repels the assault of the bush that seeks to bury the rail, as it has devoured the villages of old.

At Robinson, the clearing continues. The hot rain hammers the forest and diamonds the leaves. Annamite coolies, refuse of villages, are at work. Rickety and lousy, impregnated with forest fever, they are clad in rags a hundred times patched and dyed with cunao root, of a brown colour that masks the accumulated filth. Their faces are of a sad ugliness.

Two gang-chiefs, two cai, less ragged than their men, supervise them. It is nearly four o'clock. The train that descends from Lạng-Nác to Phủ-Lạng-Thường will soon pass. And, look — there, as far as the eye can see, a black dot on the line.

It is only a wagonnet, a lorry. It carries two Europeans. Two coolies push it. Two others, the relief men, trot alongside. Along the green wall, the habitual laziness suddenly turns to febrile activity, for the natives have recognised the two Frenchmen of the lorry: Chesnay, head of the clearing enterprise, and his employee Logiou. They have come to inspect the gang. They are without escort, though emissaries have announced the presence, in the nearby Bao-Day, of a part of the Dé Tham's band, come from Yen-Thé.

The lorry approaches, crosses a bridge that spans an arroyo of muddy waters. The brake grinds; the vehicle is about to stop.

Sudden fusillade. Bullets buzz around the lorry or strike the metal sheeting, which rings. From the vegetal wall that borders the railway, Annamites spring forth — pirates, all armed, all dressed in khaki like the militiamen of the native guard, all turbaned in black and belted with cartridge-pouches.

"Maolen! Maolen!" shouts Chesnay to the coolies of the lorry. In vain. They have flattened themselves on the ground, trembling, and the clearers have vanished... The two Frenchmen then leap onto the track.

They flee, at full pelt, towards Suối-Ganh, where there is a post of linhs. Three kilometres to run and they are saved.

Logiou is in the lead. Chesnay follows. The two cai have picked themselves up and bolt with all their strength. Soon one of them falls, his head smashed by a bullet. Chesnay in turn goes down. His foot has caught on a rail-sleeper. The weight of ten men hurled upon him prevents him from rising. Lean, bony, brutal hands flatten him in the mud — by the neck, by the head, by the legs. Two bandits violently wrench back his arms, which a third binds with a filthy turban.

Chesnay is a prisoner.

At once, the surviving cai stops, prostrates himself, makes the great ritual *laïs*, begs for his life. For all answer, the pirates beat him with rifle-butts, and the man, three-quarters stunned, lies stretched on the ground.

Logiou, for his part, has covered two hundred metres, a howling pack at his heels. The Frenchman can go no further. He hears, behind him, second by second closer, the slapping of bare feet on the soaked earth. And suddenly he feels himself caught, seized round the waist, and in the same instant knocked over and trussed like his master, to whom they couple him by a rattan cord.

Then comes the search. The two rings Chesnay wears are torn from him, as are his watch, his chain, and his money. The same operation is carried out on Logiou, then one of the pirates — the chief, no doubt — orders: "En route!"

But this chief is not the *Dé Tham*. Instead of obeying his order, the pirates debate the point. Why stop when everything is so simple? Two prisoners, even white men, are little enough. The train from *Bắc-Lê* is about to pass. What a windfall if one could bring a dozen captives to the lair!

Finally, twenty pirates, taking Chesnay and Logiou, gain the forest. The others are suddenly seized by an ardour for work that the coolies would disavow. Some turn themselves into reapers, others into navvies. But, in the distance, a locomotive whistle rings out. Then all vanish into the thickets.

IV — THE ATTACK ON THE TRAIN

Hobbling, panting and wheezing, the train descends from Lạng-Nác towards Phủ-Lạng-Thường. On the narrow track it writhes. Mixed convoy — goods and passengers. Convoy without escort. The only warriors it carries are a corporal and three soldiers of the marine infantry, who share between them two cases of dysentery and as many pernicious fevers. The hospital at Phủ-Lạng-Thường awaits them. One of them, cachectic to the last degree, will die before evening.

Carriages are crammed with natives. The women are numerous. They come from the market at Than-Mới and carry fish and great prawns, which the threatening storm is spoiling; hen's eggs three-quarters incubated; aubergines; black radishes; little roasted pigs, varnished; ducks; quarters of meat; lengths of sugar-cane. The humid heat pounds down upon it all. The stench is repulsive. Flies whirl. The red spittle of betel enamels the floors.

Five Europeans occupy a saloon-carriage. Drenched in a sweat that dries neither day nor night throughout the Tonkinese summer, all thought, all energy killed by the moist enwrapping of the heat, they doze, stretched on the benches. The crossing of the Cầu-Sơn cutting is a torment amid the sweetish and toxic odours distilled by the forest and the recently turned earth.

Seated on the access platform, legs dangling from the carriage, the train-chief has dozed off.

A brutal jolt wakes everyone. Brakes suddenly locked, the carriages jolt into each other. The train stops abruptly.

"Forward, you stuffed fool! Forward! Who told you to stop, idiot? What the devil are you doing on the line?"

Thus bellows the train-chief at the sight of the Chinese driver, who has climbed down from his engine. The man, deigning no reply — for his conduct, he thinks, explains itself — sets about clearing the rail encumbered with great branches and heaps of stones, obstacles that, by luck, have not derailed the convoy, braked just in time. And the train-chief prepares to descend as well, and the other Frenchmen with him. But, by common accord, all reconsider, quit the platform, and disappear inside the carriage.

Ten shots have broken out. Pierced by four bullets in the back, the Chinese falls dead. From the foliage, on each side of the line, some thirty pirates emerge — silent, rifles shouldered, aiming at the carriages. "Giac! Giac!" cry the natives in a high key. And panic is upon them. They leap onto the ballast, try to flee. The pirates let them. It is the French they are after. The women, too — the young ones who will fetch a price among the Chinese of Quảng Tây. A word, a sign, and the wretches prostrate themselves, offering their strings of sapèques, then huddle together, a frightened flock guarded by three or four brigands.

All this in much less than a minute.

But now it is the pirates' turn to howl with rage. The train has just shuddered again with the abrupt collision of carriages. A brutal start. There it goes, backwards, towards

Bắc-Lê, where the track is clear. Crouched on the floor of the locomotive, the fireman — a Chinese, too — has reversed the gear and opened the steam-valve wide. The natives who have taken flight have now but one idea: to get back on, to get back on at any price. They fight to force access to the carriages, cling to the steps, the buffers, and the coupling-chains. A terrible fusillade rakes the howling mass. Six killed, about forty wounded. The locomotive, the saloon-carriage are riddled. The Frenchmen, all unarmed, lie flat under the benches. Not one is hit. Soon the train is out of range — saved.

A failed affair. Bang-Kinh is not pleased.

It is his band that has just operated. He hoped for better than the capture of two Frenchmen and a score of congaïes. Now they must take to their heels. Already the clearing coolies must have alerted the militia. And the nha-qués who could not get back on the train will also talk, if the thing is not put right. They dared not leave the track. The forest is unhealthy when the pirate holds it.

It remains only to mislead the inevitable pursuit. Bang-Kinh calls two of his men, disarms them, makes them don the cast-offs of two dead men. There they are, changed into frightened nha-qués, mingled with the fearful crowd, whom they keep under their gaze and whom they lead towards Suối-Ganh. They will speak to the French, and the others, passively, trembling for their skins, trembling for their villages, will confirm their words. And so our men will scour the massif of the Bao-Day, where the Dé Tham has been reported — false intel-

ligence, in fact. Believing he pursues the pirates, the principal guard of the Suối-Ganh post follows the trail by which they arrived. Towards the Bao-Day still hasten militiamen from Bắc-Lê, ten marines and a lieutenant from the post of Kep. All turn their backs on the bandits, who make for Yen-Thé.

The group that slipped away with the two Frenchmen is already far. Through the jungle it has made its way. After an hour's march on barely visible tracks, here is a clearing at the bottom of a hollow valley locked between two leafy slopes. A rice-field lies there, abandoned, near a pond surrounded by giant reeds — some strewn on the ground, broken by beasts that have come to drink, others intact, whose purple tassels seem made of light feathers. Dragonflies with black-and-yellow thoraxes hover all around. The rain has stopped. In this sinister hollow, all the heat seems concentrated. The earth tries to give back, in vapour, the downpours received. In the distance, towards the Tam-Đảo, towards the Cai-Kinh, towards the Bao-Day, the daily storm rises that will burst as soon as the sun has gone.

The band halts. A few pirates go to post themselves as sentinels wherever access to the clearing is possible. The others sit on their haunches, in that crouched position which is a rest for yellow men. Still bound to each other, streaming with sweat and rain, the two Frenchmen collapse on the ground, exhausted. Chesnay is seated, his body in the sun, his legs stretched out. With his two hampered wrists he props his panting torso. Logiou,

covered in mud, lies on his side. The pirates do not take their eyes off them and snicker.

Suddenly there rings out, at regular intervals, the sad call of the great Tonkinese stag. At this signal the pirates rise. One of the sentinels runs up, announces the arrival of the detachment that attacked the train. Soon the group of Bang-Kinh emerges with the captive congaïes.

And the band sets off again through the forest — allied and discreet — by paths that the downpours have turned into torrents or quagmires, and which they must leave to cut through the woods, so as to avoid certain lukewarm or hostile villages that might inform the French. To follow the swift trotting of the pirates is a torment for Chesnay and Logiou. Their feet bleed. The slaps of branches flay their faces, which their bound arms cannot protect. The unhealthy moisture of the forest, the weight of the threatening storm, double the terrible fatigue. The air is stagnant. Two prisoners drown while fording an arroyo whose waters the great rains have swollen.

Brutally, night falls, like a mass of lead. The march continues nonetheless. The storm explodes. Sheets of water batter the forest. They still advance, by the blinding glare of lightning that ceaselessly links sky to earth. At last here is an old little ruined pagoda. In a buzzing cloud of mosquitoes greedy for blood, the fifty pirates and their captives pack themselves in for the night. The Frenchmen are invaded by the vermin of the Annamites. Blows heavily dealt silence the women's complaints. Five of

them have managed to escape during the night march. Will they get out of the forest?

V — AT LẠNG-THƯƠNG

Not far from Chợ-Go, about two kilometres north of the fort of Hữu-Thuế, where in May the bomb of Ba-Phuc exploded, lies — midway between the Sông Sỏi and the arroyo Ngòi-Sắt — the village of Lạng-Thương, fortified as is fitting. Close by, the Dé Tham has just installed his general headquarters, in an old lair whose defences the people of Lạng-Thương have just completely refurbished: covered shelters, casemates, great bamboo stakes and poisoned lancettes, ditch, parapet, and palisades drowned in the thickets. An invisible lair, unfindable. A lair of little extent, but what matter? The great chief's lieutenants hold the countryside. Doc-Thu operates in the massif of the Tam-Đảo, while Tong-Luan pillages, burns, and ransoms in the south of Thai-Nguyen and in the north of Bắc-Ninh and Đáp-Cầu. As for Tong-Tru, he works in the forest of Ven-Tien. Only Linh-Tuc is near the Lord Tham.

Towards Lạng-Thương rush Bang-Kinh and his prisoners. At top speed they march, despising the heavy downpours that alternate with the solar furnace. They go fast — less fast, however, than the intelligence that, in Yen-Thé, flies like a bird. And great is their surprise to be joined, at the penultimate stage, by Linh-Tuc and his men, whom the Dé Tham sends them as reinforcement... Now, Linh-Tuc warns: "Ong Tham is furious."

For some months, this fury has scarcely left the master. The news is nonetheless troubling, and Bang-Kinh, entering the lair on the 21st of September about noon, takes care not to appear in triumph. Humbly, he delivers the captives to the guard-post and, followed by his men, exhausted as he is, gains his barrack.

Under the rain, the prisoners are penned. Around them the people of the lair gather in a circle: the Annamites insult them and snicker with all their black teeth. The Thos, closed faces, eyes without expression, keep a silence of fierce beasts. Half-dead with fatigue, feet bloody, clothes in tatters, the two Frenchmen, still bound to each other, remain deaf to the sarcasms. Thirst, hunger gnaw at them, and more still the longing to be freed from the bonds that for three days and two nights have tortured them, and the longing to go no further, to stay there, to sleep under whatever hovel, sheltered at last from the rain, from the sun, and from the touch of the bandits.

Scarcely have they strength enough left to be astonished at the spectacle offered, close beside them, by the aspect of five decapitated bodies — corpses of the lý-trưởng and four notables of a village between Kep and Bối-Hạ, convicted of having supplied emissaries to the tong-doc of Bắc-Ninh. The village has been, naturally, sacked and burned; the inhabitants who could not flee have been massacred; the captured women are penned in the lair. And the pirates feast on the rice-alcohol, the choum-choum they have pillaged. The five heads are already in wide-mesh rattan nets. They will be nailed to

the watch-towers of five villages that the pirates suspect of lukewarmness.

Bang-Kinh still waits. The Dé Tham is invisible, shut up with A-Thac, an honourable Chinese to whom his profession — the only one he admits — of itinerant physician permits every necessary safe-conduct for scouring Tonkin, Annam, and, should need be, crossing the border of Quảng Tây. The Annamites fear A-Thac and admire his science. A disciple of Tuệ-Tĩnh, he knows the role of the five viscera, the moist radical, the influence of the stars, and has no equal for passing his delicate fingers over the twenty-six pulses that must be felt to track down illness and thwart the wiles of Hoạn-Đạn-Quỷ, the yellow-headed devil, sower of all kinds of ills.

To the pirates come from the delta, upon whom Thần-Cây — the spirit of the trees — has sent a terrible fever, which resists even the incantations of the sorcerer Lien, the learned A-Thac has distributed powders that must be sovereign if their excellence matches their price. To those racked by dysentery, he has prescribed bat guano, an infallible remedy. Then he has entered the great chief's presence.

There, it is no longer a matter of medicine, but of intelligence that pays more dearly than treatment. The news is bad. It is henceforth difficult to send captured women into China. Marshal Sou-Yuan-Tchéou has promised General Du to watch the frontier strictly, and the marshal — an unheard-of thing in a Chinese — keeps his word. Now, the Celestial mandarins tremble before the

terrible Sou, general-in-chief of Quảng Tây, inspector of the frontier army-corps, mandarin with the plain red coral button — mark of the first rank — bearer of the three-eyed peacock feather, bearer of the Order of the Pa-Tu-Lu and a hundred other decorations, wearer of the yellow robe, possessing two hereditary titles of nobility of the sixth and eighth ranks, member of the Grand Secretariat, and second guardian of the Heir Presumptive.

"You would act prudently," advises A-Thac, "in sending the captured women to Luong-Tam-Ky's, where the whites have no right to go and fetch them. But perhaps it is already too late. The French are stirring."

"What have you learned on that matter?" asks Tham.

"At Phủ-Lạng-Thượng, as soon as the attack on the steam-carriage was known, the substitute résident sent emissaries in all directions, then departed with linhs and French non-commissioned officers."

Accurate intelligence. The vice-résident Quennec has acted promptly and taken the field with fifty militiamen and two principal guards.

"Then," continues the Chinese, "the tong-doc Lé-Hoan has begun to search for those who carried off the two Frenchmen. Colonel Gal has left Lạng-Sơn and sent all the soldiers of Văn-Lĩnh with a four-stripe chief who has reached Bắc-Lệ and commands all the troops and all the linhs of the railway. I could learn nothing

else. And now, if you permit, O Very Old Mandarin, I shall continue my road towards my country. I am ready to serve you there as here. If you wish it, I shall see Tchang-Chai-Jin."

"I need you to see him," replies the Dé Tham. "Tell him this: 'The Dé-Doc Tham salutes humbly, with bowed head, the Great Regent. Ton-Thất-Thuyết and he assure him that, so long as Hoang-Tham lives, nothing shall be changed in the châu of Thiên-Đức, even if all things appear transformed.'"

"I have understood," replies the Chinese.

And, after an exchange of ritual politenesses, he departs. Tham then summons Bang-Kinh.

Prostrations. Great laïs. Then, having heard the report of his lieutenant, the pirate chief declares:

"Younger brother, you are quite new to the trade of arms. Another would have brought me not two, but ten Frenchmen. Who are your two prisoners, and where are they?"

"One is named Tchett-nhé. He is one of the two masters of the Pine-Parasols farm; he is also chief of the reapers of the railway. The other is one of his employees, Lo-dji-ou. They are tied together and await your will on the terreplein of the guard-house."

"Let them be untied. Let them be given food. I shall interrogate them afterwards."

And, as it is fitting to reflect before deciding, Tham, stretched on his camp-bed, asks counsel of the brown drug. And opium replies that the two Frenchmen are well worth 60,000 piastres. They may even bring more than money.

VI — NEGOTIATIONS

"We were taken north of Suối-Vi and conducted from there to Chợ-Phong. Then we marched all night and all the following day, to arrive at last at the Dé Tham's post. This long tramp by winding trails served to throw off anyone who might have followed us. Tell the authorities that we beg them to stop all operations in this quarter and to recommend to the posts surrounding Yen-Thé not to harass these people, otherwise we are lost.

"I believe that the Dé Tham desires to treat, but he must not be vexed: this band is very cruel, and we have already witnessed too many atrocities.

"Please telegraph to the Governor, to the Résident Supérieur, to Colonel Gallieni, to Captain Grimault at Bõ-Hạ, and inform them of our situation. We are in good health and not wounded, but we greatly fear the irritation of these people. The letter continues with a request for clothes, provisions, soap, etc.

"Appeal to the benevolence of the Government to get us out of this awkward situation. But let them be

prudent, for the slightest action would cost us our lives. For three days we have eaten nothing but a little rice. Be careful, when taking M. Logiou's clothes, not to send soldier's trousers, and beg the authorities to do for us all that they can. The Dé Tham always desires to make his submission. All that he does now is to take vengeance — he charges me to say it.

"We are at Friday, four o'clock in the evening. If any reconnaissance parties are out, try to stop them..."

This letter, signed Chesnay and Logiou and carried by a boy captured during the attack on the train, arrived at the Pine farm three hours after its sending. It was written in the presence of the Dé Tham and under his control.

The pirate feels strong. He holds two precious hostages. He wishes to submit. He also wishes to avenge himself on Lé-Hoan, on Ba-Phuc, on everyone. He also wants piastres — heaps of piastres.

He is sure of impunity. He treats as equal with equal with the French, and does not hesitate the following morning to dispatch to the post of Nhã-Nam two of his men, bearers of a second message from Chesnay. They are to present themselves openly, as parliamentaries. By way of a white flag, the letter at the end of a bamboo.

Now, the captain commanding the post of Nhã-Nam admits no pirate parliamentaries. The two emissaries are shot on the spot. By this example, thinks the officer, the Dé Tham will reflect.

Now, this time, Tham, without further reflection, sends for his lieutenant Linh-Tuc and gives an order.

Before the following dawn, Linh-Tuc has set out with twenty men. At dawn, he returns. Twenty-six men follow him. Six are bound — *nha-qués* of *Nhã-Nam*, seized soundlessly in their *cai-nhas*, despite the sentinels perched on the watchtowers of the post, out of tiger-range; despite the rounds of non-commissioned officers; despite the guard-dogs. Six lean and trembling *nha-qués*. Six men condemned to death... By way of reprisal, simply.

Parade of execution. The band is there, under arms. The two Frenchmen are roused. They are brought, fists bound, before six bamboo stakes planted in the centre of the lair.

Before each stake, a *nha-qué*, stripped to the waist, is kneeling in the mud. *Haï*, the executioner, supervises the preparations. Four of the condemned are already half dead. The other two, impassive, make their own final toilet: they wet their necks, coil up their chignons and bind them in a white turban — thus carrying their own mourning — then extend their arms, which are at once tied to the bamboo stakes. This done, while inclining themselves at the required angle so that the blade may strike the neck cleanly, they begin to spit chosen insults at the face of the *Dé Tham*, at the risk of seeing themselves condemned to the torture of the slow death.

But Tham remains cold. And here comes the great ceremonial gong, carried on the shoulder by two pirates. *Haï*

has abandoned the usual cutlass for a fine Japanese sabre. To sever six heads, a choice blade is needed. Wetting his finger with his saliva reddened by betel, he traces on each neck the line to aim at.

Stroke of the gong: a head flies. Second stroke: second head. One can scarcely distinguish the flash of the sabre, wielded with a master's hand. Soon it is all over; the six *nha-qués* are dead.

"Now," declares the *Dé Tham*, "their souls of the decapitated — become *ma-cut-troc*, headless spirits — will wither the rice-fields of *Nhã-Nam* and turn to straw the paddy drying on the threshing-floor."

On the cast-off rags of one of the executed, *Hai* wipes his sabre.

The execution of the wretches has not calmed the *Dé Tham*. The sight of blood overexcites him. All day he drinks *choum-choum*, bowl after bowl. In his drunken head, hatred heats against this post of *Nhã-Nam* so close by, from which so often the columns sent against him have set out — *Nhã-Nam* where, one day, the *résident* of *Bắc-Ninh* invited him to a friendly conversation. That day, the post overflowed with hidden militiamen, and anyone else but *Tham* would have been well and truly captured. But the pirate, always informed, had sent into *Nhã-Nam*, in small groups, the men of his personal guard, disguised as peaceful and ragged *nha-qués*. At the moment they were pouring the champagne of friendship, these men entered quietly into the building of the delegation, carbine in hand,

and rendered the résident military honours he would gladly have forgone. For some months now, it is soldiers who hold the post — this post not an hour's march from the lair, this exasperating post where two of the great chief's faithful have just been shot. Has Tham then ceased to be the master of Yen-Thé? In truth, there must be an end to it, and a blow struck that will terrify all the whites of Tonkin. Evening comes; rage chokes the pirate. He calls Dien-An, his first scribe and his usual interpreter. Then the two Frenchmen are brought in, their arms tied once more. Always elegant and perfumed, Dien-An speaks:

"Thus says Ong Tham. Tomorrow, two bamboo stakes will be planted for you. Before your heads are cut off, he permits you to dictate a last letter to your French friends. I shall transcribe it with pleasure and as best I can."

Chesnay, who understands Annamite, then hears the Dé Tham give the detailed orders for the execution. He deigns not to protest. It would be useless, and besides, before these people, one must keep face to the end.

"I have nothing to dictate to you," he says to Dien-An, "and your master knows very well that in killing us he signs, for himself and all his people, a death-warrant."

Then Chesnay and Logiou are taken back to the guard-house and, as always, kept under watch.

The execution is fixed for the morrow, in the middle of the hour gio-ti — the sixth — which lasts from nine to eleven in the morning.

Now, at the beginning of the hour gio-thin — which is the fifth — a detachment of pirate patrolmen returns to the fort. They are six and, two by two, carry on their shoulders bamboo poles from which hang strange burdens. Corpses, one would say. Three bodies, wrapped in shrouds of black serge, heads hooded in brown cotton, the whole tied from head to foot by rattan cords whose ends are fastened to the poles. Before the Dé Tham's door, the three bodies are dumped, without gentleness, amid the laughter of the band which has gathered.

Here comes the great chief. He has slept off his alcohol. He seems calm and deigns to laugh at the sight of the three human sausages stretched in the mud.

"Where did you find these three men? And what were they doing?"

"Bam quan lon, they were all three together in the forest between Chợ-Go and Lạng-Nửa, and were making signals with hollow bamboos."

"Let them be untied and let them speak."

The three men, unfastened, prostrate themselves, not without difficulty, for their bodies are stiff, broken by the terrible transport. All three have cropped hair, the tonsure, and black soutanes shredded by the friction of the thorny plants of the forest. One is Kham, priest of the Catholic

village of Binoi; another, Tran-Chinh-Nha, priest of Đào-Ngạn; the third, Nguyen-Duc-Hanh, is also a priest and comes from Phủ-Lạng-Thượng. They were making sound-signals to attract attention to themselves. They are happy to have been taken by the warriors of the Dé-Doc Tham, for they were wandering, blind, in the forest, hoping that chance would bring them before the illustrious mandarin, whose residence they did not know. They are the envoys of Mgr Velasco, Bishop of Bắc-Ninh.

At this declaration, Tham has the three priests enter his cai-nha and questions them:

"What does Ong Velasco want?"

"He asks you to return the two Frenchmen who are your guests. He would like to see you live in peace with all. He begs you to trust us."

"I shall have trust. I shall prove it by sending Kham back to Bắc-Ninh to carry my word to Ong Velasco. I keep here Nha and Hanh. They will be flayed alive if the French learn the place where I am. Kham, you will tell Ong Velasco that the Dé-Doc Tham is willing to speak with him. Let him come into the forest. No harm shall be done him. But let him beware of bringing an escort, if he holds dear the lives of the two priests I keep here."

Kham, his head once more hooded so that he may not find the way back to the lair, is at once escorted back to

Chợ-Go and, free of his movements, makes haste to Bắc-Ninh.

And, at the same stroke, the Dé Tham countermands the execution of Chesnay and Logiou.

Four days later, Mgr Velasco is in the forest.

Astride a little donkey, he has come, by the tracks of slippery mud, by the paths become streams or torrents, under the lashing downpour. From Lạng-Nửa, a Catholic Annamite of Nhã-Nam, a former pirate, has guided him and built for him a poor hut of branches. Then the bishop remained alone. Not for long. The Dé Tham, quickly warned, has had him conducted by one of his men to an old little isolated pagoda, with grimacing gods, leprous walls, discoloured tiles, the roof-chimeras worn by sun and rain.

Mgr Velasco installs himself there, still alone, without a single servant. At night the "cop-cop" of the hunting tiger, the dry bark of the great stag pursued by the beast, the raucous yelp of the con-nai — the Tonkinese roe-deer — the tumult of brushed branches, tell him the dramas of the forest. By day, the Dé Tham comes.

He comes without one ever hearing his approach, without the prelate ever perceiving the pirate's escort, always nearby, always on the alert, always ready — should a nha-qué chance to approach the pagoda — to cut his throat on the spot.

On the spot and in silence, for the palavers of Ong Tham with the chief of the Spanish bonzes must not be disturbed.

Meanwhile, the French authorities have ordered all detachments in Yen-Thé — *tirailleurs* or militiamen — to remain at rest, arms at the ready, in their posts. Never has the region been so safe, for the Dé Tham has given his bands a like order. He negotiates, in interminable conversations with Mgr Velasco. Sometimes the latter sends a message to Bắc-Ninh, entrusted to one of the pirates. Each letter ends with the recommendation to send neither food nor servant. Any indiscretion would make the parleys fail.

Each day brings a new interview. Patiently, the bishop gains ground, despite the thousand reticences of the pirate and the delicate questions that must be resolved. The Dé Tham demands a ransom of 60,000 piastres. He offers, moreover, to submit — but on such conditions that the French will never consent to accept them. Gently persuasive, the prelate disputes in haggling where a canton is exchanged for 10,000 piastres to be deducted from the ransom. Slowly, the price to be paid for the freedom of the two Frenchmen is reduced by three-quarters. Has Tham so great a need of money, when he shall be master of villages already rich and that peace will render more opulent still?

The interviews continue for a fortnight. And the agreement, approved by the General Government, is at last concluded. Mgr Velasco returns to Bắc-Ninh.

Fifteen thousand piastres shall pay for the liberation of Chesnay and Logiou. The Dé Tham, submitted, receives, as in fief, the cantons of Mực-Sơn, Yên-Lễ, Hữu-Thượng, and Nhã-Nam, under the surveillance of a French delegate who shall reside at that place. These four cantons give the Dé Tham twenty-two villages, more than 2,600 inhabitants who, for three years, shall pay him the tax. All this from the 23rd of October 1894.

The following day, a convoy, duly escorted and guided by a pirate, arrives at the lair. The coolies bend under the weight of the ransom, which is paid in silver piastres, for the Dé Tham wishes to know nothing of the notes of the Bank of Indochina. Fifteen chests are soon lined up before him.

"Bam quan lon," says then the chief of the coolies, "will you deign to have the money counted and to set your honourable seal on the receipt I bring?"

"Open two chests," replies the Dé Tham, "and tell your men to take from them what they will."

The great general deigns to jest, no doubt. And, before the two opened chests, the sweating and gloomy coolies do not stir. Their gaze, for an instant lit with covetousness, soon freezes in the customary dullness. They know well that a bullet would crack the head of any who dared.

Now, the Dé Tham, plunging his hands into one of the chests, suddenly hurls handfuls of piastres at the coolies. For a brief moment he deigns to laugh at the fine battle that rages around the windfall, then suddenly he thunders:

"Out of here, all of you!"

And, that same evening, he sets Chesnay and Logiou free.

HOANG-THAM, PIRATE

PART THREE

ĐỀ THÁM SUBMITTED

AND NOTHING IS CHANGED

I — ĐỀ THÁM SUBMITTED

Tham is submitted.

And the military are not pleased. Oh, I know. It is ever easy to say that the pirates — that Đề Thám himself — are the soldier's providence, that columns of repression bring promotion and crosses. Indeed. All too often wooden crosses¹.

At any rate, General Duchemin judges that Upper Tonkin is sufficiently tainted by the two cankers that are the fiefs of Lương Tam Kỳ and Ba Kỳ — inviolate refuges for the pirate bands. It was hardly indicated to create there, for Đề Thám, a domain that touches the railway line. As it happens, eighteen officers' graves have been dug in Yên Thế from 1891 to — well, since the General Government has treated with the pirate, it thereby admits

his good faith. Pointless, from then on, to maintain troops in Yen Thế. Gallieni requests and obtains their withdrawal. And the native guard occupies the posts.

Tham is submitted. And the four cantons awarded to him constitute the whole of Upper Yen Thế. The bandit chief has become a gentleman-farmer. He is tranquil, satisfied, and the reports he maintains with the French delegate at Nhã Nam are of the most courteous. Visits, protocol gifts. The rice-fields returned to cultivation. Doubtless the pirates of the band have suddenly become peaceable *nha-qués*...

Certainly not. The people who labour on the glebe are those of the villages. Tham commands and they obey. They know well that a day will come when the great chief will take up the rifle again. Woe to those who might have balked at the work.

And there he is, bent over his toil — that peasant who, over yonder, swarms, resigned, instinctive and industrious, in truth the source of all wealth. He neither pillages nor steals, that creature with the frightened, cunning, ferreting gaze, who, rising from the mat on which he was born and which will serve as shroud for his corpse, leaves his poor hut at dawn and sets off, along the crest of the rice-field dikes, in Indian file with his companions — all ragged, all chattering on a high note, all bursting into laughter at nothing, just as though life were fair. As soon as the sun, high risen, begins to hammer hard, there he is alone in the rectangle which is his own, sunk to his belly in the mixture of water and mud, his legs constellated with

leeches, bent over the primitive plough — the cày — which disappears almost entirely into the mire, following his buffalo through the whirlwinds of mosquitoes, passive, silent, and as though curled into a stupor transmitted to him by the centuries of servitude of his ancestors, bent under the yoke of masters for whom the nha-qué was only the machine that makes the rice grow. At this moment, Đễ Thám is the chief. It is for him that the man ploughs and harrows, that the woman sows and transplants, and that all harvest the paddy. It is for him that they grow buckwheat, maize, and sweet potato. For him today, perhaps tomorrow for someone else.

What matter, so long as the buffalo lives, the woman, the children! What matter, so long as one can eat and the strokes of the rattan are rare!

And if, by chance, the chief one day orders them to abandon the plough for the rifle, the nha-qué will obey — ever passive, ever resigned, the ideal fighting man in the hands of him who takes charge of thinking for him.

But for a man who has held for months in his hands the Mauser, the Winchester, the Gras rifle, or the Lebel² — the return to the rice-field is a degradation. To be sure, the mandarin despises the man of war. What matter, since in the villages of Yen Thế and of many another region, great and petty notables tremble and bow before him who bears arms. Đễ Thám's men are not of those who scratch the mud following the buffalo. They are men of prey and wish to remain so. The honours and profits that the French — easy folk to dupe — have reserved for the great chief give

his lieutenants the hope of obtaining like advantages by becoming, in their turn, as redoubtable as he. Upper Yen Thế is submitted. Agreed. But are there not other regions, close by and just as impenetrable, where it is natural to earn one's living by fire and sword? How could Tham blame those who continue to walk in his glorious footsteps?

He could not deny his companions-in-arms, so faithful. And besides, he would not dare.

And so, while at Phong Xuong Đê Thám leads the life of a feudal lord, surrounded by his three wives, his son Ca-Trong, and a praetorian guard of armed partisans who, like him, live off the villages that constitute his fief — his lieutenants, scattered across a zone of which Upper Yen Thế is the centre, continue the carousel. Đê Thám's domain remains for them a sure refuge. How would we dare pursue them there without violating the word given to a bandit?

But of this refuge they will avail themselves only if they cannot do otherwise. There are, in Yen Thế, other secret lairs and complicit villages. And other forests are near which offer their dense thickets. The close-woven forest clothes, from foot to summit, the enormous massif of Tam Đảo with its three peaks — a monstrous green dragon couched upon the province of Vĩnh Yên and obsessing with its menace that of Thái Nguyên, whose name means "high origin" and which deserves its name. The eagle and the tiger alone can dispute the peaks of Tam Đảo with the pirates. On its slopes labour the woodcutters,

sawing the rare timbers: the tán mật and the thiết đỉnh, two of the four ironwoods that last for centuries, and the most precious ngọc am, pale yellow, with harmoniously drawn veins, from which are made the coffins of the richest Annamites. Fifteen years later, when France shall have put an end to piracy, Tam Đảo — which culminates at 1,300 metres — will see rise near its summit an upland station, sure and healthful, for the French of Tonkin.

But we are not there yet, and at the moment where we stand, Tam Đảo is nothing less than safe. Đền Nguyễn scours the region. In February 1895, his band attacks the two telegraphists Holley and Sabot. The first is killed, the second captured, and taken to Kê Thượng, to the lair of Ba Kỳ, who, as everyone knows, has humbly submitted to our authority... As for the malefactors of Yen Thế, they operate in Bảo Đáy, in Đông Triều, and, on occasion, in Tam Đảo, whose approaches are not pillage-ground reserved solely for the friends of Ba Kỳ.

But let us stay in the environs of Bắc Ninh. At the point where the Sông Thương, the Sông Cầu, the Sông Thái Bình, and the Canal des Rapides converge, the movement of junks never ceases. There rises the little town of Sept-Pagodes, and directly opposite, the village of Phả Lại. On the 23rd of March 1895, in the dead of night, sampans draw up before the village. Forty bandits disembark. A few instants later, the cai-nhas are ablaze, the nha-qués killed or in flight, and the pillagers, re-embarked, streak away in the direction of Bắc Ninh. The village of

Phả Lại is no more. Thông Luận, lieutenant of Đê Thám³, has erased it.

30 April, eleven o'clock at night. Spread around its great citadel, Bắc Ninh sleeps under the rain. All is calm in the town, and in its environs reigns tranquillity — I mean to say that the pirates content themselves with stealing a buffalo here and there, from time to time stripping a few isolated nha-qués on their way to market, occasionally assassinating some native couriers, and opening fire now and then on some militia detachment, bringing down two or three linhs without anyone knowing whence the shots came... Nothing out of the ordinary, in sum, and Bắc Ninh may sleep.

Moreover, here in the main street comes a militia patrol. Twelve men and a doi. All of fine bearing, marching in order and silent, arms at the sling. Suddenly they halt before the house of a rich Chinese merchant. Doubtless they wish to shelter a moment under the eaves, for the rain redoubles. But no: four men detach themselves from the group, and the doi himself places them — invisible sentinels — at the mouths of nearby alleys. Then, having extinguished the paraffin lantern that casts a vague light in that corner, he knocks at the Chinaman's door. No answer... Then the rifle-butts begin to hammer the panels, which are about to give.

The blows ring strangely in the night. In the neighbouring houses, Annamites and Chinese, awakened, refrain from intervening. But two Frenchmen — Moulhaud, a customs officer, and Gendarme Verdene — come run-

ning. Each carries a lantern whose gleam lights their silhouettes without managing to pierce the thick curtain of rain. But two flashes suddenly streak the darkness. Two dry detonations. The sentinels have fired, and the Frenchmen fall, killed clean, at point-blank range, each with a bullet in the head.

The gunshots have raised the alarm, and here comes, at full run, another gendarme, *Maréchal-des-Logis* Jean. Two bullets in the chest bring him down, and they finish him with the cutlass.

Then the Annamites melt into the darkness, while other Frenchmen run toward the citadel to give the alarm — too late. A militia section, arrived on the run, gathers up the corpses. The patrol of a moment ago, the patrol that killed, was only a detachment of pirates in disguise. Their *doi* was a lieutenant of *Đề Thám* — *Doc Thu* — and his brother *Doc Xuyet* accompanied him.

And here are other exploits.

Less than a thousand metres from *Phủ Lạng Thương* rises the village of *Phú Liễm*. The earth there is rich. Orange trees and mandarin trees flourish there, as do banana trees and lychees. The pagoda with the curved roof stands at the edge of a pond enamelled with lotus. A clump of areca palms dominates it, dusting the sky. By day, the people of *Phú Liễm* labour all around the village in the rice-fields or in the fields of sugar cane, sweet potatoes, maize, or beans. By night, they return to their *cai-nhas* and sleep tranquilly. *Phú Liễm* is a village of the

plain, a happy village with no history. Its palisade of living bamboo is all breached. What matter! Phủ Lạng Thương is close by, and its militia watches.

Now, a little before midnight on the 15th of September, the sentinels of Phủ Lạng Thương raise the alarm and the gong of warning resounds. In the countryside, flames have sprung up as from a hundred thousand torches. Phú Liễm is ablaze. A detachment of militiamen dashes out at a run to bring aid and soon hears the entire village howling its terror. Help arrives too late. The massacre has preceded the fire which illuminates a vision of horror. One would swear a band of furious beasts had passed that way. The butchery is unspeakable. Everywhere severed heads, hacked limbs, human debris strew the ground. The cut-throats have spared neither women nor children. The thatched roofs burned first. The mud walls collapsed. Only the half-calcined pillars of ironwood remain standing, those of the pagoda and of the richest cai-nhas. To those of the pagoda are bound the notables of Phú Liễm; to those of the cai-nhas are tied the wealthiest nha-qués: all in their death-agony, bellies opened by the cutlass. The buffaloes and the pigs have been bled like the men. Only a few dogs have escaped the carnage and lick the spilled blood...

A month earlier, the notables of Phú Liễm had refused money and rice to an emissary of Linh Túc, lieutenant of Đề Thám. That night, Linh Túc avenged himself.

The glow of the fires illuminates the meaning of Tham's message to Tôn Thất Thuyết: "Nothing is changed

in the huyện of Thiên Đức, even when all things appear transformed."

In other words, the piracy continues despite the submissions.

II — REPRESSION

In truth, extremely well-informed of our internal affairs, the pirates have profited from the governmental interregnum which lasted from the recall of Lanessan to the arrival of Rousseau.

For Lanessan, having, it appears, communicated to a third party who "had no right" to an official document, was dismissed abruptly, brutally, as one sends away an unwanted servant or an indiscreet functionary. A Havas telegram notified the sentence. A dry guillotine, wielded by a Government which, at that time, was too little versed in colonial matters to understand that the dismissal, without formality, of the Governor-General made us lose face in this country of Annam where the sense of hierarchies is like a religion — in this Indochina in the full crisis of growth. One must read all that Lyautey wrote about Lanessan⁴, all that I summarise in a few words. He was truly a "governor", full of life and audacity, energetic, tenacious, as supple as he was intelligent, riding roughshod over the chinoiserie of regulations, visiting the country, seeing everything himself, and leaving everywhere in his wake the sparks of the fire that burned within him.

To Lanessan succeeded Rousseau — a man of high culture, noble character, upright, scrupulous, and tenacious. A fortnight after his arrival in Tonkin, convinced of the necessity of the sanitation that Gallieni preached, the new Governor-General gave the order, and in eighteen days — from the 16th of April to the 4th of May 1895 — the fief of the submitted Ba Kỳ was cleansed. The lair of Kê Thượng, reputed impregnable, was in our hands. Ba Kỳ was in flight. And for the first time, a European was delivered without having to pay ransom, for the telegraphist Sabot was retaken from the pirates by surprise and by main force⁵. Gallieni was at the head of the columns of repression, and his Chief of Staff was named Lyautey.

Chased from Kê Thượng, the pirates naturally flowed back toward Yen Thế. But there too Gallieni gave the sweep of the broom. He operated slowly. He had to. Since Đề Thám was submitted, the General Government required that negotiations be held, and that took time. The submittee was begged to evacuate his fortified posts and surrender his arms. He was pressed to punish his lieutenants Doc Thu and Linh Túc himself, whose submission we refused to accept. He was asked to help the authorities enter into relations with the bands of Thông Luận and Thông Trứ. Letter followed letter. To each, Đề Thám replied most courteously that his good will was entire and that none could reproach him with anything. While taking care not to explain the doings of his lieutenants, he despatched them, with their bands, to the rear of our troops, to attempt to loosen the grip that was beginning to

trouble him. Doc Thu then operated in the newly created province of Bắc Giang⁶, whose capital is Phủ Lạng Thương, while Thông Luận and Thông Trứ, descended from Tam Đảo, fell upon the villages of the Đa Phúc region. Bands were reported at the approaches to the railway line.

In a book that is a model of clarity and concision⁷, Gallieni has related the operation that I here summarise, and for which that great chief had foreseen everything a human brain could foresee, and given orders that bear the stamp of his genius.

Đề Thám, with some 300 rifles, was solidly entrenched in the heart of the jungle. The exact location of the lair was unknown, but it was known to be somewhere inside the triangle entirely covered with impenetrable forest whose vertices are Bồ Hạ, Nhã Nam, and Mỏ Tràng⁸. Our troops occupied its three sides, then slowly, methodically, without leaving an inch of ground unexplored, they advanced. Marsouins, legionaries, marine artillerymen, engineer detachments, Tonkinese tirailleurs, militiamen, and armed partisans — all, under the command of Gallieni, searched the dark undergrowth. Each detachment remained linked to the neighbouring detachment, and little by little the investment tightened until the day — the 29th of November 1895 — when a rapid fire, falling upon two of our groups, showed them they were at the site and that the lair was there. It was in the very heart of the forest, at Bãi Mết, some two kilometres east of

Phong Xuong. The fort rested on the Arroyo Sông Sỏi. It was flanked by the two small forts of Lim Rừ and Hồ Koi.

Cutlass in hand, cutting their route through the vegetal tangle, pushing back the pirate outposts, seizing the advanced works, the groups converged on the stronghold of Đê Thám. Volleys, issuing from invisible redoubts, tried to check our advance. Our vanguards encountered the usual ambushes: poisoned stakes, triple palisades, wolf-pits, ditches hidden by brush. Sometimes, forced to halt, our men entrenched on the spot. The lair was invested, and no one would fall back. And now our mountain batteries of 80 mm. They had forced their passage through the jungle and stood before the forts. Shells of melinite, newly arrived from France, filled the caissons. And those shells, fired at point-blank range, wrought marvels. In the fort, the pirates howled their dismay. And the night of the 29th to the 30th of November fell upon the forest. All our soldiers kept watch, ready for the assault.

At dawn on the 30th, the artillery again thundered. Then the infantry drew near. Silence everywhere!

At eleven o'clock, our lads rushed to the attack. Not a rifle-shot answered their charge. The fort was empty. The forest had saved the bandits! They had slipped between our fingers at five in the morning through a thicket nearly impenetrable that separated two of our columns. A precipitate flight, for in the fort were found munitions in piles, tonnes of rice, and even the correspondence of Đê Thám...

Useless to give chase to the fugitives. They had hidden their arms and, scattered among the complicit villages, were impossible to find.

But, thus dispersed, the pirates were, for a time, in no state to do harm. Some twenty had been killed. A few presented themselves at Phủ Lạng Thương and surrendered their arms. The operation cost us exactly three dead — one marine infantryman and two tirailleurs — and about ten wounded, of whom only one European. Gallieni was sparing with his men's blood.

III — PURSUITS

The dissolved military columns had regained their garrisons. They now operated only within the four military territories⁹. The civil provinces had their own police. The dispersed bands of Đê Thám gradually reformed under the command of petty chiefs. Ever elusive, by virtue of the complicity of forest and mountain, they ravaged the provinces neighbouring Bắc Giang, where Yên Thế lies. But Yên Thế remained their rallying point.

The Tổng Đốc Lê Hoàn had once again taken the head of a police column that lived off the country while appearing to pursue the bands — whose existence was, in truth, for this mandarin, an inexhaustible source of profits and honours...

The native guard, for its part, did its best. The linhs of Bắc Ninh and those of Bắc Giang drove the pirates back toward Tam Đảo. At the foot of this massif and in the

middle valley of the Sông Công, in 1896, the militia fought sixteen times against the pirates. The hunt for the bandits was often hard and bloody. On the 20th of February, Inspector Burcklé¹⁰ was killed by the band of Thông Luận. On the 15th of September, near Đa Phúc, Principal Guard Racagel and the colonist Haguelon, an employee of the Gobert concession, were killed by Linh Túc's band. But the pirates no longer had an easy life of it, and about ten of Đề Thám's lieutenants finally surrendered, with their men. Linh Túc, Thông Luận, and Doc Ké submitted, as did Ca-Rinh, whom we shall meet again. Four hundred and forty-nine rifles thus fell into our hands. And Doc Thu — whom we saw operating in the heart of Bắc Ninh town — gravely wounded in a skirmish, killed himself.

In the month of December 1896, Governor-General Rousseau died. Two months later, his successor was named. It was Paul Doumer — the true creator of the Indochinese Union, the man who endowed our colony with the economic tools and industrial equipment that engendered its prosperity and made it definitively enter the path of modern progress.

Let us return to Đề Thám. Become a nomad by force, yet ever slipping between the fingers of his pursuers, he was reported in turn in the provinces of Bắc Ninh, Thái Nguyên, and Sơn Tây. But it was to Yên Thế — whose least paths and most secret hiding-places he knew — that Đề Thám finally returned to ground. Periodically, the newspapers of Tonkin announced his imminent capture or his submission. In truth, the boar remained unfindable in

his forest, but, ceaselessly hunted, he fled from one den to another, ever anxious and harried without respite, surrounded by faithful followers grown ever rarer. He dreamed of the fine days when he had been the master, recognised by us, of the four richest cantons of Yên Thế.

And at the beginning of February 1897 — Doumer had not yet taken up his post — the curé of Bì Nội brought to the Resident of Bắc Giang the pirate's oaths. "None shall henceforth be more faithful than he. He asks to surrender and that a truce be granted him urgently so that he may celebrate the feast of Tết¹¹. He swears to lead an exemplary existence in the concession that cannot fail to be granted him." There was no longer any question of a concession, replied the French authority: Đê Thám would have his life spared, nothing more.

Then Tham plunged once more into the bush. In the month of June, his son Ca-Trong killed, in an ambush, Principal Guard Beauvais. Immediately the pursuit resumed. A flying column of 150 linhs set out in chase. The militia of the neighbouring provinces of Bắc Giang, the military posts bordering the civil territory, were alerted. On the 22nd of September, the invulnerable Đê Thám, in flight toward Lạng Sơn, was surprised by a detachment commanded by Lieutenant Maurel and wounded in the right hand. At that moment, the band was reduced to about twenty rifles. Ceaselessly harried, it was at the end of its breath.

But here came a glimmer of hope. The Kỳ Đồng was in Yên Thế.

IV — THE CHILD OF THE MIRACLE

The Kỳ Đồng — is he the predestined man who will drive the French from Tonkin, restore the ancient kings, and give happiness to all?

This new Messiah, whose true name was Nguyễn Cam, showed from childhood extraordinary literary aptitudes. At the time of the conquest, at Nam Định, he raised the standard of revolt against our troops. Convinced that Nguyễn Cam could walk on water and that bullets passed through him without wounding him, the Tonkinese people called him Kỳ Đồng — the Child of the Miracle. In 1887, an order of the Resident of Tonkin sent the Kỳ Đồng to be educated at the Lycée of Algiers. He remained there nine years and, constantly frequenting Hàm Nghi, the ex-Emperor of Annam¹², learned at our expense the hatred of France.

Upon his return to Tonkin, he presented himself to Governor-General Doumer, proclaimed his gratitude toward our country and his devotion to its representatives. Then he betook himself to Yên Thế, under colour of exploiting, on joint account with a Frenchman, a territorial concession. In truth, it was the reputation of Đề Thám that drew him to those parts. Where find a better nucleus of rebellion than among the pirate bands?

No sooner installed than the Kỳ Đồng despatched throughout the delta emissaries supposedly charged with recruiting *nha-qués* to develop the rich lands of Yên Thế.

Strange labourers, these folk who, by the hundreds, left Lower Tonkin for the middle region without bringing their families. Few had the debonair and resigned aspect of the poor rice-field cultivator. And, astonishing thing, all were provided with sums of money which they remitted to the Kỳ Đồng. All believed, with rock-solid faith, in the supernatural power of this man. For he had spread everywhere poems and tracts in which it was said that a genie would soon deliver Tonkin — a genie that all true Tonkinese must aid and join.

The deliverance of Tonkin was, for Đề Thám, a secondary preoccupation; but around the Kỳ Đồng there were men — more than 3,000 in number — and money, that indispensable manna for the hunted pirate. As for the men, they would dig up all the hidden rifles. With the money, Tham would buy other arms and munitions. And the good life would resume. In truth, Đề Thám acted wisely in rallying to Yên Thế. Already, through emissaries, he had entered into liaison with the liberating genie. And this one had sent him funds, men, and arms.

But Doumer was well informed. He gave the order, and, one fine night, he who had been the miraculous child — seized by the battalion commander who commanded the circle of Yên Thế — was brought to Phủ Lạng Thương and embarked on a launch that made off immediately for Haiphong. At the same time, the chiefs of the villages situated on the Kỳ Đồng's concession were arrested and interned at Nhã Nam.

Later, the Kỳ Đồng, deported to Tahiti, would have all the time needed to meditate upon the dangers of a poorly-organised revolt.

Meanwhile, his partisans — henceforth without a guide and deprived of the support of the Yen Thế village chiefs — gradually took the road back to the delta. It was only put off, they thought: the Kỳ Đồng would return when he wished, and if the French took it into their heads to cut his throat, it would be wasted effort; for he was not one miracle short, and everyone knew that another head would immediately grow back upon his shoulders. Fortunately, the some three thousand deluded souls were a drop of water in the ocean of the healthy and industrious population of the Tonkinese delta.

V — SUBMISSION... YET AGAIN

Colonel Péroz, who commanded the circle of Yen Thế in 1897, has given a very vivid account, of fine literary quality¹³, of the submission of Đê Thám — a greatly romanticised account, moreover, and often inaccurate¹⁴.

The affair is simple enough. Governor-General Doumer wished to contract a loan of 200 million to undertake the great works of Indochina. But how to obtain from Parliament the vote of such a loan in favour of a country where piracy still reigned?

He must finish it, cost what it may. He must reduce Đê Thám or accept his submission. The battue for the pirate continued in Yen Thế. The militia posts and military posts

that encircled the region were multiplied or reinforced. The troops and the native guard were ordered to work together, regardless of the theoretical limits of their action. All must rush at the first sound of gunfire.

The Governor-General spent three days in Yen Thẽ. The chiefs of the suspect villages trembled. Such a visit boded, for them, nothing good. But truly the Lord Tham must be a very great personage indeed for the very high French mandarin who governed an empire to put himself out so for him.

Ong Tham himself was not a little flattered when he received — always through the intermediary of Mgr Velasco — notification of the fact that the Governor-General would accept his submission on condition that he hasten. Doubtless the pirate would once again demand suzerainty over the richest cantons of Yen Thẽ.

The moment would be ill-chosen. And Tham was too cunning not to understand this. Admirably informed, he knew himself surrounded by a tight network of armed watchers. Reduced by defections, his band was weary of a perpetual existence as hunted game. It behooved him, therefore, to show himself very humble. And, on the 13th of November 1897, Đễ Thám wrote to the Governor-General of Indochina:

"I have received from Monseigneur the Bishop of Bắc Ninh a letter in which he tells me that he has spoken to you in my favour so that I might submit to the Government, and that you have had the kindness to allow me

to make my submission in the interest of the general tranquillity."

The submission was immediately accepted. It was now a matter only of life spared, nothing more. Đề Thám received lands once again, always at Phong Xuong. A boon so unexpected that he gave thanks in these words: "I am like a sick man near death receiving a saving remedy."

VI — THE GREAT LAYS

The 17th of April 1901, the 29th day of the 2nd month of the 13th year of Thành Thái. The delegation at Nhã Nam was under arms. Toward it had flowed the mandarins of the province of Bắc Giang, the notables of the villages of Yên Thế — all those who, by curiosity or by order, must assist at the official surrender of the Lord Tham.

For forty months he had laid down his arms. For forty months he had lived, tranquil in appearance, on the concession that, by French generosity, was his. But he had not yet consented to perform the ritual act that consecrated submission. Never would he yield, thought the people of Yên Thế. Yet the hour had come.

Arriving from Phủ Lạng Thương, here come the great mandarins in long robes of ceremony — of silk or of brocaded gauze, drawn tight at the waist by the red belt with plaques of gold, tortoise-shell, or horn. All wear the Chinese boots, black with square toes. All are crowned with the hat which, seen from the front, seems a bishop's

mitre and falls at the back into a chignon-cover adorned with two cicada wings in great horizontal projection to right and left.

All are respectable and inflexible of aspect. All bow before our authority — certain of them knowing very well how to violate the laws as soon as the sum that such violation will bring is worth the trouble. They are ready to entertain any request, oral or written, provided the petitioner be rich enough to grease the eternally outstretched paws of the bodyguards, servants, and secretaries who swarm about them.

First comes Lê Hoàn — still young and still Tổng Đốc of Bắc Ninh. His robe is of blue silk without embroidery. Two parasols of pale blue quỳnh silk, from which hang eight multicoloured tassels, shelter his head, guarded from flies, mosquitoes, and other flying insects by three immense feather fans with long purple handles. His suite is made up of his secretary of command, his pipe-bearer, his betel-bearer, his cudgel-bearer, and a number of servants of lesser importance.

Here come the high functionaries of Bắc Giang: the Tuần Phủ, clad in green silk without embroidery; the Án Sát, whose black robe is embroidered with flowers and whose suite is enlarged by the executioner walking before a boy who carries the sabre. Here come the Đốc Học and the Thượng Tá¹⁵, dressed in brocaded gauze heightened with the red plastron bearing the stork embroidered amid clouds. The silk of their parasols is black, and their retinue is less important than that of the Tổng Đốc.

Then present themselves other lords with immoderate fingernails, but of lesser rank — the mandarins with a single parasol: the Tri Phủ¹⁶ of Lạng Giang and of Đa Phúc, their breasts displaying the stork in full flight, while the six Tri Huyện¹⁷ of the province flaunt on their plastrons only the white pheasant.

From the very high Tổng Đốc to the modest Tri Huyện, all are subtle functionaries, installed by us and understanding marvellously how to simplify the task of the French authority, while making life sufficiently hard for their administrated that the piastres flow into their coffers as into those of the Protectorate. Of their power they make adroit use, so that complaints remain rare enough that complainants may be questioned with strokes of the rattan. Subject to these local potentates, the *nha-quê* suffers nonetheless infinitely less than in the era before the conquest, when no curb restrained the exactions of the mandarins — extortionists by essence. Besides, someone must steal, else the Annamite would not understand, and the scrupulously honest native functionary would spoil the trade and lose face.

Tonkin, like Annam, was in a period of painful growth. Our Residents were still drowned in paperwork, entangled in hasty regulations that hampered white colonisation — but all full of ardour and good will, and scrupulously honest. The Europeans who live today in Tonkin or Annam do not know how heavy was the task of the French there during the twenty years that followed the conquest. Surrounded by an inert or hostile population, they worked

hard and died in droves. He who wishes to learn and to understand must read the works of Lyautey, of Gallieni, of Boissière, of Pouvoirville, and of Ajalbert. But the golden book remains to be written — that which will give the names of the colonists, the functionaries, and the soldiers who left their bones over there to prepare the fine reality of today¹⁸.

Let us return to Nhã Nam. Leaving their suites outside, the mandarins of the provinces have entered the delegation. Under the veranda are grouped the canton chiefs and the village chiefs — major notables and minor notables, hierarchised according to the most meticulous etiquette. Most are old, mummified by opium. All are dressed in the wide white trousers floating about their skeletal legs and the long tunic of black silk with high collar, tight sleeves, fastened on the left side by tiny spherical gilded buttons that engage in silk loops. All are crowned with the flat black turban. Dragging their leather sandals, they converse solemnly about unimportant matters, letting the conversation drop as soon as one of them touches upon the subject that preoccupies them all: the submission of the Đê Đốc Tham, about which it is prudent to hide one's opinion, for here no one trusts anyone.

On the esplanade, the entire native guard of Bắc Giang is drawn up, arms at rest — a dull line of khaki uniforms heightened by the blue belts. Bắc Ninh, Thái Nguyên, Lạng Sơn, and Sơn Tây have also sent detachments. The militiamen must be many to know the features of him who, in a few months perhaps, will be again the enemy.

The bugles sound "to the field," the militia presents arms. By the fine, great road oriented from South to North, which leads from Đáp Cầu to Nhã Nam, arrives at full speed the carriage that is awaited. It stops before the delegation, and the representatives of France descend. At the head walks Morel, Inspector of the Civil Services — small, lean, the silhouette and moustache of an officer. Quennec, Resident of France at Bắc Giang, accompanies him and dominates with his frame of a solid Breton, energetic and good. Then comes Chéon, Chief of Staff of the Superior Resident of Tonkin.

The mandarins of all classes are ranged for the welcome. After the deep salutations — spines bent to the limit of breaking — they have frozen into the immobility that etiquette imposes. On the plastrons of the robes trail the goatees of sparse white hairs. Crossed hands are hidden in the wide sleeves, from which emerge long, flat ivory tablets — tablets of composure, which it is fitting to fix with a vacant gaze, by the tradition ten centuries old that defines the rite of respect without expression: the body of marble and the spirit absent, whatever the duration of the ceremony.

Beyond the cordon of the militia, the crowd of natives of Nhã Nam and of the villages of Yên Thế is likewise frozen and silent. The linhs have grounded their arms. They await Đê Thám and his bands.

Here he is. He walks at the head of those who were his accomplices and remain his faithful. Is he a hunted beast? Is he a reduced chief, but keeping the pride of the man

who has fought and who was sometimes victor? Is his bearing so particular that, seeing him mingled with his men, one could say without possible error: "This one is the master"? Certainly not. From his companions, from the militiamen who stand there under arms, and from the crowd that gazes avidly, he differs only by his tall stature, his robust frame which might perhaps prove his Chinese ancestry, and his shaven head like those of the bonzes. With his long black tunic, his wide white trousers, his flat black turban, and the babouches that shoe his bare feet, he resembles, more than anything, a well-fed peasant. His heavy eyelids let filter a gaze more cunning than intelligent, with flashes of mocking good-nature.

Those who follow him — if they had not the high head of men who have borne arms — would be like the nha-qués of the rice-field or the woodcutters of the forest. Some former servants of Europeans have, however, kept the feline and servile bearing of boys and the small gestures of hands skilled at rifling drawers and pockets, or the aspect of insolent pimps of certain saïs¹⁹. Yet a few faces — those of Tinh, of Muoi, of Khâi, of Phong, of Mai, of Lộc, of Tiếp, of Hựu, that of Ca-Huynh especially — sweat the lowest ferocity. They are neither more nor less dangerous than the others. All have blood on their hands. All have pillaged, burned, massacred...

Before them are the band chiefs in tunics of linh green, embroidered with red, green and red belts, and salaccos. There they are, very docile and well aligned. The Án Sát of Bắc Giang presents them to the Resident. Then, in their

turn, they recite in a loud voice the names of their men and proffer the tablets where those names are inscribed.

Forty months earlier, the rifles of the pirates had been handed over at the post of Nhã Nam. Đê Thám kept fifteen, for his personal security. But, as it was important that all rites be observed, toward Đê Thám advanced the people of his suite — whose rags could be guessed beneath their ceremonial clothes. They brought the ceremonial sabre and the great seal, which were immediately received by the Án Sát, whose suite seized the multicoloured banners. That of Tham bore the character "vinh," which gives victory.

Then came the ritual gifts: the jars of alcohol, the rice, the hens, the eggs, and finally a cage containing two doves — symbols of peace and love. Before all these gestures, the French remained of stone.

Then Đê Thám advanced toward the group of whites and mandarins. He spoke.

"I, Hoàng Thám, of the village of Ngọc Cúc — I, your subject who fades in obscurity, full of fear, head lowered, have dared to raise my voice to you. Your generosity has deigned to grant me peace. Your goodness has been for me the rain falling upon the parched rice-field. I swear fidelity here and before the altar of my ancestors. I swear for myself and for those who follow me. They have all abandoned arms to resume the labours of the fields. And my heart is swollen with gratitude."

Then he fell to his knees and, abruptly projecting the upper part of his body forward, he abased himself, his forehead in the dust. Five times he performed the great lay, the ritual prostration — the gesture of very humble respect which, beyond all those present, addresses him who reigns at Huế, the Emperor who is at the centre of the support²⁰.

After Đê Thám, his lieutenants, all at once, executed the great lays. Then, by groups of ten and with a single movement as regular as the gestures of a ballet corps, those who had been the pirates five times prostrated themselves.

A few hours later, they had regained their lodgings at Phong Xuong, at Chợ Go, and in the villages round about.

More than two hundred rifles lay hidden there, waiting.

VII — IN PACIFIED YEN THẾ...

Four years have passed. We are in the fourth month of the 17th year of Thành Thái — May 1905.

Đê Thám lives tranquilly on his concession. Sometimes he stays at Phong Xuong, sometimes at Chợ Go, of which he is the first notable. The runner of the woods has become sedentary. He is a worthy retired man of piracy — a pious man, a faithful observer of the rites. Never does a village of Yen Thế call in vain his attention to the

dilapidation of the communal house or the pagoda. Tham at once supplies the wood and repairs, or has repairs done.

He maintains the best relations with the French authority, whose delegate resides at Nhã Nam. Relations spaced-out, it is true: only one visit in four years. But, in truth, Tham goes out so little. At most he goes, from time to time, to pass a few moments with one or another of his devoted partisans in some neighbouring hamlet. Admire his modesty: he is then accompanied only by six armed bodyguards, whereas he could bring fifteen, since, officially, he holds fifteen rifles.

Under his aegis, the lands of Yen Thế have become fertile again and the people of Yen Thế happy. Happy and rich. In the province of Bắc Giang, the taxes come in well. They even claim that piastres also enter — in the form of requisitions — into the coffers of Đề Thám. The people who set such rumours about are perfidious and slanderous. I know well that, during the four great ritual feasts and during the commemorative feasts of Hoàng Thám, he receives gifts. Nothing could be more regular, and none ignore that, of all possible presents, the most precious and the easiest to transport are those made of hard cash. And are not those gifts the sign of the happiness and gratitude of the nha-qués of Bắc Giang... and even from much farther afield, for they come also from the province of Bắc Ninh and even from the canton of Vũ Nhai, which is in the heart of Thái Nguyên?

Some Annamites and some French colonists are discontented. Agreed. But do you know a country where everyone is satisfied?

To be fair, let us hear one or two of these complainants.

Here, for instance, is the chief of the canton of Hương Vĩ. He affirms that in January two buffaloes from the village of Bồ Hạ disappeared. Their tracks were followed as far as Làng Mặc, which forms part of the canton of Hữu Thượng, which touches the concession of Đề Thám. Two buffaloes stolen! A fine affair! They must have been very ill-guarded, those animals... They must have strayed into the jungle and simply met the Lord Tiger. Besides, the canton chief is, as all know, an irreconcilable enemy of Đề Thám and accuses him of every crime committed in the region. A woman was stripped and murdered on the bridge that crosses the Sông Thương at 5 kilometres from Cao Thượng... Đề Thám is guilty. During the last Tết festivities, an armed robbery was committed at Bảo Lộc; people were killed by rifle-fire. Still Đề Thám. But no — Đề Thám had nothing to do with it. No one had anything to do with it, the official inquiry proved it. To hear this petty chief of a canton that encompasses barely four villages, Yên Thế trembles under the tyranny of Hoàng Thám, who, with a single word, could requisition anywhere any coolies he needed. Pure exaggeration. Tham requests, and each is free. Whoever wishes comes. And if, in the end, all consent, it is through love and respect for the great

venerated chief... And, in truth, this canton chief of Hường Vĩ has his heart blackened by lies.

More serious: French colonists complain. Ah! If one had to listen to the eternal complaints of the colonists, there would be no end to it, and the Administration has enough worries with the Annamites and the Chinese. What business is it of these "marsh-dwellers" who dare to clear land and pretend to exploit the soil of Yên Thế? Could they not settle in provinces long pacified? Why choose lands neighbouring the concession of Đê Thám? They know well that this man knows French law no more than Annamite law.

And, truly, one must have a twisted mind to hold it against him. His childhood as a buffalo-herd left Tham no time to study the Chinese characters and the Four Books of the Doctrine. Born in Yên Thế, militarily organised by the Emperors of Annam to bar the way against Chinese incursions, he abandoned his cattle only to fight against our troops at the time of the conquest and, after it, against us still as lieutenant of the great pirates. The only laws he ever saw applied were first the irrevocable decisions of Đê Nam, then his own — summary, brutal, definitive. A beast, even chained, does not obey like a dog. And we have not even known how to chain the beast.

Like the creatures of the forest, Tham is skittish, mistrustful, ready to bite, ready also for panic. Since his submission, he has come once — only once — to Nhã Nam to speak with the French delegate. On that day, the militiamen of the post had to be made to disappear, while

Đề Thám entered the delegation with his fifteen armed guards. For he has forgotten neither the cup of poisoned tea, nor the traps set for him by the Tổng Đốc of Bắc Ninh, nor Ba-Phuc's bomb. When he seems no longer to think of it, his lieutenants take charge of keeping alive his mistrust, which makes them indispensable. A morbid mistrust, mingled with a superstition that makes of the house at Phong Xuong a paradise for charlatans, sorcerers, and soothsayers.

Let us enter that house on a day in May 1905.

VIII — AT PHONG XUONG

It is not of wattle-and-daub mixed with straw, the dwelling of Đề Thám, but of solid brick. Its roof is of glazed tiles. It is a rich man's house, but, as everywhere, beaten earth is its only floor. Before the door rises the low wall that stops evil spirits and, if need be, bullets. As soon as this entrance is crossed, one is in the central room — the reception hall — which bamboo partitions separate from two side chambers. Behind the house are the outbuildings: kitchen, stable, cowshed, henhouse, and guardhouse.

In the centre of the room, a small table is flanked by two enormous benches of lim wood, well polished and varnished by greasy friction. On the wall, on panels lacquered black, blazes in large golden characters the vertical enumeration of the master's virtues, and, in columns of humbler writing, the names of the donors. Other panels, in red trắc wood, bear, inlaid in mother-of-

pearl, the four allegorical beasts: the dragon, the unicorn, the tortoise, and the phoenix²¹. In the corner of the blue dragon — which is the east, the side of pure light — rises the ancestral altar with the black tablet inlaid with mother-of-pearl, the wax flowers of violent colours, the incense sticks planted in the sand of a Chinese vase and spreading a subtle perfume, and the little bronze gong that is sounded before each meal to invite the souls of the dead to sit at table. In the centre of the room is the camp bed, of a single block of precious wood, with the fresh mats for the body, the *cái gổi* for the head, and the smoking-tray.

At the edge of the camp bed, Tham is seated, scratching himself pensively. At the door, a voice rises.

"O great general, your servant Diên An is here."

"Let him enter."

And here is Diên An. He carries the four precious objects: the brush, the rice-paper, the ink-stick, and the ink-stone. Having set them on the table, he bows, retreats to the wall, and, respectfully, summarises the news given by the newspapers of Tonkin. Today, as every day for months, there is talk of the Russo-Japanese War. Of the great victory of Liaoyang, the local sheets scarcely speak. But the Chinese newspapers have sung the high deeds of the Army of the Rising Sun. The Mikado triumphs over the white Tsar. Good news, in sum — on which Diên An insists so that the master may receive with serenity what follows, which is less cheering. It is, in three columns of the newspaper *L'Avenir du Tonkin*, a long indictment

against Đê Thám. The author is M. de Baïx, a colonist of Yen Thố... He resurrects old grievances, exhumes affairs long since settled. Tham is livid with anger. He detests seeing the Tonkinese press occupy itself with Yen Thố... This de Baïx is truly intolerable. During the last visit of Đê Thám to the delegate at Nhã Nam, did he not dare to interrupt the audience and launch into an undignified tirade? Fortunately, Mgr Velasco was present — and it was above all to greet him that Tham had left his fief. Ong Velasco would testify to the pure intentions of the submittee and his men...

While Diên An was reading the press news, four men — so familiar that none announced them — have entered the home of Đê Thám. Crouched in the Annamite fashion, they have listened, impassive. They know well that, of all they have heard, only the Japanese victories matter. These four men are: Ca-Trong, son of Đê Thám and his first wife Thị Tao; Ca-Rinh and Ca-Huynh, whom the master has adopted; and the handsome Ba-Biểu, with his androgyne body, his delicate legs, his perfumed chignon — a ferocious beast in the mask of a vicious boy. Diên An having finished his report, Ca-Trong rises.

"Most venerated father, here is a letter brought from Nhã Nam."

At a gesture from the master, the paper is transmitted to Diên An, who reads it at once. Through the native secretary of the delegate at Nhã Nam, one of the notables has learned this: the French still expect that Đê Thám will

betake himself to Phủ Lạng Thương first, to greet the Resident of France, then to Hanoi to render homage to the Governor-General.

"The Governor-General came to Yen Thế," murmurs Tham. "It will be necessary that one day I go yonder."

Which of the four men will dare to answer? Ba-Biểu is on his feet. Beneath his eyebrows, plucked until only the thin line of courtesans remains, his eyes full of a hypocritical caress regard the master. And his soft voice rises.

"Thou shalt not go, O venerated ancestor. Thou shalt not go because thou knowest that the French and all the Lu dogs of Annamites who lick their hands set traps for thee, as already they have set them. Thou shalt not go because here, in Yen Thế, and elsewhere also, all admire thy warlike exploits and are ready to aid thee in all that thou shalt command. Before thy thousand and ten thousand partisans, thou must not lose face. Thou shalt not go because it is here only, in our midst, that thou canst be happy and feel thyself in safety."

"I shall not go," answers Đề Thám.

For he knows well that he would risk death in leaving his faithful. He is their chief, but he is also their prisoner. For them, his departure would be a flight, and from one of the thickets of the forest would come a rifle-shot that would bring down the fugitive...

Now, while Ba-Biểu was speaking, a woman has entered. Pretty, slender, painted and smiling, she advances, harmonious in her lascivious swaying. Then she stops; disdaining to crouch before the master, she remains erect as a statue of bronze, proud. Three collars of red gold encircle her neck. The bands of her black hair, parted by a line that one might call light, seem lacquered. Her long tunic with tight sleeves is of blue silk, and her flowing trousers of white silk. Her graceful arms hang along her body and, according to the ritual of dances, her hands with nails sheathed in silver make a right angle with her wrists adorned with jade bracelets. This woman is Cô Ba, third wife and favourite of Đễ Thám — Cô Ba, kneaded of frantic ambition and bravery, expert in the handling of the carbine and the revolver, and a sorceress into the bargain. Her feline eyes — wicked, penetrating — give the lie to the grace of her smile. Hear her.

"Thou art mistaken, Ba-Biểu. My master will go to Phủ Lạng Thương and to Hanoi. He will go at the moment he shall have chosen, at the head of ten thousand faithful, and will hurl the French out of Annam."

Tham says not a word. And Ba-Biểu whispers.

"Be silent, O precious stone. The hour has not come."

"O great man," says Ca-Trong then, "hundreds and hundreds of writings have been brought from China and from Japan. They relate, with a hundred thousand details, the victories of the Empire of the Rising Sun."

"Let them be spread throughout my villages," orders Đê Thám. "Let them be distributed in all the cantons of Bắc Giang, Bắc Ninh, Lạng Sơn, Vĩnh Yên. Let them everywhere be read to the four classes of the people and to the peasants of the four conditions²²."

And soon, in all the villages, those who know the characters read the writings of the victorious yellows. Everywhere the tracts penetrate. The discontented lettered — I mean all those whom the administration cannot employ, for they are too many — comment in their hateful manner upon the papers come from China. "The French," they say, "are rapacious vultures who strip the Annamites of their money to send it to France and keep the people in ignorance and slavery the better to exploit them. The French are ferocious beasts avid for blood, dogs full of cowardice who would flee before the people if they revolted against their state of servitude, in which they have been held since the conquest..."

The nha-qué listens curiously and is astonished. It was before the conquest that he knew slavery and ferocious beasts. Never will the man of the rice-field — the gentle peasant of Tonkin — betray those who protect him. But among the lettered, the artisans, and the merchants of the towns, the bad seed is going to germinate.

And Đê Thám awaits the hour of the harvest.

NOTES

¹ The Lebel rifle, arrived in Tonkin in 1890, was given at once to the marine infantry regiments. The Tonkinese tirailleurs received it only in 1895. But a year earlier, some were found in the hands of a few pirates.

² The Lebel rifle, arrived in Tonkin in 1890, was given at once to the marine infantry regiments. The Tonkinese tirailleurs received it only in 1895. But a year earlier, some were found in the hands of a few pirates.

³ The band of Thông Luận was sometimes at the orders of Đề Thám, sometimes at the disposal of Ba Kỳ.

⁴ Letters from Tonkin and Madagascar, vol. I, p. 98 et seq.

⁵ By the detachment of Captain Bulleux, commanding the post of Bắc Kạn, newly created by Gallieni.

⁶ By decree of 10 October 1895, signed Rousseau. The new province is composed of the two phủ (prefectures) of Lạng Giang and Đa Phúc, and the six huyện (arrondissements) of Yên Dũng, Việt Yên, Kim Anh, Yên Thế, and Hiệp Hòa. The police of the province is constituted by 423 linhs and 327 linh-cơ (mandarin guards) furnished by the province of Bắc Ninh.

⁷ General Gallieni, *Trois colonnes au Tonkin*, 1894-1895, Paris, Chapelot, 1899.

⁸ See the sketch-map p. 201.

⁹ 1st Military Territory: Sept-Pagodes, Móng Cái; 2nd Territory: Lạng Sơn; 3rd Territory: Hà Giang-Tuyên Quang; 4th Territory: Lào Cai.

¹⁰ The European cadres of the native guard are composed of principal inspectors, inspectors of 1st, 2nd, and 3rd class, principal guards of 1st, 2nd, and 3rd class, and probationary principal guards. The native non-commissioned officers are the phó quản (adjutants), the doi (sergeants), and the cai (corporals).

¹¹ Tết is the Annamite New Year festival. It is the greatest festival of the year. It falls between the 20th of January and the 10th of February, according to the Chinese calendar, which ten centuries of domination have imposed upon the Annamites. The rejoicings of Tết last several days.

¹² See the note on page 55.

¹³ "Le dernier grand pirate," *Revue de Paris*, August-September, 1911.

¹⁴ Especially concerning the history of Đề Thám before 1897. Colonel Péroz in particular confuses Ba Kỳ, a Chinese bandit chief, with Ba-Phuc.

¹⁵ The Tuần Phủ is the governor of a secondary province; the Án Sát is the chief justice; the Đốc Học is the head of education; and the Thượng Tá is the counsellor of the French Resident of the province.

¹⁶ Prefects of Lạng Giang and Đa Phúc, subdivisions of the province of Bắc Giang.

¹⁷ Chiefs of the huyện (arrondissements) of the province, which are the huyện of Yên Thế, Yên Dũng, Việt Yên, Kim Anh, Hiệp Hòa, and Phượng Nhãn.

¹⁸ The work has been begun. The Militia has its golden book. M. E. Daurès, Principal Inspector of the Native Guard (retired), has just published *La garde indigène de l'Indochine de sa création à nos jours* (Avignon, Séguin, 1933).

¹⁹ Coachmen.

²⁰ Annam is as the support of the two baskets of rice that are Tonkin and Cochinchina.

²¹ The dragon symbolises power and nobility; the unicorn is the sign of prosperity; the tortoise is the sign of longevity; and the phoenix is the sign of beauty and elegance.

²² The four classes of the people are: the lettered, the cultivators, the artisans, and the merchants. The peasants of the four conditions are: fishermen, woodcutters, farmers, and shepherds.

HOANG-THAM, PIRATE

PART FOUR

PAR LE FER ET PAR LE POISON

BY THE SWORD AND BY POISON

I — THE BAD SEED GERMINATES

September 1905. The treaty of peace has consecrated the victory of the Japanese. A yellow people has triumphed over the army of the white Tsar, the army that men believed invincible. The Far East stirs. In Tokyo, in Yokohama, they are organising the insurrection that will drive the French out of Indochina. Those who prepare the revolt are not Japanese. The Mikado's Government is correct.

But in Japan lives Prince Cuong-Dé, who wishes to overthrow the Emperor of Annam and take his place. Beside him works the agitator Phan-Boi-Chau. Around them gravitate hundreds of Annamites: lettered men and sons of mandarins. Their stay in Japan and their study expenses are paid by associations in Annam and Tonkin which call themselves Societies for Commercial and Historical Instruction but are in reality secret revolutionary

hearths. They gather native auxiliaries, Annamite soldiers, interpreters, and above all lettered men who proclaim their hatred of France.

Everywhere seditious pamphlets spread. Tonkin is flooded with them. What do they say?

"An understanding with Japan, Siam, Yunnan and Quang-Tung will allow us to fight the French dogs. In the interior of the country, we must seek the means to combat to the uttermost. He who wishes to go abroad to study must be encouraged. He who can serve us by his fortune must be sounded out.... You, interpreters and lettered men, to aid us, secretly observe the situation and intentions of the French Government. You, cantonal and communal authorities, seek the means to deceive your chiefs and turn against them. You, servants, seek the means to assassinate your masters. You, women who live with Frenchmen, poison them..."

Brochures more venomous still circulate. They are, like the tracts, carefully sent to mandarins in office.

Thus two parties form in Tonkin.

Against us are united all those to whom a political crisis would permit the glutting of their rancours and their appetites. Among them are some members of the reigning family, mandarins and lettered men without employment, malcontents and intriguers of every class, and many employees of the administration and of commerce. These last speak French and, at a stroke, believe themselves

saturated with all the science of the West and capable of taking our place everywhere and of overthrowing the old mandarin organisation, battered, without strength and without respect.

Opposed to our enemies stands the healthy element. The mandarin in office cannot separate from us; he supports us because we support him. The merchant is also of our side. He owes his wealth to French order. Finally, the *nha-qué*, the man of the rice-field, more than all others, dreads upheavals. He has no ideal other than his land, his wife, his children, his daily pittance and his tranquillity. As long as calm reigns, he eats, and when he has eaten, he is happy. Only the seasons regulate his hard labour. They bring also the ceremonies which, in the poorest village, celebrate the smallest circumstances of time and life: feasts of the new year, rejoicings that mark the beginning of each season and the middle of autumn, the anniversary of the birth and death of the tutelary genius of the commune, feasts given in honour of that genius every time the moon is full or new. On those days the poor mud-backed one dons his ceremonial clothes whose vivid colours somehow never manage to be gay. He assists, without understanding a thing, at the ritual ceremonies, he joins the processions. And, felicity without alloy, the day ends with the absorption — chopsticks wielded at top speed — of all the foods brought in offering to the pagoda. The *nha-qué* stuffs himself to the limit of fullness. Supreme delights. Joys that peace assures and that cease when comes the famine which war, revolt

and political crises engender. In truth, every change brings blood and ruin. And the poor, gentle nha-qué is the first struck.

The apostolate of the rebels has no effect in the countryside. It succeeds better in the towns where, far too often, the local French newspapers attack the administration for the most insignificant motives. Certain sheets declare our functionaries lazy and incapable. They pity the poor Annamites crushed by taxes! and, the same day, treat them as monkeys, thieves, schemers and lousy wretches... And the Annamite, always ready to lend credence to what is written, feels rising in him contempt for our authority and hatred for our race.

Worse still, no one feels protected any longer against criminals. Inexpiable folly: it is the French code that is applied to the Annamites of Hanoi and Haiphong, which is to say that repression is null. The culprit scoffs at the fine he is always incapable of paying. Prison delights him: well-fed and well-treated, he rests there. Only decapitation is, for the Annamite, an infamous punishment. But they never decapitate.

Yet, in the provinces, it is the mandarins who judge harshly, without pity. But the Fourth Chamber of the Court of Appeal of Hanoi hastens to soften the sentences... From then on, all respect is abolished towards the mandarins, henceforth without force. Everywhere the number of crimes increases.

The ground is, in truth, ready to receive the bad seed.

In the towns the insurrection organises. Outside the towns, the *nha-qué* remains inert, but the hope of the leaders is based on the support of the pirate bands. There exists one man who ceaselessly corresponds with the malefactors of every Tonkinese region and would know, when need arises, how to unleash them at the chosen moment.

That man is the *Dé Tham* — the *Dé Tham*, always submissive and ceaselessly protesting his fidelity towards us.

II — AUDIENCES

The year 1907 opens upon evil omens. Sorcerers and bonzes predict calamities: misfortune is to fall upon the land the whites dominate. Among the lettered, a password circulates: "Unite to fight them."

The *Yen-Thé* is peopling. I say "the *Yen-Thé*", but from now on and throughout all that follows, this word will designate only that part of the *arrondissement* granted to the *Dé Tham*. At *Phong-Xuong* where he lives, at *Cho-Go* where dwells the beautiful *Co-Ba*, at *Lang-Nua* where once stood the fort of *Huu-Thué*, in the fortified *traï* villages where live the *Dé Tham*'s two other women, in the *traï* where his adopted sons are lodged, one meets strange figures. These are neither *nha-qués* nor subdued pirates. And truly the *Yen-Thé* rarely sees such guests. The dead-leaf face of the forest lads contrasts with the waxen complexion of the newcomers. These are lettered men,

come in number from the provinces of Annam and Tonkin, all without employment, all proud of a knowledge that will lift them to the foremost posts of the empire, when the emperor shall be called Cuong-Dé... These lettered men have all the confidence of Tham the illiterate, who lodges them at Phong-Xuong.

In the *traï* that Ca-Rinh occupies with Ca-Huynh and old Ly-Thu are housed forty Chinese come from the Two Quangs — Chinese luxuriously dressed and smiling ceaselessly with that yellow smile which lights no face, for the eyes remain searching, cold, cruel. All obey their compatriot Long-Tu-Xuan, a reformist chief, former lieutenant of Marshal Sou and a great friend of the Dé Tham. All these Chinese are armed, and truly this *traï* would be well defended against attack, for Ca-Rinh is at the head of twenty-five rifles, Ca-Huynh's troop numbers forty and Ly-Thu's fifteen.

At Lang-Thuong, the *traï* of the master's first wife, reside Thos come from the Black River and the province of Tuyen-Quang. These are tall and muscular fellows, with wide-open eyes, men of the bush who never part with their cutlasses in their wooden sheaths, rough souls, resigned, people whom the Annamite and the Chinese exploit without mercy, tireless marchers and porters — precious recruits for the hour when one will dig up the four hundred rifles hidden in the deep jungle two hours' march from Phong-Xuong, in the fortified hamlets.

But it is not yet a question of taking up arms. The fruit is not ripe. Yet soon, perhaps... We are now in the month

of August 1907. It is the seventh month of the nineteenth year of Thanh-Thai, and the following month will see the dawn of the first year of the Emperor Duy-Tan. The fifth year of the proconsulate of Governor-General Beau draws to its close, for Beau succeeded Doumer on the 15th of October 1902.

This present day is the Dé Tham's audience day. Those who wish to see him are many, and the master has decided to receive them in the communal house, the dinh of Phong-Xuong.

It is a great square hall. Strong pillars of light-brown tan-mat wood support the tiled roof and mark out aisles. In the centre aisle rises the altar of the tutelary genius of the village. Four camp beds and benches furnish the hall.

Around the Dé Tham are his bodyguards, his secretaries and his sorcerer. Here and there, in groups, converse the chief's faithful and the notable guests of the Yen-Thé: lettered men of Annam, Chinese surrounding their chief Xuan — paunchy and of pacific aspect, clad in heliotrope silk, crowned with a false panama, shod in shoes of thick felt sole. Outside, about thirty visitors await the chief's pleasure, sheltered as best they can be from the heavy, incessant rain by the sort of veranda formed by the roof extended as an overhang.

Near the Dé Tham are seated two men whom it behoves us to examine closely. One of them has been, for some months, the confidant of the lord of the Yen-Thé. His name is Ly-Nho. This former ly-truong of a village of

Ha-Dong, the suburban province of Hanoi, is in that province the agent charged with preparing the revolt against France. He has rather the appearance of a sickly nha-qué than that of an insurrection chief. The other is the Doi-Ho, an old habitué of Phong-Xuong, former sergeant of tirailleurs, former overseer of Dr. Gillard's concession, which lies in the Yen-Thé. He is a man of age and experience, intelligent and full of energy. He possesses all the confidence of the great chief.

The Dé Tham makes a sign and, under the furtive gaze of Ca-Trong, under the eyes of Ca-Rinh — ardent, wide-open and of a simian mobility — the visitors file before the master. All offer gifts and hear the same declaration:

"Prince Cuong-Dé is ready to come and reign over Annam. I count on you to march against the French. How many partisans can you recruit?"

When the man has answered, the Dé Tham adds:

"You must enrol yourself in the Ngia-Hing Society which I have founded to aid those of our people who are in Japan and are learning the science of beating the whites. Give fifty piastres to my treasurer and you shall be inscribed."

The tax is heavy. It is added to a number of piastres already extorted. For each visitor, excepting of course recognised and known friends, must, before gaining access to the Dé Tham, pass through the hands of the brother of the beautiful Co-Ba, whose name is Can and whose hands are expert at searching the newcomer and

gently stripping him of every object worth pocketing. Then, if the man's face inspires confidence, he is led to the post of Ca-Trong for a more minute and even more costly examination. That done, the wretch is sent back with these words: "Good, you shall see Ong Tham, but first bring a suitable gift."

Who would dare complain? One speaks to the great chief only in the presence of his faithful, who miss not a word. One day, however, a notable emissary began to describe the introductory ceremonial, thinking perhaps that the chief was ignorant of its rites. Tham cut him short from the first words:

"Bah!" he said, "these are my faithful and brave children."

But here come two visitors of importance. Ly-Nho rushes forward and presents them himself to the Dé Tham.

"O great mandarin, here is Lang-Seo, the celebrated sorcerer of the Rue des Voiles, and here is his brother Lang-Lan the tailor. I have spoken to you already of these faithful ones. Lang-Seo is a man full of learning. In him all our partisans of Hanoi have entire confidence. I have brought him here so that he may hear your orders. He implores you to accept these two sentences which a very old and very learned professor of characters has written for you."

The sorcerer then unrolls two panels of very sumptuous red silk whereon the sentences are embroidered.

In the silence Ly-Nho chants:

"Protect the Northern coast, defend the Southern coast of Annam. The reputation of the Dé-Doc Tham spreads over ten thousand lands."

"Only the Dé Tham may be compared to the genii who exterminated the Nguyen dynasty and suppressed that of the An."

"I thank the diviner and his brother," replies the Dé Tham. "Let them stay near me today. I shall speak with them presently, at the pagoda."

Ly-Nho continues to present emissaries he has brought to Phong-Xuong. Here is the student Dau-Xu, who was received first at the examination of the province of Ha-Dong. Here is Do-Dam, a lettered man without employment, ready for any task. Here is Ong-Bay, a physician of the Rue des Changeurs in Hanoi. This one speaks low and brief: "O great man, thirty rifles and ten cases of cartridges will be carried to Cho-Go in two nights."

The audience is ended.

"Let us go to the pagoda," says the Dé Tham.

III — THE ORDERS

Passing between the stone horse and the stone elephant which serve the spirits for travelling between earth and heaven, only the familiars of the great chief and the partisans of note enter the pagoda of Phong-Xuong,

freshly whitewashed, whose glazed tiles the rain washes and rewashes on the horned roof. In the interior shadow gleams the reflection of golds and lacquers, the shimmer of silk bands in vivid colours embroidered with sentences, flowers and symbolic animals. In incense-burners sticks of incense smoulder. On the altar of precious carved wood, around the tablet of Confucius, are deposited the votive objects suitably arranged and the offerings: alcohol, meat, betel, flowers and fruits.

The Dé Tham deposits them on the altar, then, having rinsed his mouth, he chants:

"Above, in the centre and below, all must be clear and pure. I am between heaven and earth like all animals, like all plants. The smoke of the incense rises into space and becomes pure air, then the subtle and powerful ether, essence of the Buddha, spirit of the Buddha; it will reach as far as the third planet. I invoke Ngoc-Hoang, the Jade Emperor, and I believe I see him appear before me. He will grant my prayer, he will have pity on me, for his heart is vast as heaven and earth and resplendent as the moon and the sun.

"And now listen well. All those whose hearts are rightly placed must execute my orders. These are the orders of Ky-Ngoai-Haoi, who will come from Japan and will reign over Annam when the French have been driven from the land. You must push to revolt the four classes of the people, the peasants of the four condi-

tions, and all the soldiers of our race who serve under the French banner.

"You, Nguyen, who come from Thanh-Hoa, you shall speak to the Muongs of that province and to those of Hoa-Binh. You, Dau-Xu, and you, Quach-Hop, you shall enrol likewise the Muongs of the Black River and the Thos of Hung-Hoa.

"You, Ly-Nho, I name you general-in-chief. Here is your title of *thong-thuong* with the sabre and the seal. Here is a great cachet and a small cachet with which you and Do-Dam the lettered man shall seal military brevets for the most worthy.

"And here for my two troop commanders, Lang-Seo the sorcerer and his brother the tailor, are titles of *tan-ly* and *tan-thung*. Act, all of you, and I will aid you, and my faithful Doi-Ho will aid you."

All salute and withdraw. They are about to depart to execute their occult and evil work.

Mark them well. These people hate France and hate each other far more. Soon, after the failure of two criminal attempts, some will accuse others before French justice and heads will fall: the heads of Lang-Seo the sorcerer, of Do-Dam the lettered man, of Doi-Ho, and ten other heads, for the greatest good of the land of Indochina.

But, beforehand, Lang-Seo, the sorcerer of the Rue des Voiles, will have slain the general-in-chief Ly-Nho and the Muong chief Quach-Hop.

IV — THE SORCERER OF THE RUE DES VOILES

Lang-Seo dwells at Number 51 of the Rue des Voiles, which, over three hundred metres in length, runs from the Rue des Pavillons-Noirs to the Rue des Cantonais, in Hanoi.

Lang-Seo is famous throughout the whole city. He knows magic thoroughly — that supreme science which sums all sciences, science of happiness and misfortune, of death and of life. Like a rat three centuries old, Lang-Seo sees through walls. He enslaves spirits. Each night, during the third and fourth watches, he betakes himself to the cemetery, and the fireflies, which are wandering souls, hasten at his call to aid him in his magical operations. He knows the stars and the genii. He excels at expelling evil spirits from haunted houses, and his friends say he will know how to drive the detested whites from the land.

Lang-Seo sells very dear the knucklebones of the "noble master", of the "prince", of the "general" before whom all animals kneel, while the jungle, that his eyes illuminate, trembles beneath his roar as beneath the onslaught of the typhoon. But the Lord Tiger — may he forgive me for calling him by his vulgar name — prudently turns about before whoever carries a knucklebone. Lang-Seo sells very dear those thunder-stones which, as none ignores, spring from the soil a hundred days after the storm, at the exact spot where the lightning

struck: most precious stones, for they preserve man from thunder and silk-worms from death.

Lang-Seo knows the incantations that heal and the rites of the death-spell that kills. The amulets he traffics in have sovereign power. He has not his equal for ridding people of their nightmares by means of the talisman of the White Serpent, whose image he traces himself on sacred paper, with vermilion mixed with the blood of a yellow eel.

In truth, Lang-Seo is a powerful and dreaded diviner.

Great is the number of Annamites of every class who frequent his house. Such an influx might awaken the suspicions of the Hanoi police. But the Rue des Voiles swarms with the native clientele that peoples, at every hour of the day, a score of Chinese eating-houses and restaurants. And the sorcerer's visitors are drowned in the crowd.

They enter on this evening in May and are straightway introduced into the chamber of incantations.

The room is red, the walls are red, the hangings are red, and red is the lacquer of the furniture. Red is the colour of fire, of the sun, of all forces that drive away phantoms and demons, beings of darkness. The chamber is cluttered with sorcery accessories: flags of the five elements, wooden swords, cudgels of every sort for thrashing incarnate demons, rattles and gongs whose noise frightens evil genii, amulets of every virtue. By the hundreds lie spell-statuettes, all decapitated. All represent

Frenchmen. The light is veiled and discreet. The odour of incense-sticks catches at the throat.

Lang-Seo, after the necessary ablutions, gravely officiates. He first conjures the evil spirits with the torch of thirty-six bamboo slivers, whose fire disperses malevolent influences. Then, having pronounced the incantation which precedes every ceremony, he convokes the three patrons of sorcery and the five tigers that are at the orders of the diviners, and respectfully calls to his aid the immortal gods, the saints and the omnipotent genii whose statuettes the altar bears: Tich-Gia-Mau-Ni-Phat (Gakiamouni), Khong-Tu, preceptor of kings, Lao-Quan, great master of the doctrine of Tao, the genius of the kitchen, that of the soil, and the five genii of thunder. On a table lower than the altar he then places the offerings and lights a ritual lamp.

And all the assistants, one by one, solemnly, bind themselves to kill or drive out the French and to keep secret the decisions that are about to be taken.

"Before the lamp that shines I swear. If I fail in my oath, I shall die as it is extinguished."

Thus speak the general-in-chief, the lettered man, the Muong chief and, after them, many others: non-commissioned officers and native gunners of the 4th Artillery Regiment, Tonkinese tirailleurs, students, a merchant of greasy water and a timber merchant, lettered men come from Annam — all leaders of the revolt that must be unleashed at once.

Ly-Nho is about to speak — Ly-Nho, whom the Dé Tham has named general-in-chief, wherefore the sorcerer of the Rue des Voiles holds him in profound hatred. The said sorcerer is a master diplomat after the yellow manner. Hear him:

"O elder brother, before telling us your will, deign to hear the faithful Co-Tai. She has arrived from the Yen-Thé with a letter from the Dé-Doc Tham."

Here is Co-Tai, slender and lithe. Her face, of an almost European oval, is pitted with smallpox. She is elegant but wears no jewellery. Expert in the art of disguise, she assures liaison between the Dé Tham and the agitators of Hanoi. In the train of Phu-Lang-Thuong, what policeman would suspect this little *nha-qué* who, baskets in hand, goes from one market to another? And on the roads of the Yen-Thé, what militiaman would think of stopping this young woman who travels in a rice-field rickshaw with its hood a hundred times patched, its springs mended with string, its wheels squeaking, its seat spitting out horsehair — a vehicle pulled and pushed by two emaciated coolies who trot without tiring for hours and hours, two coolies who are two men of the Dé Tham, revolvers concealed, ready for anything.

Co-Tai speaks in a low voice. Only the sorcerer and the general can hear.

"O elder brother," she says to Ly-Nho, "the anger of the Lord Tham is not calmed. He will pardon you your

failure of the tenth month if you repair it without delay."

"I must," replies the general-in-chief, "await a favourable day."

"O great mandarin," retorts the sorcerer, "that is my affair and, presently, I shall indicate to you the favourable date."

"I bring also an order," says Co-Tai.

Ly-Nho runs his eyes over it, then, aloud, so that none may be ignorant:

"Here is what the Dé-Doc Tham writes: 'The commander-in-chief of the troops of Tonkin says that His Majesty Cuong-Dé orders that the recovery of the country be carried out in the course of this year. The principal chiefs are invited to do what they judge useful to procure the money necessary for the expenses of the war.'"

A silence. Then the sorcerer Lang-Seo speaks:

"Concerning the money, all is simple. When our faithful shall have taken Hanoi, the bank and the treasury will be ours. Will the general-in-chief deign to tell us what he has decided?"

And, saying this, the diviner reckons that Ly-Nho will immediately lose face. But the latter replies:

"All is ready. In the province of Ha-Dong, which girds Hanoi, my partisans await only my signal. The other

provinces are ready to rise, and the Dé-Doc Tham, I know, takes charge of taking Dap-Cau and the province of Bac-Giang. His lieutenants Ca and Thiet will come to Gia-Lam with their men. Our brothers of the artillery and the tirailleurs of Hanoi will come out of the citadel to clasp the hands of the assailants. I shall give the signal on the night of the 23rd, if the date is favourable."

"The genius of Bach-Ma will tell me," declares the sorcerer.

Bach-Ma, the White Horse, is the spirit who inspired the Chinese general Cao-Bien, who, as governor of Hanoi, made of it an immense city and girdled it, in 867, with marvellous entrenchments. The Chinese, like the Annamites, venerate the pagoda of Bach-Ma, dedicated to the genius of the city, who protects Hanoi and the kingdom.

Lang-Seo penetrates into the pagoda, deep to the far end, into the square chamber where sits the statue of the genius in perfumed carved wood surrounded by four other statues. The very old and respectable bonze of the pagoda soon remits to the sorcerer grimoires which the latter deciphers: the day Ly-Nho has chosen is a favourable day, and the projected operation will succeed.

V — THE DEATH OF THE THONG-THUONG

"Water that has no slope cannot flow; troops that are not well commanded cannot conquer; it is the general who decides all."

It is not enough to have been ly-truong of a village of Ha-Dong and to hate the French to possess the hundred thousand qualities demanded of a thong-thuong. In bombarding Ly-Nho general-in-chief, the Dé Tham chose badly.

Ly-Nho had sustained a first setback on the 17th of November 1907. On that day the native garrison of Hanoi was to revolt. Ly-Nho had organised the insurrection at meetings held in a cai-nha near the citadel. Fortunately, M. de Miribel, inspector of civil services, had the suspect house watched. Despite the inertia of the Parquet and the clumsiness of the police, Miribel did not hesitate to alert General Piel, superior commander of the troops of Indochina. All cartridges were removed from the native soldiers. The rebellion miscarried.

No matter. Ly-Nho then decided that it would erupt at the moment the tirailleurs went to the camp of Tong for the annual group firing exercises. General Piel, mistrustful, sent the regiments by small groups and cartridges were distributed only on the firing range. Second failure of Ly-Nho. In a fit of black rage, the sorcerer Lang-Seo demolished with kicks the altar of the genii in the chamber of incantations and hurled at Ly-Nho's face the varied and scatological insults of the Annamite repertory.

And now, despite the certainty acquired at the pagoda of Bach-Ma, the operation planned for the 22nd of May 1908 fails miserably. At nine o'clock in the evening, the non-commissioned officers and soldiers of the conspiracy are ready. Without insignia and without visible arms, they file out of the citadel to go to meet the rebels who are to come from Son-Tay and Gia-Lam. Already the artillery brigadier Cai-Nga — the executioner will sever his head on the 6th of August — has dismantled the breeches of the cannon. All is prepared. But, among the non-commissioned officers, disputes arise. Are the troops really certain? Are the civilian assailants numerous enough? The French soldiers will resist and their strength is terrible. A *doï* of *tirailleurs* refuses to march. The date is bad, he says, and they must wait for the fifth month to act. Incapable of imposing his will, the general-in-chief Ly-Nho renounces giving the signal... And, soon, on the road to Son-Tay, a glow of fire bursts forth. The hundred insurgents come from that province signal their retreat and their disappointment by burning a *cai-nha*.

This is too much! The sorcerer Lang-Seo prophesied success. They must, at any cost, succeed. And the diviner convokes the conspirators anew at his house in the Rue des Voiles.

That evening the assembly is complete. Doi-Ho has come from the Yen-Thé and, with him, Xuan, the Chinese chief.

Straightway Ly-Nho takes the offensive.

"O Lang-Seo, I had confidence in you. In the pagoda, you affirmed that the day fixed for the attack was favourable and that we must succeed. Your science, this time, betrayed you, and everything miscarried."

"O great general," replies the sorcerer ironically, "Kong-Fou-Tseu has said: 'There are plants that do not come to flower; there are also those which, having flowered, bear no grain.' Such are the plants that you sow. The great Dé-Doc Tham made you general-in-chief, he remitted to you the seal, the insignia and the sabre. He judged you capable of walking in the track of heroes. But, until this day, you have been but a man whose spleen is shrunken and who has not dared to go to the end of his designs. Today you dare accuse the spirit of the temple of Bach-Ma, who spoke through my voice. The Dé Tham will judge you, and, higher than him, Prince Cuong-Dé, who, despite your incapacity, will reign over Annam."

Then Do-Dam, professor of characters and licentiate, takes the word:

"The great and venerated Lien has written: 'To find excuses, one throws the fault upon the genii. To make the kingdom strong and resist the enemy, one thing is needed: wisdom.' We seek in vain your wisdom, O Ly-Nho. And to Xuan, who has warred under the banner of the powerful Marshal Sou, I ask if he would range his troops under your direction."

"Ou-Tsé answers for me," jibes Xuan. "'A warrior without any talent for his art is a dead man. A warrior without experience is a vanquished man.'"

"I command here by the will of the Dé Tham," says Ly-Nho then. "He alone can judge my acts. From tomorrow, I shall depart for my village and await his orders. As for you, Xuan, and for all, I add this: I was not vanquished and I am not dead."

"Not yet," murmurs the sorcerer of the Rue des Voiles, while Ly-Nho departs, escorted by his friend Quach-Hop, the Dé Tham's agent in Muong country.

And the diviner resumes:

"O elder brothers, Ly-Nho is decidedly incapable. He is unworthy of the Dé Tham's confidence. We have not the power to withdraw his title of general-in-chief. He must die. The genii of the temple of Bach-Ma will see to it that he disappears. I shall now betake myself to the pagoda to invoke them."

Having allowed the assistants time to return to their homes, the sorcerer, accompanied by the elegant Co-Tai, directs himself towards the pagoda. But truly, is it so necessary to adjure the spirit of Bach-Ma? The genius knows his duty and one risks mightily irritating him by giving counsel. The sorcerer reflects. Perhaps the Dé Tham will support Ly-Nho nonetheless, and it behoves one to assuage his resentment by a well-chosen gift. He is fond of fine pastries, and there happens to be, at Number

59 of the Rue des Voiles, the shop of the Chinese Siac, who has no equal for concocting the pâté of high savour that is called gio. Without doubt Ly-Nho will be sensible to the gift of such a dish.

Having therefore bought a gio whose aroma is fragrant, the sorcerer regains his dwelling, and, the next day, at the moment Ly-Nho sets out towards his village, Co-Tai accosts him.

"O great mandarin, Lang-Seo, being ill, begs excuse for not greeting you. He charged me to tell you that his words of yesterday were inspired by evil spirits which he has now driven out. He traced for you, this night, this amulet of ten thousand powers. You shall burn it and carry the ashes upon you, which will preserve you from all dangers. And, as a sign of friendship, he implores you to accept this gio. May you regale yourself greatly upon it."

"Younger sister," replies Ly-Nho, "I thank the powerful diviner. He has understood that nothing should separate those who pursue the same designs. I return, happy, to my native village, and there I shall work for our next combat."

And Ly-Nho makes his way towards Thach-Nam, which is in Ha-Dong. Quach-Hop accompanies him. On the road, the two travellers share fraternally the delicious gio.

And both die five or six days later.

Such is the influence of the genius of the pagoda of Bach-Ma... or of a poisoned pâté.

VI — DIVISION OF LABOUR

The sorcerer of the Rue des Voiles is jubilant. He is the *thong-thuong* Lang-Seo, the general-in-chief. The Dé Tham has named him to replace Ly-Nho, suppressed so discreetly.... Good work, all in all. Having, without further delay, retrieved from the dead man the letter of command and the written powers, the sorcerer can henceforth deliver brevets, or sell them at varying prices according to the man. To the poor, the late Ly-Nho asked only five piastres. That is little for a title bearing the great seals of the Dé-Doc Tham and Prince Cuong-Dé. In Lang-Seo's hands are also the marks of recognition, which are of violet cardboard for the chiefs and of yellow satin for the subordinates, and bear, in red, the square cachet of the Court prescribing fidelity and, in black, the characters *Dich-Khai*, which signify "Against the hostile kingdom", separated by the character meaning "Approved".

And now comes the month of June, the fifth month of the Annamite calendar, the month favourable above all, the month of the rice harvest, the month during which enterprises must succeed. They must hasten.

Incessant shuttling of conspirators between Hanoi and the Yen-Thé. The Dé Tham is in liaison with the pirate chiefs of the upper Tonkinese region, with the Muongs of the Black River, with the agitators of Annam. The name of

this illiterate bandit, barely civilised, is for all a rallying sign. He distributes placards calling to revolt for the provinces of Ha-Dong, Ha-Nam and Thanh-Hoa. During a solemn session at the pagoda of Phong-Xuong, he hypnotises the guardian and asks him the date to choose for the great attack. The sleeping man dictates two verses:

The attack will succeed during the fifth month;

In the sixth month, the French will flee by the Eastern sea.

And the Dé Tham has two ceremonial sabres forged for those who will command the assault on the capital. He sends to Hanoi the red silk from which will be made the flags that will float over the captured citadel.

The hot season, the terrible Tonkinese summer, has begun. Each evening of June, around five o'clock, on the threshold of the upper Tonkinese region, the sky is streaked with bluish lightning which, leaping from the thick clouds, ceaselessly stab at Ba-Vi, the sacred three-peaked mountain whence the tigers and the genii descend upon Son-Tay and upon Hong-Hoa, and at the Tam-Dao, which seems a Fuji-Yama clad in green. Over Hanoi the heaviness increases. The thirsty city implores the wind, begs for rain. But the formidable summer downpours will not descend until July from upper Tonkin upon the delta. They will simply change the furnace into a steam-bath.

The heat is unbearable. Thirty degrees night and day, without an hour of respite. The electrical tension is at its maximum. The humidity of the air is such that sweat

never dries on the body. It is the epoch of sleepless nights, of furunculosis, of lancing prickly heat, of dysenteries, of pernicious fevers — the epoch when mortality increases amongst Europeans as amongst the natives.

Like a whip-crack, night falls upon Hanoi, the night as stifling as the day. In the French houses, fans and punkahs churn warm air. On the quais of the Red River, rickshaws come and go. Their movement gives the occupants the illusion of a fan's draught. In the cafés of the Rue Paul-Bert and the Boulevard Henri-Rivière, iced drinks — whisky-sodas, Singapore lemonade — fill the immense colonial glasses on which humidity condenses as mist. One drinks, one drinks again; it is too hot to speak, too hot to risk a gesture, too hot to return home. The sky has cleared, the constellations glitter.

The coming of the four terrible months weighs upon everyone. And yet none knows the true menace that hovers.

Nevertheless the hour approaches. The sorcerer of the Rue des Voiles receives new adepts each night. Repeated incantations, the interpretation of magical sentences, and above all the twenty-times repeated examination of chicken feet have given assurance of complete success, provided the attack takes place on the twenty-ninth day of the fifth month.

It is Do-Dam the lettered man who will command it, and Doi-Ho seconds him. Such is the order of the Dé Tham. Do-Dam has gone to fetch, from the Yen-Thé, forty

proclamations bearing the great seal. Then he has installed his headquarters in an inn of the Rue Neyret where, each evening, come ever more numerous the native non-commissioned officers and soldiers.

They have but a few steps to make, for the Rue Neyret is hard by the citadel where the troops of Hanoi are barracked — that citadel surrounded by a simple wall replacing the ramparts that French officers built in 1803 in the service of the Emperor Gia-Long, that citadel which Lieutenant de Vaisseau Francis Garnier took in 1873 and which Capitaine de Vaisseau Rivière reoccupied in 1882.

Five days before the date fixed for the attack, a solemn session takes place in the inn of the Rue Neyret. Do-Dam presides, assisted by Doi-Ho. About them are Tri-Binh and Duong-Bé, auxiliary *maréchaux-des-logis*, and Nhan, brigadier — all three of the sixth company of artillery workers: three heads that the executioner will sever seventeen days later. Here is the artillery brigadier Cai-Nga and the *tirailleur* Cai-Ton: those two will be executed in August. Finally here is Hien, the merchant of greasy water, chief of the secret syndicate of the citadel's boys, and here is the former *ly-truong* of a village of Bac-Ninh, named Chanh, who will be decapitated on the 6th of December at the same time as Do-Dam and Doi-Ho. Others are there too: some fifteen in all. All have taken the great oath of the blood by drinking a glass of rice alcohol mixed with chicken blood.

And to each is assigned his task.

At nine o'clock in the evening, on the 27th of June, Cai-Nga will fire three cannon shots to launch the attack. At that signal, the same Cai-Nga, doubled by Hien the merchant of greasy water, will assault the citadel towards the northern blockhouse. From the Pont de Papier, where Commandant Rivière perished at the head of his men, will then come those of Son-Tay with Phokhet. They will rush into the military buildings, seize arms and munitions and, aided by the native troops under the orders of Do-Dam the lettered man and Doi-Ho, will massacre the European soldiers, harness the artillery mules to the cannon and transport them to the Doumer Bridge and the Pont de Papier, so as to stop the loyal troops that might come from Son-Tay, Bac-Ninh or Haiphong.

At the same time, two hundred men with the student Dau-Xu, lying in ambush on a sandbank of the Red River facing the Concession, will pillage it from top to bottom, while Ca and Hoa — lieutenants of the Dé Tham — will sack Gia-Lam, destroy the railway station and the track, and cut the telegraph wires.

Massacre the European soldiers? Indeed. The operation seems difficult.

Pardon. The sorcerer of the Rue des Voiles, Hien the chief of the citadel boys' syndicate, Cai-Nga the artillery brigadier, the rickshaw-maker Cai-Xé, and Vinh the timber merchant will have them poisoned.

Thus is logically applied the principle of the division of labour.

At the sorcerer's house, at Hien's and at Nga's, they occupy themselves with pounding in mortars and reducing to very fine grey powder the dry seeds of datura. Then the cooks and scullions of the troops are convoked by the chief of the boys. But his house is too small. So, on the 24th of June, the rickshaw-maker receives them for the oath of secrecy and obedience. All the chiefs of the plot are there.

"Tomorrow," declares Brigadier Nga, "the poison will be ready. Meet all of you at the Botanical Garden, where we shall try it. And in three days we shall see if it kills the French."

Each evening, between five and seven o'clock, the carriages and automobiles of the Hanoians, betaking themselves to the traditional promenade of the Digue Parreau, traverse the delightful Botanical Garden. Its twenty-five hectares surround the Old Hill, which bears on its eastern flank the royal pagoda and from which one commands, on one side, the Great Lake and, on the other, the citadel. The Allée des Manguiers leads to the Hill, at whose foot there once stretched a brickworks that has been made into a charming little lake. Other harmoniously laid-out avenues run in the shade of the finest trees of Tonkin and among the lacework of bamboos and tree-ferns, and pass the aviaries, the cages of the tigers and those of the serpents, the bears' pit, the monkeys' house, the elephant's kraal and the deer park.

Hard by the deer shelter is the cai-nha of Den, the head-lamplighter of the garden.

Den is absent, but his friend Pho, a coolie gardener of the Gouvernement Général, does the honours of the lodging on the 25th of June. The visitors are many. To each, Brigadier Nga offers tea. He presents the last three cups to the gardener and to two children — fourteen and sixteen years old — helpers of the lamplighter.

"Tell me, Pho, do you not find this tea has a bizarre taste?" asks the artillery brigadier.

"It is tea from Son-Tay," replies Pho. "It is the tea my friend the lamplighter always offers me."

"It is tea that puts to sleep," says Nga then. "Look at the two children."

These already stagger, eyelids heavy, gestures limp. After a quarter of an hour they slump, legs suddenly cut from under them, flattened by a leaden sleep.

Pho, for his part, is a colossus. It would take many cups of this soporific tea to put him to sleep. But, after a moment, he turns green, seized by uncontrollable nausea. The malaise lasts about two hours, then ceases.

"That is sufficient," says then the sorcerer of the Rue des Voiles. "Give the children an infusion of banana root, and they will be cured."

Then, coldly, he orders:

"For the French soldiers, we shall put a triple dose, and from their sleep they will wake no more."

"Well enough," says the student Dau-Xu then, "but the brass-bound doctors will know, as well as you yourself, how to cure them."

"The doctors will be poisoned like the soldiers," replies the sorcerer.

Then, addressing himself to Doi-Ho, he adds:

"You may now regain the Yen-Thé and say to the Dé Tham that all is prepared. We shall act in three days. We count on him to attack the provinces of Bac-Ninh and Bac-Giang. And bear him our most humble salutation."

VII — HANOI, 27 JULY 1908

In Tonkin, minds are oppressed as bodies are oppressed when the storm threatens. The torrid summer sharpens the edginess of all. The smallest incidents seem catastrophes. The demonstration of a handful of malcontents from the Annamite provinces is baptised a rebellion. Each time in Tonkin — and it is not rare — that a few pirates steal buffaloes or pillage a market, a certain press affirms the impotence of the Protectorate, and the Annamites delight in such affirmation. Read a few local newspapers. They have poisoned the reservoirs of Saigon, they say. Haiphong has escaped by a hair's breadth from a general massacre darkly prepared. The convicts of Poulo-Condore

are in full revolt. Eighty thousand Chinese, massed in Quang-Si, are about to pour down upon Tonkin. This flight of ducks keeps the dull uneasiness alive. In Hanoi, grave events are feared. But few people know the true danger that threatens the city.

By good fortune, the superior authority has information. Hanoi is surrounded by the province of Ha-Dong, a lettered province above all, the cradle of many native functionaries, of university graduates, of mandarins with or without employment. Ha-Dong is a nursery of malcontents. Now the Resident of France at Ha-Dong, Duvillier, is one of those who know to the depths the native soul and politics. Watching very closely the movements of some of his administrés, he knows that at Hanoi their pole of attraction is a house in the Rue Neyret, where the revolt is being prepared. He knows that Do-Dam, the professor of characters, presides at the meetings. He has been able to learn the names of the principal leaders. At his insistence, a search is made. In vain. Nothing can be done without proofs. Yet Duvillier's emissaries affirm that the rebellion will erupt in the last days of June. The military authority has the arms and munitions depots watched.

An anonymous letter has revealed to General Piel, commander-in-chief of the troops of Indochina — a sad, energetic, bearded man — the names of the three non-commissioned officers of the sixth company of artillery workers: Duong-Bé, Nhan and Binh, who are to place themselves at the head of the revolted soldiers.

On the 26th, at midnight, in the kitchen of the artillery workers, these three men assemble about fifteen comrades for the oath of blood. They swear to march against the French, with the rebels who will invade the citadel. Then they return to the bunkroom, and Duong-Bé speaks to the soldiers:

"The attack is for tomorrow evening. Those on leave will be free to go out into the town. The others must hold themselves ready to obey me and to receive the rebels. Red leggings will be the rallying sign. Those who refuse will be killed during the combat or after."

Then, taking aside the four gunners employed at the mess of the French non-commissioned officers:

"Here is poison. You will mix it tomorrow evening with the food you serve."

And, as none of the men will take charge of the packet of toxic powder:

"Very well," says Duong-Bé, "you are cowards, and your heads will be the first to fall."

And we come now to Saturday, 27 June.

At half past nine in the morning, Lieutenant Delmont-Bebet, commanding the sixth company of artillery workers, receives in his office the master-workman Truong, who is capable of expressing himself in French intelligibly.

"Mon lieutenant," says the man, "this evening the pirates will attack the citadel. They will enter by the non-commissioned officers' garden. Almost all the Annamite gunners of the company will aid them, for they are terrified by the *maréchaux-des-logis* and the brigadiers who threaten to kill those who will not march. They are to seize arms and massacre the Europeans."

"How did you learn all that?" asks the officer.

Truong then recounts the nocturnal session in the bunkroom. He denounces the three non-commissioned officers, chiefs of the movement, and gives the names of seven gunners, including a deserter.

"But," says the lieutenant, "do you not fear being killed if your comrades learn that you have revealed the plot to me?"

"I am a Catholic, *mon lieutenant*, and I have been told that revolts have always been accompanied by massacres of Christians. So I thought I would risk less by telling you the truth. I have three friends, Catholics like myself, who are ready to testify. Besides, if you wish, I shall run no danger. You have only to have me put in prison by inventing a fault."

"Invent one yourself," replies Delmont-Bebet.

"Well then!" says Truong. "I accuse Brigadier Nhan of having struck me brutally at the morning roll-call."

"Is that the same Nhan whose name you gave me just now, who is one of the chiefs of the plot?"

"Yes, mon lieutenant."

Having then had the brigadier brought before him, the officer summons the gunner Truong to prove his accusation and, faced with the latter's embarrassment, has him locked up on the spot pending an enquiry.

The result being that Truong's three friends, seeing him led to the prison, lose all desire to testify. But, still fearing for their heads, they run to the curé of the Annamite parish of Hanoi and reveal the whole affair to him. Of the poisoning there is no mention. These men know nothing of the project.

While the curé goes to find the commandant of arms of Hanoi, Lieutenant Delmont-Bebet warns his superiors through the chain of command.

Thus General Piel learns, from two different sources, of the imminence of the attack and finds, among the names of suspects, those of the three non-commissioned officers indicated in the anonymous letter received some days before. He orders them arrested at the first abnormal movement.

Let us now rejoin the rebels.

In the morning Doi-Ho has returned from the Yen-Thé. He brings red pennants which are to be hoisted at the four corners of the citadel. For the rebels, here are brevets and laissez-passers. The whole lot, wrapped in a mat, is

deposited at the lamplighter's house in the Botanical Garden.

Noon. The man named Ngoc, in charge of the gunners' kitchen and nicknamed Ao-Giay — the long robe — obeying Hien the syndicate chief, goes to Brigadier Nga's to fetch the bottles and packets of poison and distributes them towards four o'clock among the various cooks, scullions and plate-boys of the citadel. In two of the kitchens, he mixes the datura powder into the food himself.

Six o'clock in the evening. Brigadier Nga designates the men who will saddle the mules and lead away the cannon. The French soldiers are at table.

Around Hanoi, the attack detachments are hidden in rice-fields, in sampans on the Red River, everywhere. The population of certain villages situated around the Great Lake is ready to pillage the town. Informed of this, the insurrection leaders have charged the thirty men under the command of Xa-Tuan, a noted bandit, to guard the Bank and the Treasury. Xa-Tuan obeys the sorceress Ba-Dong, an old friend of the Dé Tham, who has no desire at all to see the precious piastres slip into the pockets of nha-qués.

On the Digue Parreau, at the Botanical Garden, on the riverbank, the carriages and cars of the Europeans brush past, without suspecting it, the lurking bands.

Seven o'clock in the evening. Commandant Grimaud, major of the garrison, learns that more than two hundred

French soldiers of the 4th Artillery and the 9th Colonial have been poisoned.

Thus the coup de force is for this night.

The three non-commissioned officers of the workers' company, denounced that morning, are arrested instantly. Detachments of colonial infantry occupy the electric plant and the principal points of the town. Patrols criss-cross the streets.

The news of the arrests spreads at once. The bands that were holding themselves ready to attack the town and the citadel melt away. Brigadier Nga slips off prudently. The guilty cooks and scullions have left the citadel as soon as the poison was mixed with the food. The chiefs of the plot have fled or are in hiding. Almost all will be found.

The insurrection miscarries. The affair has failed.

The military doctors, hastening to the quarters, find the men staggering, legs cut from under them, faces congested, hallucinating, half mad. Hot water and massive doses of ipecac attack the malady and conquer it in two hours. Some excitement persists, nonetheless. Men climb trees; one completely naked soldier will cycle all night long around Hanoi. On the morning of the 28th, all are cured. The Annamites, though thoroughly expert in matters of poisoning, have botched their job.

VIII — FRENCH JUSTICE

What a windfall for the newspapers! This time they have an exact piece of news. They need only amplify it; and certain gazettes of Hanoi and Haiphong do not fail to do so.

By good fortune, most of the French of Hanoi keep their cool.

But there are others: a minority weak in number but excessively clamorous. It is composed chiefly of a kind of European proletariat that has survived the execution of the great public works of the Doumer programme. Their completion has also struck certain contractors who imagined no doubt that the golden age of railway, bridge and engineering construction would never end. Those contractors readily make common cause with the aforesaid proletariat.

Governor-General Beau is absent. The interim is assured by Bonhoure, lieutenant-governor of Cochinchina, an administrator of the elite, a man with a cool and solid head and a great heart. On the 28th of June, the day after the attack, he reassures the Chambers of Commerce, the notabilities of Tonkin, and the press.

Labour lost. On the 30th, one of the contractors I have spoken of and a journalist of the eternal opposition organise a meeting to demand exceptional measures. The meeting is at half past six in the evening. A dentist, a municipal councillor, presides. Violent speeches. Then the assistants mass themselves to go to the Gouvernement

Général. Two hundred and fifty persons, among them three women and five soldiers of the colonial infantry, scale the railings and penetrate the palace precincts. They stand before the perron. Bonhoure dominates the crowd with his tall stature and powerful build. "Give us arms!" "Let all suspects be executed immediately!" Such are the cries of the demonstrators.

But Bonhoure, very calm, raises his hand. Silence! They listen.

"From the very day after the attack," he says, "in agreement with the general-in-chief, the Résident Supérieur in Tonkin and the Procureur Général, I decided to divest the ordinary justice of the case and to remit the compromised natives to the Criminal Commission provided for by the decrees in force. The political nature of the offence is clear, and the repression will be prompt. The Criminal Commission began its labours yesterday. It will not yield to popular pressure. The law will not be violated, and the accused will have all legal guarantees."

And, as they murmur, Bonhoure adds, in a yet louder voice:

"Your dignity as Frenchmen demands that you remain calm; otherwise you lower yourselves in the eyes of the Annamites. Will you permit them to doubt our strength? In truth, the situation is serious, but it is not critical."

The crowd is calmed. After forty minutes everyone goes away. Some curious souls have entered the palace, which they visit without committing any damage. On the first floor, three demonstrators have entered the billiard room and, calmly, are playing a game.

On the way back, the crowd continues shouting "Arms!" The sentinels of the citadel hear "To arms!" The générale is sounded, the garrison is alerted. A frantic military telegrapher signals that a native regiment has just revolted. A false report, naturally. By eight in the evening calm has returned.

But the natives find us nervous...

From 29 June to 27 November 1908, the Criminal Commission works without let-up. Five months of investigation and patient instruction. Not all the suspects are known from the first day, and many people are in flight: the poisoner cooks and the civilian leaders of the plot. Time is needed to find them. But, from the 8th of July, the non-commissioned officers of the artillery workers' company — Binh, Duong-Bé and Nhan — are executed according to the Annamite rite, as will be decapitated on 3 August Hien the merchant of greasy water, the artillery brigadier Nga and the cook Xuan; on 29 August Lang-Seo the sorcerer of the Rue des Voiles, the rickshaw-maker Cai-Xé and the tirailleur Cai-Ton; finally, on 27 November, Do-Dam the lettered man, Vinh the timber merchant, Doi-Ho the right arm of the Dé Tham, and the professor Ong-Chanh.

Thirteen executions in all. Had Governor Bonhoure yielded to the frantic crowd, eighty-four heads would have rolled under the executioner's sabre.

But, judging without hatred and without fear, the Criminal Commission solidly underpinned its conviction. It surrounded itself with all guarantees to avoid errors. Justly hard towards the instigators of the attack, humane and indulgent towards the accessories, it applied a scale of penalties which proves that it weighed in all conscience every culpability.

It did the work of sound French justice and high equity.

The instruction, the debates, as well as the investigations and the luminous reports of the Resident of France Bosc — who replaced Duvillier, called to other functions, in the province of Ha-Dong in August — showed, clear as crystal, the role played by the Dé Tham in the whole affair.

Yet the Dé Tham is not disturbed... He keeps his prestige intact.

Provisionally.

PART FIVE

LE ĐỀ THÁM TRAQUÉ

(1909-1910)

LE DÉ THAM TRAQUÉ (1909-1910)

I — UNEASE

The Lord of the Yen-Thé begins to tremble for his skin.

The miscarriage of the Hanoi plot first muted the audacity of his partisans. Then the executioner made thirteen heads fall, and seven belonged to emissaries or friends of the Dé Tham... Others, and not the least, are in the penal colony for twenty years or for ever.

In the villages of the Yen-Thé stupefaction reigns. France has just proved her serene strength. It is henceforth unhealthy to be an accomplice of the bandits. Villages that until then trembled at the mere name of Hoang-Tham range themselves openly on our side. The prestige of the submissionary chief crumbles.

And his fear grows. He dreads being assassinated. He never sleeps two nights running in the same place. His son Ca-Trong and the beautiful Co-Ba watch over his sleep in turn. At his door mount guard night and day his most faithful companions.

In all his letters to the Delegate of Nha-Nam, he protests his fidelity: "I am old," he writes. "They had the kindness to give me a concession. I ask only to live there in peace with the aid of the French administration."

Such are the words. And here are the deeds. The Dé Tham concentrates his men around him. He recalls his lieutenants who, with their bands, pillaged and ransomed in the province of Bac-Giang and the neighbouring regions. From Phuc-Yen hasten Ca and Hoa with their fifty rifles. The elegant Ba-Bieu rallies with his acolytes. Quan-My quits the neighbourhood of Sept-Pagodes, where he has just killed the inspector of the native guard, Dubarry. The Yen-Thé again becomes a stronghold of piracy. A stronghold of which the village of Cho-Go is the redoubt and whose defences are feverishly completed. Every road, every track that leads there is flanked by posts hidden by the thick jungle and around which, during the night, circulate packs of dogs. Their barking keeps the sentinels awake. Around the redoubt rises an earthwork forming a firing-step. "Why are you building this épaulement?" the Delegate of Nha-Nam asks the Dé Tham one day. "To make it pretty," the pirate answers coldly.

Beyond the earthwork stretches a cleared glaxis surrounded by a very high and very thick pisé wall. Further yet runs a bamboo palisade over two metres high. Scaling is impossible.

And the Dé Tham guards against surprises. In each village, one of his men watches the movements of the native guard and the soldiers. Pirate patrols circulate on

every road, sometimes descending as far as Nha-Nam itself.

The master of the Yen-Thé passes the summer of 1908 in terrors. In Hanoi heads fall on 8 July, on 6 August, on 29 August. At Phu-Lang-Thuong, Maire installs himself, succeeding Quennec as Resident of France at Bac-Giang. Maire is energetic, shrewd, intelligent. Tham fears him. Yet the days pass. Calm everywhere. Come, the faithful lieutenants can go into campaign again. Doing nothing they risk growing rusty, and their men have had enough of the meagre ball of rice the Dé Tham feeds them each day, believing that stuffed men make poor warriors. All thirst for pillage. The great chief then lets Ca and his band leave, duly provisioned. They steer towards the province of Vinh-Yen. The others continue to milk the Yen-Thé, which truly can bear it no more, delivered over to the terrible tyrant that is the Dé Tham, whose pillagings and cruelties we cover so long as he makes his lieutenants commit them without acting himself. And yet the French authority is ignorant of nothing. Lacombe, the Delegate of Nha-Nam — a function infinitely delicate — uses all his diplomacy to try to set the pirate chief back on the right path and to calm conflicts. Better supported, he would do fine work, for he is one of those who know the language of the lettered and that of the people. He is, like certain very old colonists of yonder, one of those whom the people recognise and love, for the Annamite, despite his atavistic duplicity, sometimes obscurely admires certain high consciences.

But where the Dé Tham is concerned, no one dares speak. One day, however, Lacombe receives the confidences of the quan-huyen of the Yen-Thé. This emaciated old man, with his long grey beard, suddenly emerges from his impassivity. Dismounting from his horse in the middle of the bush, he begins to roll on the slope weeping. This old man, sobbing like a very small child who is hurt, says more, and more largely, than all the written reports in the world. Through the spasms of his grief, he groans: "I can bear it no more. I prefer that they kill me or drive me away, that they send me to the delta or to the Quang-Si frontier, anywhere. Here I am nothing, I am less than a dog kicked out of the way... I, the chief of the notables, am more despised than the lowest coolie of Phong-Xuong. There is but one master here, and that is the Dé Tham. Every day he makes me lose face. He mocks me, he has killed those who would obey me. Why does he not cut off my head and be done with it once and for all? I do not want to continue this miserable life. I cannot go on. The rice we harvest, the fish we catch, the beef we kill are not ours..."

Since the energetic repression of the Hanoi plot, it sometimes happens that the nha-qués dare to warn us of the passage of pirates. At Vinh-Yen, on 8 September, a detachment of linhs commanded by Principal Guard Lagarde attacks Ca's band, which holds trenches dug in a field of sugar-cane. Dislodged, the pirates flee under cover of night. But Ca is mortally wounded.

Panic in the Yen-Thé. The old men, the women, the children quit the Dé Tham's concession and scatter through the complicit villages.

Now comes autumn. By order of the great chief, his lieutenants stay quiet. He keeps an eye on them and, while remaining in constant relations with the reformists and the Chinese smugglers of the Tam-Dao and the Dong-Trieu, he protests ever more loudly his fidelity towards France.

Meanwhile, Quan-My's band, operating in the very heart of Bac-Giang, is surrounded and destroyed on 17 November in the pagoda of Lieu-Dé by the marsouins of Lieutenant Moing and the linhs of Inspector Lafferrère. Thus is avenged the death of Inspector Dubarry, killed five months before by the same Quan-My, whom the Dé Tham hastens to disavow in clamorous fashion, without any risk since he is dead, he and all his men.

And now comes winter. All is calm. Come, come! The Yen-Thé is a good fief that will remain in the hands of the Dé Tham, submissive and loyal... And his great lieutenants Ca-Trong, Ca-Rinh, Ca-Huynh, Ba-Bieu and old Ly-Thu will no doubt transform themselves into as many model farmers.

II — THE FACE LOST... AND REGAINED

Governor-General Klobukowski has decided to finish with the Dé Tham.

In great secrecy, this time well-kept, the civil and military chiefs prepare the operation. It will last eleven months. And, when after three hundred and twenty-eight days of struggles and pursuits our soldiers regain their garrisons and the militiamen their provinces, the Dé Tham will still be alive, but hunted, powerless, miserable.

The attack takes place on 29 January 1909. A date well-chosen, for it is winter — the cool, dry winter of Tonkin — and it is reckoned that all will be finished before the hot season. And since it is the end of the Tet festivities, the Annamite New Year, the people of the Yen-Thé have probably exhausted the rice reserves of the past year. That of the new harvest is not yet husked. Its transport, in case of flight into the forest, is very difficult.

A very thick book would not suffice to describe the operations. Readers curious about colonial expeditions will find the technical account in works of high interest. For the rest, it is nothing but a series of pursuits, reconnaissances, marches and counter-marches in the forest of the Yen-Thé and also at Vinh-Yen, at Phuc-Yen and on the slopes of the Tam-Dao. One acts upon information often false. One picks up the trail, one loses it, one finds it again. Guerrilla most deceptive of all and without glory. Hard existence for the French and Tonkinese soldiers and for the militia, harder still for the pirates.

I will therefore simply summarise the events as our men lived them. We shall rejoin, afterwards, the hunted band, still irreducible.

Colonel Bataille commands the column. It is a matter of encircling the Dé Tham's domain and seizing his lairs.

On the eve of the attack, an ultimatum to the king of the Yen-Thé: "Surrender your arms and munitions. Deliver up the deserters, thieves, contumacious, bandits and rebels who have found asylum in the Yen-Thé. Present yourself at Hanoi and enter finally into the common law."

No reply. Ten times already the Dé Tham has received such summons without turning a hair. It is but one more paper, a paper that scarcely moves him. Yesterday nha-qués of Phong-Xuong and Cho-Go went, as usual, to the market at Nha-Nam. All was calm. All will remain calm. It is useless to recall to Cho-Go the numerous companions who have gone to celebrate Tet in the villages where they were born.

Now, on the morning of the 29th of January, in every agglomeration of the province of Bac-Giang, a proclamation is posted on the wall of the communal house. The nha-qués, none of whom can read, gather — instinctively respectful before the poster — and wonder. Today it is not the well-known cachet, the great seal of the Dé-Doc Tham, that is affixed along the vertical columns of Chinese characters. But here is one of the oldest notables, whom a sickly pot-bellied child has gone to fetch. The old man adjusts his horn-rimmed spectacles. He reads, at first low, for himself alone, then begins to chant on the five tones of Annam:

"The Résident Supérieur in Tonkin makes known to the population the following:

"The French Government permitted Hoang-Hoa-Tham, some years ago, to make his submission on condition that he be, in the future, an honest man.

"Never has this pirate chief kept his word. His concession became the refuge of poisoners, robbers, assassins and brigands. The Government, whose generous sentiments all honest folk know, wearied of the abominable conduct of this bandit, has decided, to support the working population and to assure their tranquillity, to put an end to the present situation of the Yen-Thé, which will be placed under the ordinary régime.

"Hoang-Hoa-Tham has deceived the Government. He oppresses the people harshly. That is why, today, he and all his partisans must be driven from their lair and pursued without cease by the troops of the Protectorate.

"To succeed in quickly and completely exterminating these bandits and to restore peace and confidence to all, the Government calls for the most active support of the population.

"Mandarins of every grade, canton chiefs and sub-chiefs, notables and simple inhabitants who have suffered from the exactions of the Dé Tham's partisans, gather together and march with our troops. The Annamite country must no longer be troubled by

bands of pirates. Inform yourselves of their movements, capture the brigands who come to take refuge among you. You will thus render service to your country and you will be delivered forever from those who oppress you cruelly.

"The Government is resolved to go to the very end. All is ready. It will reward all who aid it. Deliver up the Dé Tham, who has violated every law.

"Do not believe that the Government will accept a submission from Hoang-Hoa-Tham.

"It is finished. Too many crimes have been committed. They must be punished so that the population may be tranquil and the inhabitants, delivered henceforth from all fear, become happy and rich.

"If Annamites have allowed themselves to be compromised, through fear, by working for the Dé Tham, and by accompanying his lieutenants in their expeditions through the villages they ransomed, they may, by surrendering their arms and by aiding us to capture Hoang-Hoa-Tham's partisans, redeem their faults and escape severe punishments.

"In no case shall honest folk who aid us to avenge themselves for the rapine and violence they have suffered have cause to fear the rebirth of these misfortunes. The malefactors must disappear forever.

"Mandarins of every grade, cantonal and communal authorities, old notables, and you all, honest folk, once

again, courage! Aid the Government to exterminate the pirate bands for the greatest good and the fair renown of the land of Annam.

"Let this notice be posted wherever need shall be, by the care of the mandarins and the representatives of the people.

"The 28th of January 1909, being the seventh day of the first Annamite month of the third year of Duy-Tan."

"Well," thinks the notable, having finished his reading, "well, here is astonishing news. We must simply wait and stay quiet. The Government is powerful and Ong Tham is powerful. Let us act prudently and avoid the nearest danger, whatever it may be."

The very day the proclamation is posted, the troops are at work. The secret has been so well kept that our soldiers, setting out from different points, did not know, until the moment of their arrival, their true destination. The surprise will be complete.

Alas! An inexplicable misunderstanding between the civil authority and the military authority causes the native guard to attack alone and too soon for the troops to arrive in time — the lair of Cho-Go where the Dé Tham is, and the lair of Am-Dong where his adopted sons Ca-Rinh and Ca-Huynh are. Two hundred pirates armed with modern rifles defend them. The linhs and their chiefs display

marvellous grit. But, too few to carry the pirates' positions by assault, they are forced to fall back upon Nha-Nam.

Their attack is, for the Dé Tham, a free warning, a precious notice completed by intelligence that natives of the Yen-Thé bring him. French troops are approaching, numerous. Then, at seven in the evening, the pirate chief abandons all his fortified lairs and takes to the bush with all his people.

The next day, 30 January, our soldiers occupy Cho-Go and Am-Dong. The pursuit begins through the jungle of the upper Yen-Thé.

The main body of pirates is at Rung-Tré with the Dé Tham. Attacked on 1 February, the old bandit, as is his custom, resists, kills some of our men, and flees. On the 11th, one of our detachments encounters at Dong-Dang the combined bands of Ca-Rinh, Ca-Huynh and Ly-Thu. Combat from one o'clock to six in the evening. We lose six killed and sixteen wounded. The pirates vanish. Ca-Huynh slips away on his side. The others entrench themselves at Dong-Den, kill five of our men, wound thirteen including two officers, and melt away...

It is, each time, the same disappointment. One encircles the bandits, one attacks them, and the band slips through our fingers, saved by the forest...

But each time also, one kills pirates. And our men will not weaken. The bandits are set upon as soon as they stop. They no longer have time to rest and reorganise. And they are too exhausted to think of attacking. They have neither

supplies nor direction. They wander in the forest, living on roots, on that wild banana which, eaten raw, gorges the stomach after the fashion of a diarrhoea. They lose their cartridges in the swamps, kill those who can no longer walk, and abandon the women and children who encumber their flight.

The hunt resumes.

HOANG-THAM, PIRATE

PART FIVE

LE ĐỀ THÁM TRAQUÉ (1909-1910)

THE HUNTED DÉ THAM, 1909-1910

...and with that he could breathe again. Ca-Rinh and Ba-Bieu are in flight toward Monajuong, the Dé Tham and his son Ca-Trong toward Rungphé, Ca-Huynh passes into the province of Phuc-yen.

The Yen-thé is cleansed. They organise it. Marines, legionaries, sappers and riflemen take up spade and pickaxe and build fortified posts which bar the pirates' road of return and cut off their supplies.

By order of the Resident Superior of Tonkin, a price is set on the Dé Tham's head: two thousand piastres and a

rank in the mandarinat is the prize promised to him who delivers the outlaw's corpse.

Veil your faces, O humanitarians who operate in France, snug and safe. And leave in peace those who operate in the colonies. They, they know that your utopias are not articles for export. Once his head is priced, the Dé Tham will live in fear of his own acolytes and will not dare recruit new partisans. The decision of the French authority accords with the traditions of the land of Annam. And moreover it proves to the natives that we shall go through to the end. In Tonkin, yellows and whites alike applaud. And later, the heads of the old pirate's lieutenants will be priced, like his own.

Encounter follows encounter. The blows of armed partisans, military reconnaissances, operations of the native guard are incessant and decimate the bands. That of Ca-Huỳnh is three-quarters destroyed.

In the month of April Ca-Trong was killed. The pirates fragment into small groups which make for the provinces of Vinh-yen, Phuc-yen and Bac-ninh, without the hunt stopping for a single instant. Weary of the eternal flight, twenty-six ruffians make their submission.

In the last days of April, the problem is resolved. The Yen-thé, pacified, has re-entered the common law. Forty-four pirates have been killed, fifteen are prisoners. The affair has cost us twenty-nine dead — seven of them European — and seventy-four wounded, among them five officers and twenty-four white soldiers. The Dé Tham is at

bay. He writes letter upon letter, attesting his devotion to the Protectorate.

On the first of May, the authority declares the operations concluded.

The Dé Tham hides in Phuc-yen where the native guard operates in police column. The submissions continue. Old Ly-Thu surrenders; the Dé Tham's brother-in-law, Can, and his physician Langcong surrender.

The pirate chief has decidedly lost face.

The newspapers, each day, announce his submission for the morrow.

In truth, the old boar regathers the debris of his forces. On the twenty-fourth of June he is at Phu-lo, fifteen kilometres from Hanoi. His lieutenants Ca-Rinh, Ba-Bieu, Cai-Son and Hai-Nom have rejoined him.

On the fifth of July, he captures a European.

The face is regained.

III — WITH THE PIRATE BAND

A pousse-pousse of the rice-fields, a "choléra-cart", makes its way along the grand road, two hundred and sixty-seven kilometres long, which links Hanoi to Cao-bang, through the provinces of Phuc-yen, Thai-Nguyen and Bac-kan: a fine road, passable for carriages everywhere, so fine that the occupant of the pousse-pousse is accustomed to covering it by bicycle.

But on this fifth of July 1909, the heat is too crushing, and Voisin, who is travelling from Hanoi to Backan to supervise some works, has preferred the hard jolts of the vehicle that three ragged coolies pull and push. Voisin could have taken the motor-car that makes the service from Dong-anh to Thai-Nguyen, but that costs dear, and besides, on that day, the car was taken by a traveller.

At Dong-anh station, leaving the train that had brought him from Hanoi, Voisin met a lieutenant of Tonkinese riflemen and a principal guard of the militia. Conversation. Naturally, they speak of piracy. The region is calm, says the principal guard. "No suspicious movement," announce the posts of Dong-anh, of Phu-lé and of Phu-da.

"Nonetheless," adds the principal guard, "you would do better to take an escort."

"Never in life," replies Voisin. "I need to go fast and your linhs would delay me. Besides, I have in my pocket a respect-compeller."

And he shows a big Browning bought the day before in Hanoi.

"With that, I do not fear pirates."

"I knew Monsieur Voisin at Cao-bang," the lieutenant puts in. "That was in the time when no one ventured on the roads without an armed guard. He never would take an escort."

Before the station are the pousse-pousse, numerous as always. The coolies at first press forward. But learning

that it is a matter of going to Thai-Nguyen, they refuse. It takes a quarter of an hour to recruit three.

En route. From eight in the morning the heat pounds. Not a breath of air. The road is bordered by rice-fields. Some show the green velvet of young shoots recently transplanted. Others, still full of water, reflect the white-hot sky and seem rectangles of mercury. The backs of buffaloes emerge like round reefs. Perched on the pink spines, egrets pick the vermin from the enormous beasts. In the distance rise, sole landmarks in the monotonous plain, the live hedges of bamboos masking the villages they protect from all intruders, tigers or pirates, and which are dominated by the slender watch-towers of the lookouts.

The road, deserted, powders with dust. The trotting of the coolies invites drowsiness. Look! There are only two of them now... Where has the third gone?

Mystery. Bah! They'll attend to it at the next halt.

The road crosses the village of Phu-lo.

On the long grey ribbon, Voisin's white helmet makes a spot that can be seen from very far. But who might be watching for white spots on the road?

Soon nine o'clock. The heat increases. Voisin shakes himself, opens an eye. Here is Vé-linh, a palisaded village some five hundred metres to the left. And here, much nearer, a hut of thatch, a cantonniers' shelter no doubt.

Voisin wakes fully, for two men come out of the shelter. They look armed. Yes indeed. Each carries a short-barrelled rifle. Two partisans without doubt, auxiliaries of the Phuc-yen police — or two pirates. But that is little for a good Browning. The Frenchman seizes his weapon. Besides, the two men separate. One walks northward, like the *pousse-pousse*. The other takes a dozen paces toward Voisin, then disappears behind a bank.

The trot of the coolies has slowed. And suddenly, from the shelter of the bank, twelve Annamites surge up, all armed. A volley sweeps the road. The coolies flee, belly to the ground. Barricaded behind his vehicle, Voisin makes a stand and begins to empty his Browning at the attackers. But they are too far. No shot tells. Twelve bullets. Thirteen. It is recommended to keep the last for oneself, in case of extreme urgency.

Which Voisin wisely does, and now he takes to his heels toward Dong-anh.

A fine six hundred metres flat under the burning sun. Voisin zigzags to dodge the bullets. But the pirates fire little. They run terribly fast. Some launch across the fields to cut off the fugitive's retreat. He leaves the road then, takes a rice-field dike. To right and left *nha-qués* are at work. Here the men do the last ploughing of the fifth month. Further on women busy themselves with transplanting. Despite the Frenchman's calls and the pirates' shouts, all remain as indifferent as the buffaloes harnessed to the ploughs. This affair, evidently, could not interest them.

Voisin can go no further. Little by little, the dike becomes a mire where his shoes sink. The pursuers, barefoot, gain ground and cap the unhappy man as a pack caps the boar. A turban ties his arms behind his back and, as he continues to struggle, a rifle-butt opens his right leg at the instep and another bruises his shoulder. One of the attackers has seized the Browning and, drawing cartridges from his belt, reloads both magazines. Then the group sets off toward Vé-linh.

All obey one man, dressed all in red and coiffed with a black felt hat. This is the Doï-Huan, chief of a Phuc-yen band, who has ranged himself as is fitting under the banner of the Lord Tham as soon as the latter did the province the honour of his presence. The Doï-Huan is a ferocious beast, pillager, murderer and incendiary. He hates the French to the limit of execration.

Behind Vé-linh is a grove of strong bamboos surrounding a sort of rectangular redoubt, with thick walls of rammed earth and a patrol-path.

The whole band of the Dé Tham is there. Some fifty men.

Sly faces, honeymouthed expressions, muzzles of hyenas, jaws of bulldogs blossom in laughter that reveals blackened teeth. A white! A white prisoner! This capture will force, as is customary, the French to accept the band's submission. Thus will end the abominable life of hunted game that the pirates have led for five months. And who knows whether a solid ransom will not come to sweeten

the peace reconquered? The captured man is perhaps a functionary or a colonist of importance. Besides, they will soon know.

Voisin is brought before the Dé Tham for interrogation. The pirate chief has abandoned Annamite clothing. He is dressed in khaki drill and coiffed with a black felt hat. Like his skull, his face is now shaved. Near him rests his Winchester carbine. In his cartridge-belt is thrust a Browning. Beside him stand the gentle Co-Ba, Mauser pistol at her side, and the handsome Ba-Bieu who, almost alone of all the band, has kept his silk tunic and his long hair which he so loves to spread over his shoulders — he can toss his head at a single stroke, for the great joy of Co-Ba, who adores passing her fingers softly through the abundant black fleece.

Tham interrogates. In truth, he wanted to seize a European, any European at all. Voisin states his name and qualities. He is but a modest works supervisor operating for the account of the contractor Leroy.

"Hai," says the Dé Tham then, addressing a pirate, "you will go to Hanoi and you will bring back the French newspapers that speak of the prisoner. You will rejoin me in four days. I shall see if the man has told the truth."

At that instant, five or six brigands of the Doi-Huan's band burst into the redoubt, bringing an Annamite they have just arrested on the grand road. From the fact that the man is decently dressed and carries an identity card from

Hanoi, they deduce that he is Voisin's servant. With great difficulty, the latter demonstrates that this is not so. And the captured native is about to be released, when a nha-qué arrives who, in a low voice, speaks to the Dé Tham, who addresses Voisin:

"This man tells me that a detachment of linhs of the province is advancing toward this village to surround it. If these dogs pass to the attack, you will be decapitated. Write at once to their chief. The man they took for a boy in your service will carry the letter."

Inspector Lambert of the native guard is duly warned that at the first shot fired on Vé-linh, Voisin will have his head cut off. That is the order of the Dé Tham.

The interrogation has ended. The prisoner's toilette remains to be done. They shave his moustache. They take away his shoes and replace them with Chinese slippers. They cover his helmet with khaki cloth. Finally they pass around his neck a rattan cord which descends to his wrists, bound behind his back.

And, while sentinels watch around the redoubt, the torrid hours pass slowly. Toward five o'clock in the evening, Voisin is constrained to send to the chief of the militia detachment at Phu-da an invitation to stay quiet. A woman of Vé-linh, a ba-gia with rheumy eyes eaten by ophthalmia, with empty flabby breasts hanging on her belly, a sort of skeleton surmounted by a head ravined with grimy wrinkles and coiffed like a mop, takes charge

of the message and receives a piastre from the Dé Tham for her pains.

At six o'clock, the chief makes a sign. The band gathers around him. It is the hour of the evening prayer. Disturbed in their rest, the pirates grumble. But at a menacing glance from the chief, the faces, suddenly become hateful, resume an aspect of vague indifference or lively interest in the ceremony about to unfold. Over his khaki, Tham has put a red ceremonial tunic. Before a makeshift altar where the ritual offerings are laid, he officiates. The liminary invocation to the Jade Emperor is followed by prayers to the Dragon, god of the waters, whose veins are the rivers and whose navel is at Hanoi, in the citadel. Then comes the call to the genies of the mountains, of the storm, of the soil they tread today, to the genie of the pirates who is King Lam of Tong. Finally comes the thanksgiving to Buddha who has prolonged by one day the life of all. The thanksgiving is repeated by the lieutenants who, in their heart of hearts, care very little for Buddha, then by the men who could well do without this psalmody in the open air.

In a corner are ranked the notables of Vé-linh, kept under guard. Their seizure as hostages is also a rite by which the Dé Tham obtains the aid of the villages he deigns to honour with his visit. At once into the hands of the ly-truong the great chief pours some twenty piastres, payment for the symbolic offerings to Buddha. Every evening it is the same, and the Dé Tham's acolytes consider this expense a shameful waste.

Having then settled the sum due for the food supplied to his men, the Dé Tham makes his entry into Vé-linh, at the moment when the daily storm unleashes itself which salutes with its formidable cannonade the agony of July evenings. The lightning, which no one ignores, disperses ghosts, and also blinds the militia detachments that the resident of Phuc-yen has posted at the village exits. Toward midnight, the Dé Tham, his band and his prisoner slip away and flee northward, keeping at a distance from the Thaï-Nguyen road of which one glimpses vaguely, at moments, the telegraph poles standing out as black verticals against the rain of fire of the incessant flashes.

At three o'clock in the morning, here is a pagoda where the band shelters. It is built on a height commanding a village where the pirates enter at daybreak, not without having made a great detour in order to penetrate by the north face, as if they came from the province of Thaï-Nguyen, toward which, in reality, they are heading. The Dé Tham neglects no ruse and mistrusts everything and everyone.

Yet this place is as safe as the safest. All day long there file past ly-truongs and notables from neighbouring communes come to salute the Dé Tham. They are old men full of prudence and judgment. They know how to hold the balance even between the redoubtable host of today and the police forces which tomorrow will doubtless come. But the Lord Tham is master of the hour since he has captured a European. And each of the respectable functionaries, with white and wispy goatees, with finger-

nails of immoderate length, brings the pirate chief all the useful intelligence. The bandits, who amuse themselves seeing the old men tremble, nevertheless speak to them only using all the polite formulas of the land of Annam. The "O ancestor," "O most wise," "O born before me," resound, accompanied by bows.

In the evening, the band resumes its road. The region seems calm. The sentinels who have watched all day at the tops of the tall trees surrounding the village have perceived no suspicious movement. And the emissaries have brought no alarming news.

Each night the band is on the march. It passes each day in a different lair. Sometimes it comes up against a palisade girdling a hostile village where the alarm gong resounds, while the inhabitants raise great cries and refuse to lift the heavy portcullis that closes the enclosure. The band then does not insist and pushes further. Phuc-yen is not the Yen-thé, and the Dé Tham here is not the king of the country.

Despite which, guides never fail, sent by the notables of friendly villages. Four unarmed nha-qués pilot the band through rice-field, wood and marsh. The relief of the guides occurs every six or eight kilometres very regularly, without any need for palaver. On the march, the Dé Tham demands total silence.

The country is now broken, wooded, bristling with hillocks dressed in grasses that grow to a man's height. The massif of the Tam-Dao is not far. On the eighth of

July at six in the morning, the band enters Lang-lai. Hard by the village, a thick wood hides a clearing where a fortified pagoda rises. A wide, deep, water-filled ditch surrounds it. It runs along an enceinte all of trenches, firing-steps and traverses. A communication trench links the line of defence to the leafy underwood. Pirates are on guard in the tallest trees at the wood's edge. In the pagoda, where twenty statues of Buddha in Chinese mortar are erected, holes are dug to shelter marksmen in case attackers should breach the wall.

The pagoda is, in sum, a solid lair. Tham is there, day by day, informed of the movements and the strength of the native guard by the man named Thu, who is ly-truong of Lang-lai, and by the former ly-truong Sou. Both also take charge of the post, for the pirate chief engages in negotiations with the French authority. He attempts, once again, the dodge that has until now succeeded. He asks to submit, to return to the Yen-thé. He counts on Monsignor Velasco, still Bishop of Bac-ninh, to discuss the conditions.

Busy organising a new military column, the Government lets the parleys drag.

IV — THE HUNT RESUMES

On the sixth of July, in Hanoi, the news burst like a bomb. Voisin carried off twenty kilometres from the capital! The Dé Tham is not at bay, then. His surrender is no longer a question of hours. Everything must begin again.

The Governor General orders the despatch of a column — still another — against the old pirate. Objective: to free Voisin and destroy the bands. General Geil, superior commander of the troops of Indochina, puts at the head of the troops Chef de Bataillon Chofflet, of the colonial infantry.

Chofflet is invested with full military and civil powers. He has proved himself in Madagascar. His way is the hard way. When he judges that pity would be weakness, he is without pity.

While the conversation with the Dé Tham is allowed to drag, Chofflet concentrates his troops at Phuc-yen, then directs them on Lang-laï, already invested by the native guard.

The twelfth of July is, for the Dé Tham, a fateful date. The Government's reply is clear: "Free Voisin and you shall have your life, and nothing more. A maintenance pension shall be granted, if need be, to the people of your family, who for the moment have been arrested in the Yen-thé and will be deported immediately if any harm comes to the Frenchman you hold prisoner."

At the same time, letters arrive from Nha-nam, addressed to various bandits, whose parents have been locked up and who strongly advise the recipients to submit as soon as possible. These latter will know nothing of it. Tham reads everyone's post before anyone else and burns the letters at once when he judges the measure useful. And these letters are good for burning. It is rendering the men a

service to keep their morale intact. But today, the chief's anger bursts. On his order, they bind Voisin more tightly. The pirates insult him. The tender Co-Ba puts her Mauser pistol under his nose. And Tham has barely time to raise the rifle of the red man, the Doï-Huan, who wants at all costs to shoot the Frenchman.

On the thirteenth, the black series continues. The notables Sou and Thu bring bad news. The Government demands from the Dé Tham an immediate reply. And, graver still, the French troops have encircled Lang-laï. They will attack at the following dawn.

Now, that very evening, the Dragon master of the waters and the genie of the thunder, bent by the old pirate's invocation, unleash a storm among storms, more violent than the most violent. Rain of fire and waterspouts block the view at two metres for every eye, save those of the hunted pirates.

And when, on the fourteenth of July, at dawn, under the cleaned sky and in the warm mist rising from the ground, Chofflet launches the attack, the pagoda is empty. The people of Lang-laï manifest, at the entry of our troops, a joy too marked ever to be the joy of Annam... The ly-truong Thu makes grand salaams and offers the gifts of welcome. He affirms he has had no contact with the pirates. The former ly-truong Sou, for his part, entered the pagoda. The bandits kept him as hostage and pushed audacity so far as to bind him at the moment of flight. Happily, he was able to free himself from his bonds. It all stinks of lies.

"But," says Chofflet, "the Dé Tham was provisioned by the village and you, both of you, made the necessary purchases."

"Was it the Dé Tham? O great mandarin, how could we know? The Dé Tham is in the Yen-thé..."

Fists joined and frantically agitated before their faces, the two notables multiply their bows.

Five minutes later, they are, both of them, shot on the spot.

Burn the village? Impossible. It lies on the concession of a French colonist.

V — THE BOAR IN FLIGHT

The Dé Tham is in flight, but, like a boar, he will deal some fierce thrusts.

The tropical storm unleashes itself. The rain batters the roads, the rice-fields and the woods, powerful and as if poured from an inexhaustible reservoir, opened wide forever. It seems it must exterminate under its bludgeoning blows or drown under its flood all the exasperating insects, which nonetheless will surge forth more numerous and more avid as soon as the deluge ceases. Under the bombardment of the lightning, accompanied by the drumming of the downpour, the pirates make their way. Two hundred metres ahead march six men as scouts. Then comes the main body of the band, Dé Tham at the head,

Co-Ba and Ba-Bieu near him. The chief carries on him only his arms and cartridges; all the others transport in haversacks, slung crosswise, their baggage and, turn and turn about, food and reserve ammunition. Only three coolies march with the bandits. One, a former soldier of the artillery workers' company, is the Dé Tham's bearer. The other two are loaded with French and Annamite picks, indispensable accessories for pirates sent out for intelligence who must then take on the look of harmless *nha-qués*.

In the centre of the group marches Voisin, arms bound, held on a leash by the pirate Haï, Co-Ba's protégé, former boy of a colonial adjutant and, as such, speaking French. The pirate Khaï also watches the prisoner. Both declare, in low voices, that they have had enough of their present existence. But both tremble before the Dé Tham.

In its hasty departure from Lang-laï, the band has not had time to take guides. Three times in the night it loses its way, deceived by tracks that lead the vanguard, through copses, up to great pools bordered by grasses taller than a man and which, surely, serve as watering-points for the beasts whose pads have traced the deceptive paths. Sometimes, in the darkness thickened by the rain, the flank guards separate from the main body. The Dé Tham stops then and sounds the croaking of the frog, which he repeats until everyone has rallied. They confer then and set off again. Discipline is as tight as in the best troops.

The trek lasts the whole night of the thirteenth to the fourteenth of July and continues through the warm mist of

the morning. At eleven o'clock, here is a hamlet of four or five poor cai-nhas. It belongs to the concession of the French colonist Bellan. As it is important to keep secret the passage of the band, the Dé Tham, who has used Voisin's waterproof all night, gives it back to him in order to hide the cord that binds the Frenchman's neck and wrists. To the nha-qués who come running, he explains:

"This is Ong Bellan inspecting his concession. He does not know Annamite. And, as he fears pirates, he has had himself accompanied by a troop of partisans of which I am the chief. He orders you to bring, for us all, everything needed to eat. I shall pay the price."

The natives obey. But during the meal, Voisin, whose one arm is untied, manages to make the coat slip. The cord appears that encircles his neck. The nha-qués understand and, without a word, one by one they flee. In a few instants the hamlet is deserted.

With half his band, the Dé Tham then climbs to the summit of a hillock of three hundred metres that commands the country. At every view appears the embankment of the railway line. Nearer runs the road that links Phu-lo to Phuc-yen. Two large villages are in sight and the chief chooses the one that will shelter his men. The band approaches it, but, this time again, the alarm tam-tam resounds. Nothing doing. The pirates resume their road.

Exhausted, suffering from the wounds left by the rifle-butt blows he received, Voisin advances with great pain. His knees are swollen fit to burst. From ten o'clock in the

evening, he cannot cover more than a kilometre without being forced to stop. The bandits copiously abuse him. But the precious hostage must be allowed to catch his breath a little.

At three o'clock in the morning, the sixteenth of July, the Dé Tham finally finds a village that consents to receive him. Rest for all, save for the sentinels who are relieved every three hours. The Dé Tham sleeps. No one must disturb his slumber, not even Ca-Rinh, who, dressed in khaki and coiffed with a black felt hat, arrives with his partisans toward four o'clock and will wait twelve hours before daring to disturb the great chief.

Reinforced by the fifty or so brigands that Ca-Rinh brings, the pirate troop is at full strength. With stupor, Voisin contemplates the rag-tag of well-armed bandits, ready for anything, sturdy and healthy, for the sick and the lame are left in complicit villages, where one easily finds ten volunteers for a single available rifle.

Voisin has counted: twelve Lebel rifles, fifteen Lebel carbines, about a dozen magazine carbines of a new model, about a dozen Winchesters, a dozen Mauser pistols, two Brownings, four service revolvers, about twenty Gras rifles in good condition, others sawn-off and without foresight. A few rifles whose barrels have burst have been re-soldered with copper.

Depots of ammunition are also found there. Tham has them bought in Hanoi, from Chinese merchants. Women

transport the cartridges in baskets hidden under vegetables.

Two days' halt, then the wandering resumes. Night marches under the terrible downpour. Rest by day. The band passes into the province of Thai-Nguyen only to return to that of Phuc-yen. Each evening, Tham invokes Buddha. In the night of the twenty-first of July, the pirates cross the Song Calo by sampan and establish themselves at Xuan-lai, where the welcome is cordial.

Yet the Dé Tham fears a surprise. He has just learned that the day before, the band of Hai-Nom, a Phuc-yen pirate chief, was destroyed by Lieutenant Bouffé at the head of a platoon of the Foreign Legion. Hai-Nom was killed. Order to all to keep arms slung even during rest.

VI — AT XUAN-LAI

Commandant Chofflet presses forward. By a proclamation posted everywhere, he declares that the tablets of the genies will be broken in every village where the pirates have found refuge. In one week, sixteen natives are shot in Phuc-yen: informers, scouts or emissaries of the Dé Tham, or, quite simply, pirates disguised as nha-qués. The notables begin to believe that, decidedly, the French fist is stronger than that of the Lord Tham. At a stroke, many Annamites second us and inform us. And many villages refuse to open their gates to the wandering band. Moreover, Chofflet has had all the agglomerations with their inextricable alleys cut by two wide avenues in a

cross. And the bamboo hedges of the suspect villages have been razed.

Let us rejoin the Dé Tham at Xuan-laï. The square enceinte is made of a bamboo palisade intact and impenetrable. Inside are a few brick houses and thatch huts which the pirate chief has burned from dawn on the twenty-second of July, to clear the view. Xuan-laï possesses a pagoda and a Catholic church. The Song Calo flows at some distance east of the village.

On the twenty-second of July, Principal Guard Martineau, warned of the presence of a pirate party at Xuan-laï, heads toward that point with a small group of militiamen. At the approaches to the position, a volley of fire greets him and kills four linhs. A nha-qué runs up: "It is Ong Tham who is there, with his band and that of Ca-Rinh." Nothing to be attempted for the moment. The militiamen fall back and await reinforcements.

They are on their way. At daybreak, Captain Saillens of the colonial artillery has seen, from the post where his guns were cantoned, the flames and smoke of the fire lit by the Dé Tham. He marches to the fire and warns Chofflet, who at once despatches the company of marines of Captain Perthuis and the company of riflemen of Captain Chastelier.

They must move fast and our men have great difficulty advancing on the gluey road that skirts the Song Calo, whose muddy waters cast a sinister reflection in the sad light of early morning.

The riflemen march in single file on a narrow rice-field dike. All are silent. Sometimes one hears the clink of a bayonet striking a mess-tin, sometimes the soft noise of a man falling who has slipped in the mud. The others then seek more carefully the place to set their bare feet.

The marines follow a road that the tall grasses have invaded. It crosses a wood of latanier palms with bluish trunks. Not a nha-qué in the countryside. The rice-fields are dead, the plantations ruined. The villages one glimpses to right and left are mute and as if deserted. This is the country of fear. Ca-Rinh has scoured it with his band, and now Chofflet makes a salutary terror reign there.

Hourly halt in one of the rare villages the road crosses. The nha-qués come running, curious. Here are the French, that troop of tall, big and heavy men, agitated and noisy, ceaselessly in the act of ordering something, those people whose apparent anger hides a soul always ready to swallow the coarsest lies when those lies appeal to pity, that virtue unknown in the land of Annam — the French, with their ready kick and their open purse. They say these French are going to rid the country of pirates and that one must reveal to them the place where the Lord Tham lies. In reality they will say nothing. The fear of terrible reprisals seals mouths threefold. For it is always the same: the French arrive with soldiers in number, they say even that today they have brought cannon; they attack the bands, they kill some pirates, but the others flee with their chiefs, their invulnerable chiefs, to return afterwards terrible and unleashed, when the troops have gone and

only a few rare militiamen occupy the region. A very old and very wise mandarin who has lived in Hanoi affirms that over there, in France, the assembly of notables, hundreds of men who talk much and are all-powerful, has refused to send to the land of Annam enough soldiers to finish forever with the bandits. Thus prudence commands silence.

Now the ly-truong advances, humble and eager. On a tray he offers the colonial captain bananas and eggs, the ritual gifts of welcome. But when the officer questions him about the Dé Tham, the man's smile fades. He seems bewildered. He does not understand. How would he know? And the notables who have come make chorus: "Pirates? O great three-stripe mandarin, we have not seen pirates for many days. How would they dare to come now that the French soldiers are in the region?" The eyes lie, and the trembling of the goatee reveals the lie despite a remnant of fixed smile. That ly-truong would do well to flee as fast as possible if he wants to avoid the dozen bullets that Chofflet destines for him if it is proved that the pirates have passed this way.

The sun is high now and the heat intolerable. It falls from the sky and rises from the ground. A French sergeant collapses, knocked out by the "coup de bambou." He will die in a few hours. The steel of the weapons burns the hands. Throats are dry. Over the plain, the air is at boiling point. The column heads toward the smoke, more and more tenuous, rising in the distance and indicating Xuan-lai.

At noon, our men are at the work-site. The village is encircled. The attack is unleashed under the atrocious bombardment of the sun's rays. The native guard affirms that the Dé Tham is there. We shall see.

Marines, riflemen and militiamen are deployed and shelter as best they can, ready to give the assault. Our volleys search the palisade. The pirates, invisible as always, reply, aim at whoever shows himself. But it is no longer the nourished fire of old. They are economising their ammunition.

The Dé Tham has taken post in a trench behind the church. Voisin is near him, still bound and guarded by two men. Tham sometimes leaves his shelter, goes from one fighter to another, gives orders and advice, but without firing a single shot himself.

Our officers have quickly understood that an attempt at assault — more than two hundred metres to cover across a bare muddy zone — would result in a useless massacre. They must give the floor to the cannon. The church and the pagoda, glimpsed above the bamboo hedge, are good aiming-points. The artillery opens fire. Slowly, patiently, shrapnel and percussion shells fall on Xuan-laï. Tham then rallies all his men in an old, deep ditch dug in the south-east angle of the village. And, as all our shots fall too long, the pirates do not lose a man.

As is his custom, the Dé Tham awaits the night and the nightly storm to escape. But he fears that our shells may finally breach the palisade. He knows that then, even at

the price of heavy losses, the French would not hesitate to give the assault — the irresistible assault of the colonial troops. He must gain time. During a pause in the firing, Voisin's voice rings out: "Cease fire. The Dé Tham is going to surrender."

And we cease fire. Three times the stratagem succeeds. No matter. The reinforcements that Chofflet sends from Da-phuc will arrive on the twenty-third at dawn and they will attack thoroughly. And night falls.

Our troops encircle Xuan-lai. They watch especially the south palisade, where the gate is.

Some six hundred metres from the north palisade runs a fairly high rice-field dike. A Tonkinese rifleman stands sentry there. Moreover, this whole zone is lit by the flames leaping from a pagoda which the marines have just set ablaze. No chance for the band to slip away that way.

Yet it is from this side that the Dé Tham has decided to escape. At his order, the fusillade redoubles. The pirates fire at random to make noise. Our men shoot back by guess. The night resounds with the whip-crack of the Lebel's, the muffled and grave detonation of the Gras rifles, the bizarre sound of modern weapons loaded with Chinese powder and primed with hunting caps. Hard by the burning pagoda, a clump of bamboos catches fire and the dry bursting of the stems crackles louder than the fusillade. The noise of the sharp cutlasses attacking the north palisade is covered by the uproar. Soon the breach is practicable.

Across a fallow rice-field, some pirates, Ba-Bieu at the head, run northward, flattening themselves on the muddy ground when the burning pagoda throws too clear a light. Here they are at the dike. Ba-Bieu hails the Tonkinese sentry.

"O dog who fights against your brothers, we come to their aid with two hundred rifles. Get yourself out of here without raising the alarm. If you do not obey, I shall make you prisoner and tomorrow Ong Tham will apply to you the slow-death torture. Rejoin your men and tell the *doi* of your section that the *linhs* of the native guard occupy the dike."

Trembling, the poor rifleman vanishes. Little by little, the pirates rally on the dike and, posted upon it, open fire against Xuan-lai, now evacuated, just as if they were part of the troops sent to reduce the village.

But one cannot blaze away all night. They must make good their escape while deceiving the vigilance of the French and Tonkinese watchers with whom the ground is sown. But, this time again, fate is complicit with the pirates. Beyond the dike stretches a wide, deep pool. In groups of eight or ten, the pirates throw themselves into it and, sometimes walking on the muddy bottom, sometimes swimming, cross it unseen. Two pirates support Voisin, still bound.

And then the nightly storm bursts. The Dé Tham and his band are saved again.

Rest on the twenty-third in a village. Voisin is at the end of his strength. For three days, a bout of fever has laid him low. Tham gives him Annamite medicines which, naturally, aggravate the ill. And, as on the twenty-fourth of July the pirates are about to set out again, the Frenchman declares to the Dé Tham:

"You may kill me if you wish, but if you intend to march during the night, I shall not follow you. I have no more strength."

"Kill him, O most wise," murmurs the suave Co-Ba, holding out her automatic pistol to the great chief.

"Be quiet, younger sister," replies Tham.

Then, addressing Voisin:

"If I gave you your freedom, could you walk?"

"If you released me," replies the prisoner, "I would lie down on the ground and await rescue or death."

"He will follow nonetheless," says Ca-Rinh then, "and without fatigue."

And the terrible lieutenant, human for once, has bamboos cut from which a stretcher is made. Coolies from the village will carry the Frenchman.

Tham has reflected long. Every night that will come will be a night of desperate flight, for the French troop is on his heels. He feels it coming. He will not give in. But by keeping Voisin, he risks seeing him perish from exhaustion and fever. Then —

Then, without doubt, the French would not hesitate to have the women and children arrested in the Yen-thé judged by the native tribunal. The Annamite law is harsh for the close kin of pirates. No decree of the Protectorate has abrogated it, and it is out of humanity that France has never applied it to this day. But Tham has exhausted our patience. Judged by the mandarins, the hostages would be sent to the *bagne* of Poulo-Condore. That must at all costs be prevented.

At the moment of departure, the Dé Tham approaches Voisin and, slipping a letter into his pocket:

"Tonight, I shall set you free. You will give this letter to the French mandarins, you will tell them that I have always treated you well. Do not forget that all your words will be reported to me and that I shall always know how to find you wherever you go."

And the band sets off. Exhausted by fever, Voisin is half dead. It seems to him that they cross swamps, that they cross the grand road where he was captured. The moon at its setting shows him that the pirates are marching westward. The hours drag heavily. The feverish man vaguely feels his wrists untied. Insensible to the squalls that lash him, he finally falls into a sleep cut by atrocious nightmares.

Toward one in the morning, a terrible shock wakes him. He finds himself lying, in impenetrable darkness, on beaten earth. The Dé Tham having ordered the bearers to deposit Voisin in a peasant's *cai-nha*, they entered and

simply capsized the stretcher, emptying Voisin as they would have emptied water from a bucket. Then they left, without a word.

In the dark, the inhabitant of the cai-nha strikes a match to see. Voisin questions him: "Where am I? How did I come in? Where are the pirates?" Without deigning to answer, the nha-qué makes his two children, who were sleeping on a camp bed in a corner, get up. Voisin hoists himself painfully into their place and falls back into his torpor.

A lancinating sting in the ear makes him suddenly start. He brings his hand to it and feels, under his fingers, an enormous centipede. The pain and the disgust wake him completely. The fever makes his arteries beat. His ears ring so loud he thinks he hears a gong resounding in the vicinity. He listens more carefully. The rhythm of the sounds is not that of the heartbeats. It is indeed a gong, it is the watch tam-tam of a friendly post. Voisin gets up, leaves the cai-nha, drags himself toward the sound. At half past three in the morning, he is before the post of Kim-anh, occupied by partisans armed by the resident of Phuc-yen.

Voisin is saved.

Toward six o'clock, a nha-qué, breathless and pale with terror, rushes into the post. "I have just come from Hien-luong," he says. "The pirates have just entered there. They are burning everything."

VII — LAST COMBATS

On the twenty-fifth of July, Commandant Chofflet attacks Hien-luong, terribly fortified. Two bloody assaults. Disappointing result and heavy losses. Thirteen dead on our side — among them Captain Perthuis of the colonial infantry — and twenty wounded, all European save one militia caï hit by a bullet while carrying off the body of a French soldier.

For one must, above all, carry off the dead, white or yellow. Otherwise their heads, cut off by the bandits, would serve as trophies to affirm the Dé Tham's power.

In the night, according to the immutable rite, the pirates slip between our fingers. Our troops are on their heels. Here they are at Ninh-bac on the twenty-sixth. Shall we have them this time? Not yet. Five riflemen perish. But the band loses nine men: six dead and three prisoners.

In that harsh summer of 1909, the heat and the fever decimate our columns. They must be spared.

The Governor General decides then to act according to the Annamite legislation. He names a Kham-saï. And this Kham-saï is Lé-Hoan, then Tong-doc of the province of Haï-duong — Lé-Hoan, whom we have seen operating at Bac-ninh and whose hatred for the Dé Tham has not slackened.

On the thirtieth of July, at Phuc-yen, in the presence of the Resident Superior de Miribel and General Geil, Lé-Hoan is enthroned in great pomp. The general reviews the

four hundred partisans that the mandarin will command. The Kham-saï receives the brevet bearing the great seal of the Emperor of Annam. This is in conformity with the treaties and with the tradition in force in Tonkin regarding the attribution of ranks and honorary titles. The Kham-saï is "the king's envoy." The intervention of the sovereign in this matter places the Dé Tham and his partisans beyond the pale of the empire, enemies of public order. It obliges the inhabitants to refuse all succour to the pirates, to give chase to them over the whole extent of Annamite territory.

The four hundred partisans of the Kham-saï are to make contact with the pirates and hold it until the arrival of our troops.

Encounter on the thirteenth of August at Bach-da between the Dé Tham's band and a group of Chofflet's column, which loses one killed and three wounded, among them Sub-Lieutenant Braun of the colonial infantry. The extract that follows, from a letter of this young officer to a comrade, gives the affair its most vivid aspect:

"First, I scarcely deserve congratulations. I did my duty and that is all. You would have done absolutely the same. I had luck, that is a fact — a double luck: that of being the first to attack a strongly entrenched pirate position, and that which permits me to write you today, for I have seen the Great Reaper very close. I am more fanatical than ever, naturally, and I have had rare sensations. I lived for five weeks — from the eighth of July to the thirteenth of August only — when I was in column.

"I had the exquisite impression of commanding a convoy, sole European with five riflemen, crossing at night a region infested with pirates, on frightful roads, with a hundred coolies. Fatigues that, in normal times, would make you stay by the side of the road, but that do not appear under nervous excitement. It is true that, all spirit of arms aside, our men are marvellous, having nothing in common with the mediocre subjects we have in France — whose number has much diminished in the past two or three years that engagements have been terminable. Here, nothing but sturdy old gaillards: an impression of unimaginable strength.

"Example. One day, at five in the evening, while the men were eating, we receive the order to leave. A quarter-hour later, the company was formed on the road in march order.

"We set out. At seven o'clock, sound of a lively fusillade, machine-guns, artillery — a real concert. At ten o'clock, we leave the road to go onto gluey, wet dikes where the foot slips. It is pitch dark. At eleven o'clock, we arrive on our position to prevent the pirates from scarpering. Forward combat posts, the men two paces behind a dike, bayonets fixed; a sentry five paces ahead, you cannot see him. It begins to rain — not the least shelter; we remain thus standing, searching the darkness. The cold rain falls, falls always — not a groundsheet, nothing. The men's teeth

chatter. At five in the morning, day begins to break, very grey. It has not stopped raining.

"At seven o'clock, we learn that the pirates have scarpered, as chance would have it, on the side watched by the militiamen.

"Rest in a pagoda. We make big fires to dry ourselves a little. The men have some bread that has been soaked all night. At eight o'clock, we set off again. It has stopped raining; the weather clears. Long march on ever muddier dikes. At eleven o'clock, it begins to get hot. We make a halt of one hour. Nothing to eat, save a remnant of jam that the captain finds in one of his holsters and that we swallow with wet bread.

"At noon, we set off again under a torrid heat: forty degrees in the shade — and at five o'clock we return to cantonment, absolutely grilled, hanging our tongues a little, nothing in the belly. The next day at sick parade, no sick men. It is true that each man had absorbed fifty centigrams of quinine before departure.

"There are days that count, and men to whom you will not deny a certain value. And we had not even taken part in the combat; the company that marched that day was much closer than we were.

"What you read in the *France Militaire* is, it seems, exact, and does not surprise me. I have not seen it myself. The story of the types hidden in the pools and breathing through bamboos was noted by Gallieni and

Voyron when they operated against the Dé Tham some ten years ago.

"But I am not surprised by it, and I will give you the example of Bach-da where I was wounded.

"Picture a green island in the middle of the rice-field, surrounded by a bank two metres to two and a half high and crowned by a bamboo hedge that makes it impenetrable except for the gates, which are solidly barricaded. Behind, twenty to thirty metres back, a second similar hedge. Between the two hedges, pools, then an inextricable tangle of houses with mud walls, sometimes of stone covered with thatch, and everywhere, here and there, pools, walls without any order. One cannot see more than seven or eight metres ahead. Those are the positions that must be attacked.

"Well! That village of Bach-da was surrounded — a post of eight or ten men before each gate at seven or eight metres, no more. Those posts linked by support posts lying behind a rice-field bank. Men all around the village.

"Twice the pirates tried to scarper; each time they had to go back into the village carrying their dead. In the morning we entered Bach-da. Not a rifle-shot, nothing, not a soul. A whole company searched for two hours: everywhere, thrusting bamboos into doubtful spots, men stabbing their bayonets to right and left. Nothing, nothing, nothing. Had they saved themselves, or had they hidden? We stayed in the village from six in the

morning until noon without finding anything. After that, the bamboo story does not seem to me improbable. Besides, these pirates are never very numerous, hence their ease in escaping. In general, twenty rifles for forty men; the others have cutlasses and hammocks to carry the wounded.

"It is in approaching such a wood-edge and seeking to make a breach that I received at twenty-five metres two shots from a popgun that passed through my thigh. I kept my head and, lying in the mud and water of the rice-field, I continued to command fire while a squad of riflemen cleared a gate obstructed by thorny bamboos. I had unforgettable sensations then. Each time I raised my head from behind the bank, a bullet whistled and lodged near me. It is true I was the only one with a helmet. Finally, after a good while spent in that mud and water, I was able to use the crawl and gain a few metres. Then comes the delicious moment when one says to oneself: 'Look out, I am going to stand up — the man or men twenty metres from there are going to shoot at me.'

"I have them lay down a covering fire ahead, I hop on one foot, dragging my leg. Ping! Pang! A few bullets whistle and miss me, and it's over. It's curious. I wanted to stay a while longer, hoping to manage to penetrate the village, but my leg gave way. A man had bandaged me with my individual first-aid packet — jolly useful it was — but the captain had me evacuated. It seems I was beginning to turn greenish.

"But after all, none of that is terrible. I had a jolly command — twenty marines, forty riflemen, about twenty linh-co guards of the mandarins drilled with the militia, and finally twenty or thirty partisans of that phenomenon Lé-Hoan of whom you must have heard in the newspapers. So, eighty serious rifles, the partisans not counting — that's a pretty command for a sub-lieutenant.

"I had a jolly European sergeant, Abgrall, who was killed a month later in an affair.

"This life is marvellous and there are some of those patrols of riflemen that are stunning. They are not afraid to do eight hundred to nine hundred metres of gymnastics on the rice-field banks. It's really jolly to launch a patrol when you expect to receive prunes. A more bizarre sensation is that of a man killed two metres from you, as happened to me running along a wood-edge, a partisan before me. One stops dead! It's rather bizarre — the poor devil had been cleanly done for, a simple groan, then nothing more. The philosophers may philosophise.

"P.S. — Re-reading your letter, I see 'six hundred men against twenty pirates.' It's true. One could, evidently, carry the position. But the losses would not be in proportion to the objective. And the watchword comes from Paris: 'Above all, no casualties; Tonkin is at peace.'"

At Thuong-Ven, on the sixteenth, we mark a point. Ba-Bieu is established there with his faithful. From dawn until two in the afternoon, the native guard, the partisans of the Kham-saï and the linh-co of the Quan-an of Bac-ninh invest the village, then dislodge the pirate from his first positions. Then Chofflet arrives with two companies. The fight lasts until night and the bandits slip away. They carry off eight wounded and abandon eight corpses, among which lies that of their chief. Tied to a tree on the Hanoi-Thai-Nguyen grand road, the body of Ba-Bieu, seated legs crossed in the Buddha position, remains exposed for the greater edification of the people of Phuc-yen.

In that province, the villages tremble. The Kham-saï has a heavy hand. At the least suspicion of connivance with the bandits, he strikes the locality with an enormous fine and confiscates the property of the notables. Profit and security at once. He extends over the country the antennae of his yellow diplomacy, opens parleys with the Dé Tham's lieutenants, promises them the indulgence of the authorities, compromises them in the eyes of their chief, thus dividing the band to crumble it. Pirates submit. But Tham remains untouchable. Must it not be, say the ill-intentioned, that the Dé Tham live so that Lé-Hoan may continue to command?

Chofflet, for his part, acting by fire and sword, cannot remain long in accord with the Kham-saï, any more than with the resident of Phuc-yen. His position quickly becomes untenable. Recalled on the thirtieth of August, he

is replaced by Chef de Bataillon Bonifacy, a markworthy Annamitiser, as smitten with Tonkin as with a second fatherland, and very well acquainted with the recesses of the native soul. He brings fresh troops, for it is high time to let the two companies of the 9th Colonial, which have held the bush through the furnace and under the storms for the whole atrocious summer, catch their breath.

The Kham-saï provides intelligence and invests. Bonifacy attacks. On the sixth of September comes the assault on the village of Yen-lo. The debris of the Phuc-yen pirate bands are entrenched there in a formidable lair. Through the inextricable defences, our lads charge with the bayonet. Four killed and six wounded, among them Captain Fontaine. The enemy takes flight leaving seven corpses.

At a stroke, the last ruffians of Phuc-yen submit en masse to the Kham-saï.

The Dé Tham is still in flight. Ca-Rinh, Cai-Son and the faithful and hateful Co-Ba are with him. He has left, it is said, forty armed men. In the mountainous maze of the Nui-lang, on the left bank of the Claire River, he has installed a fort furnished with all accessory defences, visible or hidden.

Bonifacy moves to the northern exits of the massif. The Kham-saï and his men hold the southern paths that lead to the Red River.

Combat on the fifth of October, from two o'clock to seven in the evening. Our soldiers crawl, cutlass in hand,

through a dense tangle of shrubs and thorny lianas. From their trenches dug in the heart of the bush, the pirates fire and kill. But the well-directed fire of our cannon terrifies them and, more still, the extraordinary grit of our soldiers who carry, one by one, every position. By night, the fort of Nui-lang is in our hands, dearly bought by the death of seventeen combatants, among them seven Europeans. Lieutenant Gressin, twenty marines and fifteen riflemen are wounded.

The Dé Tham managed to flee, but he is discouraged. He believed himself inexpugnable in his Nui-lang lair, better fortified than all the pirate posts he has defended in his life, in the Yen-thé and elsewhere — and his lair is taken. Henceforth he will flee, without entrenching.

And then, every day is marked by defections of his companions. Wounded at Nui-lang, the famous Ca-Rinh surrenders on the twenty-fourth of October with eight bandits. Tham has taken refuge in the province of Thaï-Nguyen, where no village will receive him. Hunted, harried, having sometimes barely two hours' lead on the pack of militiamen, partisans and soldiers who pursue him, the old boar finally rebeds himself in the Yen-thé. On the twentieth of November, his lieutenant Caï-Son abandons him and surrenders with three men. Like Ca-Rinh, he obtains only his life. The Kham-saï leaves the submitters at liberty, in order to make them auxiliaries and spies. But, before them, the nha-qués take fright, and soon the prison of Hanoi shelters the former pirates, seventy-eight in all.

The Dé Tham has no longer with him but nine rifles and the irreducible Co-Ba. He holes up in the triangle Mo-trang, Cho-go, Dzinh-tep, in the inextricable forest. Our reconnaissances explore it bush by bush and capture one fine day, crouched in a thicket, Co-Ba — who was beautiful and remains enraged, but reduced to a rag of humanity by the eternal flight and privations. She is a precious lure to trap the Dé Tham.

Our men lie in ambush and here, in the night of the first to the second of December, comes the old chief seeking his third, his warrior wife. In the darkness, our fusillade kills a pirate. The others vanish. The Dé Tham, who was as if touching the fallen man, flees almost alone.

On the ninth of December 1909, the Bonifacy column is dissolved. Its chief remains in the Yen-thé, which has become an autonomous circle. On the twenty-eighth of February 1910, the military operations come to an end.

PART SIX

THE DEATH OF ĐỀ THÁM

THE DEATH OF THE DÉ THAM

I — TREMORS AND PARLEYS

The Dé Tham, still alive, has vanished.

In reality, he no longer leaves his Yen-thé forest. The days and nights of this pirate of fifty-two years are the days and nights of a hunted beast. For the native guard watches, and Administrator Bouchet is the French delegate at Nha-nam.

Bouchet speaks and writes the Annamite language like a mandarin of Hué if need be, and, if need be, expresses himself like a nha-qué of the rice-field or the forest. Bouchet was detached to the staff of Colonel Bataille during the operations of 1909. He knows the Dé Tham. Better than the notables of the Yen-thé, he knows their administrés. And, in the forest, he finds his bearings as a pirate would. It is, in truth, Bouchet who should have written this book.

So the Dé Tham has vanished. Silence has fallen on his name. Natives claim that the fatigues and sufferings of the harsh 1909 campaign have killed him. Others say he

committed suicide after the capture of his family and the disappearance of his faithful.

Nevertheless, in July 1911, the rumour runs that Tham has been sighted, roaming in the upper Yen-thé. On the twenty-first of November, he is reported at Yen-lé. The native guard hastens, surrounds him on a hill dressed with giant grasses and reeds. The old pirate's bullets kill five militiamen and wound seven. Then he vanishes.

He vanishes for four months. It is said that five men are with him: two Annamites, two Mán, and one Chinese. How does he live? Mystery. Bouchet watches every supply route. And now the peasants of the Yen-thé are with us.

On the twelfth of March 1912, a Chinese brings a letter to Nha-nam. The Dé Tham asks to submit. Bouchet acknowledges receipt, no more.

Ten days later, the village of Ngoc-cuc is attacked. A nha-qué killed, a house burned, two wealthy natives carried off. Five Chinese, it is said, did the deed. Was the Dé Tham with them? Perhaps.

The residents of Bac-giang, of Phuc-yen and of Thaï-Nguyen have patrols out on every road.

The Dé Tham seeks in vain to recruit partisans. The nha-qués of Bac-giang remain deaf to his calls. And the thieves escaped from the towns, the escapees from village prisons, the militiamen or riflemen deserters will no longer rally to his banner. They know it leads no longer to pillage and the good life of old, but to long nights of

ambush in the evil forest, to furtive struggles, to perpetual flight, with fear in the belly and the belly empty.

At the end of June, the Dé Tham writes again. He would like to surrender. He will settle wherever they wish, to live there in peace.

Albert Sarraut, Governor General of Indochina since the fifteenth of July 1911, replies: "No."

It is a question of prestige, and Sarraut is not among those who allow French prestige to be eroded. And this great proconsul knows admirably how to profit from the lessons of the past. The Dé Tham, once submitted, would not fail, under cover of an apparent loyalism, to attract the malcontents and the debris of the old hordes. All would come to him. All would say: "Ong Tham the invulnerable is still all-powerful and invincible, since the French Government has treated with him."

During the negotiations, Bouchet has exactly located, on the map of the Yen-thé, the point where the pirate is lodged. Must they attack?

"No," Sarraut replies again. He refuses to send, into the inextricable bush, the native guard — which has no artillery — to get itself killed without result by half a dozen bandits installed in a lair that Bouchet himself declares imprenable. And the Governor General will not hear of a military expedition in the height of the hot season. Always the lessons of the past.

And then, like Gallieni before him, Albert Sarraut husbands the blood of our men, European or Annamite. "Let them continue to watch him closely," he says. "That suffices for the moment."

The surveillance shows that the Dé Tham is in relations with the bandits of Quang-si and especially with the Chinese pirate Vuong-Sam, who has recruited his band from among former revolutionaries of the Celestial Empire, expelled from their country, and coolies of the Ba-lao mine, and among the feudatories of the great submitter Luong-tam-Ky.

Decidedly, they must finish it. There are, for that, other means than violence.

II — AT THE HOUSE OF LUONG-TAM-KY

Ong-Luong, the former Taïping, the former pirate, still resides at Lyn-dam, near Cho-chu. A submitter since 1890, he has nonetheless held in his hands the threads of piracy in Tonkin and many times given refuge to the hunted bands. Then, with age — he is seventy-two in this year 1912 — he has calmed down. When troops of Chinese reformists, driven from their country, flooded back into Tonkin, Luong intervened to make them lay down their arms. His fief is calm, prosperous and well administered. His vassals fear him. He does not hesitate to eliminate those who act in complicity with pirates. During the 1909 campaign, not a man of the Dé Tham found asylum with him.

It is through his intermediation that Albert Sarraut, in full accord with Destenay, Resident Superior in Tonkin, and on the suggestions of Bosc, Director of Political Affairs of the General Government, intends to bring the Dé Tham to book.

One day in December 1912, Bosc, a shrewd man, a fine diplomat, more apt than anyone to engage in the most delicate parleys, finding himself on an excursion in the middle region, stops, as if by chance, at Lyn-dam, at the home of Luong-tam-Ky.

After having, according to the custom of the Far East, exchanged views on twenty subjects far removed from the purpose of the interview, the two men approach it slowly. They speak of the piracy that still rages in the Yen-thé.

"The neighbourhood of that territory is a constant source of trouble for you," says Bosc. "The bad subjects — there are them everywhere, alas — of your concession are tempted to join the Dé Tham. Happily, you stop them in time."

"I stop them when I can," replies the old Chinese modestly. "I am very severe for that sort of thing. I try to maintain calm on my soil."

"I know it. And the Governor General knows your loyalty and your virtues. Thanks to you, the pirate chief Vuong-Sam has just submitted to the resident of Thái-Nguyen, with his men and his arms. Without your very wise influence, Vuong-Sam would have joined the Dé Tham and the region would still know

the worst misfortunes. In truth, Ong Sarraut would be happy to seize the Dé Tham to re-establish everywhere the five felicities."

"The thing is difficult," objects Luong. "So many men have died trying."

"One must use ruse," says Bosc then. "He who could capture Tham would receive twenty-five thousand piastres."

"Who would be mad enough to draw misfortune onto his head by laying hands on the Dé Tham? In truth, the people of Annam feel a hundred thousand macaques in the belly at the mere thought of approaching him. No sum could decide them to face in combat the one they say is invulnerable. They are sure to be killed before they kill. Tham is suspicious to the limit of suspicion. He would strike first, and without pity."

"It is a question neither of striking nor of killing," replies Bosc. "Only of capturing the man. He is almost alone. Only two servants accompany him. It would suffice to separate them from him."

"I have understood very well," says Luong-tam-Ky without smiling.

"And then," continues Bosc, "Tham wishes to link up with reformists from your country. He would receive, I think, those who asked to see him."

"I have understood very well," repeats Luong. "But that would be bad work..."

The old Taïping is visibly tired. One must not insist today. Slowly, Bosc extends his hand toward his teacup. The old man imitates his gesture. Which signifies, according to Celestial etiquette, that the audience has lasted long enough. And, as the Frenchman politely sees the old man out, the latter murmurs:

"My son Luong-Van-Phuc will go very soon to Hanoi and will be happy to call on you."

Bosc, too, has understood very well. He will receive Luong-Van-Phuc, who is Tri-huyen of one of the districts embraced within his father's fief.

Phuc arrives a few days later. Long palavers with Bosc. The affair arranges itself. At the end of the conversation, the Director of Political Affairs declares further:

"The Governor General does not want the Dé Tham to be killed, but that he be arrested, simply, by surprise. He wants him taken alive and, alive, shown to the people of Tonkin who claim that he can be neither captured nor reduced."

"One does not surprise the Dé Tham," objects the Chinese. "He will try to strike, to kill. He is strong and agile as a tiger."

"Then," declares Bosc, "listen well, to repeat it to those who may profit from it. French law permits striking when one is in a case of legitimate defence."

And you know as well as I that it is written in Annamite law: 'When the guilty are armed and resist those who pursue them, if those who pursue them kill them in fighting against them, they shall not be punished.'"

III — THREE CHINESE REFORMISTS

They are three former reformists, three Chinese from Quang-si. The oldest is Ky, fifty-one springs. The second is Chai, who counts thirty-seven years diversely filled. The third, Tsan, is only twenty-eight years old.

Three honest merchants: Ky and Tsan buy and sell at Cho-chu, Heaven knows what wares. Chai operates at Cho-moi.

Three well-armed merchants. Each his Lebel and his cartridge-belt. Ky adds a service revolver. Commerce is not safe in Tonkin...

Ky is all muscle and bone. Emaciated, tanned face, hollow cheeks, a glance like a knife-cut. A hare-lip exposes two yellowish incisors. He is, like his two comrades, dressed in European fashion, in worn, faded clothes. No linen. What for? On the head, a wide-brimmed black felt hat, the legacy of an ancestor to judge by its shape and colour.

Chai wears the flat Annamite turban, which masks a chimpanzee's facial angle. The over-prominent shelf of the

brows does not manage to hide the furtive eyes, bloodshot, full of ferocious cunning.

Tsan sports a black felt hat over a regular face, almost pretty, the expression of which would inspire confidence, were it not for the fixed, hard gaze of the barely slanted eyes.

Three merchants on the run from the counter, for here they are, on the tenth of January 1913, promenading in the upper Yen-thé, through the sombre vegetation that the tender green of bamboo brakes tries in vain to enliven. They travel in the region of Cho-go, avoiding the roads. Visibly Ky, the hare-lip, a man of age and experience, knows the forest. He serves as guide to his companions. From time to time, he stops, and the croaking of the frog resounds. Ten times, twenty times. Suddenly, a similar croaking answers.

"It is time to hide our arms," announces Ky.

Then, alone, he advances through the copse. But a voice hails him:

"Halt, uncle Cac-tiou. And do not move. What seek you?"

"I seek Ong Tham and I have found him, for I recognise his voice. I salute you, O born before me. I am Tsan-Tac-Ky, the man with the split lip. You saw me at Phong-xuong four years ago. I was one of Xuan's faithful. I come from Quang-si with two friends, and I

bring you the greeting of the great chief Lien who works beyond the frontier."

Silence. And suddenly from a thicket springs the Dé Tham, accompanied by two servants, his last two faithful. They are armed and surround the Chinese. Their approach was made without sound. Tham examines the stranger.

"I recognise you, uncle Cac-tiou. Tell me why Lien sends you to me."

"Lien says that with my two friends we can serve you greatly. In Quang-si, we three learned to make bombs that can be transported without danger and primed at a blow the moment one throws them. They would be, for you, precious weapons. Moreover, here is a letter from Lien."

The Dé Tham recognises the seal of the Celestial pirate. The letter was fabricated at Lyn-dam, at the home of Luong-tam-Ky, but the Chinese refrains from giving that detail.

"I shall have this missive read by my scholar," declares Tham, just as if he still had a secretary. "Where are your companions? Are they armed?"

"I shall lead you to them," replies the Chinese. "We each have a Lebel rifle and I possess a French revolver."

"Alone, I command here," declares the Dé Tham. "Let your friends present themselves, one by one and

unarmed. My servants will then go to fetch your rifles. If you have spoken true, you may stay with me to make the bombs. I want a whole supply of them."

IV — THE DEATH

The days pass. Tham changes lair constantly. Sometimes it is a cave with two exits which brambles mask hermetically. Sometimes it is an excavation covered with a roof of planks upon which earth has been piled. In two days, the devouring bush invades this roof flush with the ground, and one may walk over the lair without suspecting its existence. Sometimes, but more rarely, it is some abandoned pagoda, three-quarters eaten by the forest.

Patiently, the Chinese await the moment when the servants will leave the Dé Tham alone. A minute would suffice to leap on the old pirate and pinion him. But Tham is never left alone. His two satellites watch over him night and day. And the days pass, and the nights.

Ky seems impatient to receive from Quang-si the bomb casings, the explosive and the fuses. Tham is impassive, but hardly takes his eyes off the three gaillards.

"O Ky," he says one day abruptly, "have you not lived in the province of Thaï-Nguyen, on the lands of Ong-Luong?"

"Yes," replies the hare-lip. "All three of us resided in the concession of the Lord Luong-tam-Ky. But his

service is hard and we deserted to go to Quang-si to the chief Lien."

Suspicion! Suspicion! Three weeks pass. A native of the Yen-thé, always the same one, brings food regularly. One day, he speaks low to the Dé Tham. The three Chinese understand that he is talking about their presence, which the man finds strange. Has someone from Luong-tam-Ky's entourage spoken? Or someone from the Résidence Supérieure?

But no, the secret is total. Bouchet himself does not know that Ky, Chai and Tsan are in the Yen-thé.

All three begin to feel suspected.

February 1913. The old wolf of the Yen-thé has changed lair again. He is lodged in the heart of an inextricable thicket, quite near Dzinhtep, that village where, in 1888, the thousand pirates gathered for the great congress.

On the night when he marched, stopping suddenly on the path that leads from Cho-go to Dzinhtep, the Dé Tham declared to the Chinese:

"Here died, three months ago, the Pho-Doï who wanted to lay an ambush for me. I killed that dog with a bullet in the back... Forty days later at Luc-gioi, quite near here, I executed a notable. That one tried to have me taken three years ago. I killed him at night, in his house. He who wishes me ill does not leave my forest alive."

The unease of the three Chinese is close to terror. They live in a crude thatch hut and never sleep all at the same time. The hunters feel themselves become the hunted. Tham rests in a similar hut, on a camp bed of juxtaposed bamboos. Within reach of his hand, three rifles and two Annamite picks — those picks with which one quickly digs a marksman's shelter in the forest humus. The old pirate's two servants spend the night before the entrance of the hut, loaded rifles in hand.

Alarm on the ninth of February. That day, Ky hears the Dé Tham say to his two faithful:

"In this place, three trees bother me. Prepare to cut them down. The biggest first. Thus my view will be cleared and we shall be more at ease."

Three trees... The Chinese are three. Ky has understood. He alerts his companions. It must be now.

Night falls. The Dé Tham's two servants watch at the entrance of the chief's hut. Crouched in their own hut, without stirring, the Chinese spy on them.

A clear, dry and cool night, a night of the fine Tonkinese period, the season the Annamites call the beginning of spring.

The last night of the Dé Tham.

Five o'clock in the morning. The two servants have fallen asleep. With a gesture, without a word, Ky gives the signal. The three Chinese go out. Their steps are muffled. Three tiger-cats. Ky, the hare-lipped man, enters the

pirate's hut. Tsan and Chai follow him. All three are unarmed.

This night, Tham has smoked long. The little opium lamp vaguely lights the shaven face, the athletic body hardened by life in the deep forest — the body of steel. It also lights three rifles and a revolver, set near the tray.

Tham sleeps. Does he still possess the jade stone that renders invulnerable? And is the protection of the forest genies still upon him?

He has, in any case, kept intact his instinct of the great beast, to whom the lightest brush gives the alarm.

Did he sense or hear the approach of the Chinese? At the instant the hare-lipped man advances toward the camp bed, the pirate opens his eyes and, in the same instant, Ky absorbs a formidable blow of the fist and the Dé Tham seizes one of the rifles.

But the Chinese strikes back with the fist too, with all his force, at the right flank, then at the left flank of the bandit who, breath cut short, hesitates a second to get to his feet. One second suffices the hare-lip to seize one of the Annamite picks.

Han! Right in the ribs, on the left, near the heart.

Han! Full in the face, below the left eye.

The Dé Tham is dead.

And his two servants are dead. Having run up, rifle at the ready, to aid their master, they fell at once. With the revolver from the camp bed. Tsan or Chai aimed well.

"We must carry the corpse at once to Nha-nam, to collect the bounty," declares Tsan then.

"No," replies the hare-lipped man. "The body is too heavy..."

V — THE HEAD AND THE BODY

That morning, the tenth of February 1913, Bouchet, the French delegate at Nha-nam, studies, as every day, the reports of the post chiefs of the delegation. He interrogates the partisans who watch the Yen-thé.

He listens to the grievances of some nha-qués.

It is the usual routine, the work that has lasted for him four years. Four years of hard labour, during which it has constantly been a matter of battles, of pillagings, of cut-off heads, of ambushes. Four years that have tired his body, yellowed his complexion, undermined his liver.

Nothing new this morning. Information, carefully cross-checked, proves that the provisioning of the Dé Tham — where can he be at this minute? — comes from the village of Thuy. Bouchet will organise a close watch on that side.

But someone knocks at the office door. The militiaman on duty enters.

"Bam quan lon, three Chinese are there, three armed Chinese; they ask to speak to the delegate alone."

"Disarm them and let them in."

Enter Ky, Chai and Tsan. On a chair, the hare-lipped man, calmly, sets down a bundle. A ball wrapped in a cloth that was once khaki. He undoes the wrapping, then, still calm:

"Bam quan lon, it is the head of the Dé Tham."

Bouchet has recognised it at once. He rises, staggering, as if hallucinated. The head is there, bloodless. The drama that lasted twenty years is finished.

"Tell me everything," says Bouchet to the Chinese.

When the man has finished his story, Bouchet resumes:

"Where are the other two?"

"Bam quan lon, they remained on the spot."

"It is well. Do not leave the delegation without my order. This afternoon you will lead me to the bodies."

Bouchet then ciphers telegrams for the Resident of France at Bac-giang and for the Résidence Supérieure. Then he summons Principal Guard Richy, chief of the militia post at Nha-nam.

"Here is the head of the 'old one.' Let your men ensure its guard. If it were to disappear, the Annamites would never believe he is dead."

Richy, stupefied, asks for details, but Bouchet is already gone.

He is at the cemetery of Nha-nam. Collected, he files past the tombs of the officers, the soldiers, the militiamen who died on the field of honour in the course of twenty years of struggle.

Three hours later, Bouchet has reached the Dé Tham's last lair. But someone has preceded him. The headless corpse is open from the nape to the small of the back. They have removed the liver — the liver that will give to whoever eats it all the bravery of the old pirate. The gall too has disappeared.

"The heads," orders Bouchet, designating the corpses of the two servants.

Flanking that of the Dé Tham, these heads will be, for three days, exposed at Nha-nam. Before them, all the Yen-thé will file past — the Yen-thé which, at last, breathes. And all Tonkin will know that Hoang-Tham, pirate, is dead.

"A pyre," says the French delegate then. "And let the bodies be burned."

A Thô partisan, furious, seizes a sharpened bamboo and plunges it into the belly of the Dé Tham, belching a blasphemy. An old notable of the Yen-thé conscientiously brings wood to the pyre, murmuring: "Chet zoï... Chet zoï." Is it joy, is it sadness? Who could know?

Three days later, an old nha-qué among nha-qués presents himself at the delegation for some grievance or other. And, as Bouchet speaks to him of the dismember-

ment of the Dé Tham's body, the old man draws from his pocket a notebook bearing the name of the Samaritaine department store, opens it, extracts a little paper that contains, dry and shrivelled, the gall of him who was the king of the Yen-thé:

"Bam quan lon," he says, "take this gall. It is a sovereign remedy against asthma. Steep it in a cup of hot water, breathe deeply, and you are cured."

The next day, a very aged ba-gia, in white mourning clothes, comes to see Bouchet. It is the widow of the "old one," the former "first wife" of the Dé Tham.

"Ah!" she says. "My husband was not the most guilty. If he had not had Co-Ba, that third woman eaten by ambition, he would still be alive, my son Ca-Trong too, and we would be happy."

"He would still be alive," thinks Bouchet. "Maybe. It is better that he is dead. Tonkinese piracy died with him."

Hanoi, 1909–1910

Paris, September 1933

THE END

— *END* —